Hellfire Deconstructed

An In-Depth Study of the Bible Verses About Hell

Eitan Bar

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Contents

Epigraph

Preface

Introduction

1. The Biblical Meaning of the Word "Hell"

2. Hell—A Short Historical Overview

3. Hell in Modern Christianity

Understanding Biblical Genres

4. Hell in the Torah

5. Hell in the Prophets

6. "To be thrown into Gehenna"

7. 'Eternal' Punishment

8. The Sheep and Goats

9. Outer Darkness, Weeping and Gnashing of Teeth

10. Lazarus and the Rich Man

11. "Unquenchable Fire"

12. Aren't we "Born Again" to Avoid Hellfire?

13. "Away from me, you evildoers!"

14. "Narrow Gates" That Lead Where?

15. The "Gates of Hell"

16. Fear Whom?

17. Resurrection of Judgment

18. Hell in the Book of Acts

19. Racing for What?

20. Everlasting Destruction

21. Tartarus

22. Jude

23. The Book of Life

24. The Lake of Fire, Sulfur and Smoke

25. The Augustinian Fallacy

26. Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of God's Character

27. Why "Free Will" Can't Justify Eternal Conscious Torment

28. He Truly Sees Us—Understanding Is Love

29. God Understands Evil—and the Way It Shapes Us

30. Love, Fear, and the Conditional "If" - Why the Gospel Cannot Be Rooted in Terror

31. God Is Not a Nazi

32. Then What's the Point in Evangelizing?

33. A Word on NDEs (Near-Death Experiences)

34. Conclusion

A Final Word

Endnotes

This book is, for the most part, a synthesis of two sections from my other works: "Part III – Hell in the Bible" from ***HELL: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine***, and "Part V — Rethinking Hell" from ***The Gospel Before Christianity, A Jewish Perspective on Jesus' Atonement, Sacrifice, and Redemption*** mixed with original thoughts. Pardon any overlaps and repetitions.

Hell vs. Hellfire

The term "**Hell**" encompasses a broad doctrine with diverse interpretations, ranging from a literal place of fire to a purely symbolic metaphor and with varying views, such as a place of eternal damnation or a temporary process of purification. Therefore, I will use the term "**Hellfire**" when specifically describing the Augustinian-Calvinist depiction of a literal place of endless torture in the fire, known by theologians as the ECT (Eternal Conscious Torment) Hellfire view.

Lastly, I advise you to read the chapters sequentially rather than randomly.

Preface

Every human being wants the same thing: to feel safe. To avoid pain. To believe the world makes sense and that, in the end, it will be okay. Christianity understood this early. That's why it sold us a God who is father, protector, merciful, and full of compassion.

Then came ECT — Eternal Conscious Torment. The idea that God would sadistically keep people alive in hellfire forever just to torment them. No exit. No healing. No hope. No restoration. No end to their suffering.

The problem isn't just the cruelty. The problem is the contradiction. You cannot preach infinite mercy and enforce infinite torture in the same breath. Mercy that has an expiration date isn't mercy. It's leverage.

Take ECT out, and religion suddenly looks like what it claims to be: compassionate, restorative, humane. God suddenly looks like God.

Leave ECT in, and you get a God who offers love with a gun to your head. And people feel that. Because deep down we know the truth: you cannot have both a god who torments most of humanity forever and a God who *"reconciles to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven."* (Colossians 1:20).

Introduction

> The proper context for interpreting the Bible is not Augustine or any other church father. It is not the Catholic Church. It is not the rabbinic movements of late antiquity and the Middle Ages. It is not the Reformation or the Puritans. It is not evangelicalism in any of its flavors. It is not the modern world at all or any period of its history. The proper context for interpreting the Bible is the context of the biblical writers— the context that produced the Bible. Every other context is alien to the biblical writers and, therefore, to the Bible. Yet there is a pervasive tendency in the believing Church to filter the Bible through creeds, confessions, and denominational preferences. [1]
>
> Dr. Michael S. Heiser

As a Jewish individual, ever since I became a believer in Jesus, I've noticed significant differences in the interpretation of the biblical text between Jews and Christians. One example is the concept of hell, but there are many other examples as well, such as 'sin,' 'atonement,' 'salvation,' and 'divorce.' [2]

Numerous interpretations of the concept of *hell* have been proposed throughout the generations in most religions. Still, one particularly striking interpretation has captivated the minds of some Conservative Protestant denominations. Among them are the Baptist, Calvinist, Lutheran, Pentecostal, Evangelical, and other

fundamentalist groups holding to what is known as the Hellfire view—a place where God, directly or indirectly, punishes most of humanity, eternally tormenting billions of people through excruciating and abusive methods, which according to some depictions, include burning them in flames. These sadistic tortures allegedly would persist every minute of every day for eternity.

I have also observed that varying interpretations of biblical texts can greatly affect one's mental and emotional health. The manner in which we understand certain doctrines, especially concepts such as hell, can profoundly influence our faith-life perspective. Misinterpretations or overly strict views may result in adverse emotions and actions, such as anxiety, depression, fear, and a tendency to judge others harshly.

This is one reason why theologians who critique the "Hellfire view" often argue that it is both illogical and misrepresents God's nature as depicted in the Scriptures, emphasizing love, mercy, and corrective justice. A more compassionate and logical understanding of the doctrine of hell can possibly foster a healthier mental, emotional, and spiritual life, free from the burdens of existential fear and religious legalism.

The Modern Reader's Challenges

Modern Christianity has significantly diverged from its origins within the early Jewish movement, undergoing a two-thousand-year evolution shaped by church history and cultural shifts. This transformation started with the adaptation of the Gospel to fit the anti-Jewish sentiments of the Roman Empire and the philosophies of Greece, proceeded with its recontextualization for the converted European pagans, was further altered during the Reformation wars, and ultimately adapted to the distinct context of America's settlement. Consequently, while traces of the original Gospel remain, they are now interwoven with diverse interpretations, traditions, religious biases, erroneous translations, and cultural accretions, which many contemporary Christians might not fully acknowledge. Considering this long history of adaptation and transformation, it is conceivable that numerous obstacles to understanding Christianity from a Jewish perspective have become entrenched in its foundational beliefs.

The Bible, a collection of ancient Jewish documents, is rich with metaphors, symbolism, figures of speech, allusions, parables, and allegories. These literary devices permeate the text, posing significant challenges for those not versed in the original languages, cultures, and historical contexts. This often leads to questionable interpretations and confusion among modern readers, especially Westerners unfamiliar with the Ancient Near East, Judaism, and the Hebrew and Greek languages.

Moreover, language is dynamic; it evolves, and the meanings of many words and phrases change over time. Also, most Hebrew and Greek words have a spectrum of meanings, which context alone can clarify. Additionally, Hebrew operates on a fundamentally different linguistic structure than Germanic / Indo-European languages such as English. Its Semitic roots make it particularly resistant to full translation, as nuances and layers of meaning often elude capture. For example, Semitic languages such as Hebrew and Aramaic are unique compared to English because they primarily use root-based morphology, where most words are formed from three-consonant roots that convey core meanings. This allows for a rich and flexible derivation of related words, unlike English, which relies more on fixed prefixes and suffixes.

For instance, the "Serpent" in Genesis 3 is commonly perceived by English readers as a literal snake. Still, in Jewish tradition, it is often understood as a shining being or an angel of light who later lost his ability to fly or walk as punishment (Bereshit Rabbah 20:5). This interpretation arises from the Hebrew word "*NACHASH*," which is typically translated as "serpent" in English. However, "*Nachash*" is a three-letter Hebrew word that can also mean "copper," "shining," or "bronze," suggesting a luminescent and perhaps divine figure symbolizing the supernatural world rather than a talking reptile. Paul, a Jew, likely shared this perspective, as evident in his description of Satan as *"an angel of light"* (2 Corinthians 11:14). I provide numerous examples in another book, *"Lost in Translation"*; however, this one suffices to demonstrate that the content you read or comprehend in your English Bibles may not be exactly what I read or understand in my Hebrew Bible.

Evidently, translation choices can have far-reaching repercussions that stem partly from inaccurate Bible translations and a failure to appreciate the nuances of language, culture, and context in which pivotal figures like Moses, Jesus, and Paul delivered their teachings.

Additionally, some Semitic languages utilize patterns of vowel changes within these roots to convey grammatical nuances, making their structure markedly different from the more linear construction of English. In any event, the complexity of the biblical text requires meticulous translation decisions, which are undeniably shaped by the translators' pre-existing theological and religious views. This fact likely accounts for the existence of over 900 different translations of the Bible in English alone.[3]

I'll now share one example of what I mean by *"the translators' pre-existing theological and religious views."*

Matthew 10:29

- New American Bible:

> Are not two sparrows sold for a small coin? Yet not one of them falls to the ground without your Father's **knowledge**.
>
> Matthew 10:29, NAB

According to the NAB English translation, God knows or is aware of every sparrow's fall, implying divine knowledge rather than will.

In the original Greek, however, no specific word indicates the meaning, so many English translations interpret it as "knowing." At the same time, some, like the King James Version, translated the text as is (only from context it clear the verse speaks of God's knowledge):

> Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father.
>
> Matthew 10:29, KJV

Now, see how the NET translation, a popular translation in the US made by a Calvinist group, inserted a different word:

> Aren't two sparrows sold for a penny? Yet not one of them falls to the ground apart from your Father's **will**.
>
> Matthew 10:29, NET

Adding the word “will" into the text implies that nothing, including death, occurs without God’s explicit intent. This perfectly aligns with the Calvinist-TULIP doctrine of predestination, where everything that happens happens because God wills it, thus negating true human free will.

For me, as a Jewish reader who has lost family members in the Holocaust, this Calvinist addition is troubling. This translation doesn’t just imply that God was aware of such atrocities—it suggests that Jesus taught God actively willed them to happen! Such a portrayal risks making Jesus appear indifferent to human suffering, even endorsing evil events as divinely ordained. For Jewish readers with a history of suffering and loss, this interpretation is not only theologically revolting but also alienates them from Jesus' teachings altogether. Moreover, Free Will is a tenet doctrine in Judaism, as are God’s mercy and compassion, contrasting the depiction of God by many Calvinists.[4]

But juggling between translations is not the only challenge to the modern English reader. Another challenge is understanding the authors' original context and culture. Therefore, one of the most significant challenges and a popular fallacy in modern-day Bible interpretation is the Anachronism Fallacy. This fallacy occurs when an interpretation places ideas, theological concepts, events, customs, etc., in a historical period where they do not belong, leading to distorted conclusions. This involves projecting contemporary ideas, knowledge, or concepts onto past texts, events, or figures.[5]

For instance, the term "gay" had a completely different meaning a century ago than it does today. Reading the word in a book written a hundred years ago and applying the modern meaning would be an example of the Anachronism Fallacy. It will soon become evident that the Anachronism Fallacy is frequently employed in modern Christian teachings about the "hell" verses.

To complicate things even further, 49,000 different Christian groups[6]—holding to varying interpretations of the Bible—uphold the Bible as the ultimate expression

of God's will, each believing they—not others—have interpreted it all correctly. Can you imagine? Every denomination and group is convinced that all other groups and denominations, except their own, of course, are partially or fully mistaken. This conviction has led to violent religious conflicts throughout Christian history, including disputes over numerous theological doctrines, especially salvation, faith, and hell.

Book's Goal

The goal of this short book (as in the complete book) is to transcend more than 2,000 years of predominantly Western, non-Jewish interpretations and strive to comprehend these complex Jewish texts in a manner as close as possible to how their original —also mostly Jewish—audience would have possibly perceived them without permitting our contemporary theological biases to influence our understanding. This task involves a deep dive into historical contexts, examining how ancient words were used and understood in their original settings, and being mindful of the interpretative choices made during later translations.

I have no horse in this race other than to offer my understanding—as a Bible scholar, a follower of Jesus, and a native Hebrew-speaking Jew—of this complex and often controversial topic. Personally, as a theologian, I value the diversity of opinions and, for the most part, avoid emotionally attaching myself to any particular doctrine.[7] Therefore, you will not get conclusive "yes" and "no" answers. I will not be spoon-feeding you with answers—as though I possess all the correct knowledge—but aim to challenge preconceived notions you may have considered sacrosanct and seek to enrich you with new perspectives on a very controversial doctrine.

P.S. English is not my first language. I was born and raised in Israel, where Hebrew is my native tongue. Later, I studied Greek in seminary. I would truly appreciate your understanding if you notice any faults in my English. As an indie author I cannot always afford the editing fees.

The Biblical Meaning of the Word "Hell"

Language is never static; it evolves, and meanings shift over time. Words often drift far from their original sense. For example, *awful* once meant "full of awe" or "worthy of reverence," whereas today it means "very bad." The word *gay* once meant joyful or lighthearted; now it primarily refers to sexual orientation.

The same goes for words like "eternal" or "hell" that we come across in English translations of the Bible. Historically, *hell* referred to the realm of the dead—the grave, the underworld—not a place of everlasting torture. This view is also widely acknowledged and accepted in both Christian and secular academia.[8, 9, 10, 11, 12] It was only later, through cultural, philosophical, and theological developments, that *hell* came to be seen as an afterlife of either temporary punishment, as in Judaism and several eastern Christian denominations, or eternal conscious torment, as in Islam and in denominations shaped by Augustine of Hippo, like Protestantism and Catholicism. Understanding this linguistic shift is crucial, because reading modern meanings back into ancient texts inevitably distorts what the biblical authors were actually saying.

Where the English "Hell" Came From

The English word "hell" originates from the Old English "Hel" or "Helle," which was derived from the Proto-Germanic term "haljō."[13] This term generally referred to the underworld (the graveyard), or a mystical hidden place. "Haljō" is also related to

the Old Norse word "Hel," which referred both to the underworld—a realm of the dead—and the goddess who ruled over it in Norse mythology. In Norse belief, this underworld was where souls who did not die in battle would go.

As Christianity spread through Europe, hell was adopted and adapted within Christian theology to describe a place of punishment for the wicked, further shifting its meaning from a concept of cosmic graveyard to the more specific notion of hell as a place of punishment.

The evolution of the word *hell*:

- **Proto-Germanic:** "haljō" first referred to a concealed or hidden place and was used to describe the underworld—realm of the dead.
- - **Old Norse:** "Hel" was both the name of the underworld and the deity presiding over it.
- - - **Old English:** "hel" or "helle" referred to an afterlife place of punishment.
- - - - **Modern English:** "hell" refers to a place of punishment after death, sometimes excruciating and perpetual.

Four Words Translated "Hell"

English translations frequently employ the term "hell" as a replacement for four distinct Hebrew/Greek words: "Géenna," "Sheol," "Tartarus," and "Hades." However, these words are not interchangeable synonyms, and each carries its unique connotations and meanings. Let's see some examples.

Sheol:

> For thou wilt not leave my soul in ***hell*** *[sheol]*; neither wilt thou suffer thine Holy One to see corruption.
>
> (Psalm 16:10, KJV)

Hades:

> And death and ***hell*** *[hades]* were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death.
>
> (Revelation 20:14, KJV)

Géenna:

> And if thy right eye offend thee, pluck it out, and cast it from thee: for it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish, and not that thy whole body should be cast into ***hell*** *[Géenna]*. (Matthew 5:29, KJV)

Tartarus:

> For if God spared not the angels that sinned, but cast them down to ***hell*** *[tartarus]*, and delivered them into chains of darkness, to be reserved unto judgment.
>
> (2 Peter 2:4, KJV)

Clearly, translating these four distinct concepts as "hell" loses their original meanings. In fact, none of these terms implies a place where people are supposedly tortured by fire forever.

Sheol, Hades, Géenna, Tartarus

Sheol is a Hebrew word used in the Old Testament to describe the realm of the dead (e.g., Genesis 37:35, Job 14:13, Psalm 16:10, Ecclesiastes 9:10), often translated as "the grave" or "the pit." It is portrayed as a shadowy place where the dead are asleep,

regardless of their beliefs or moral choices during life. Sheol is not associated with punishment or reward but is simply the state of being dead and hidden from the living. [14]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

Hades is the Greek word equivalent of *Sheol*, [15] representing the underworld or the realm of the dead. In Greek mythology, Hades is both the name of the god ruling this domain and the place itself. In the New Testament, Hades similarly stands for the unseen place where souls metaphorically go after death, awaiting resurrection. Like *Sheol*, *Hades* is not inherently a place of torment or bliss but a temporary holding place for the dead. [16]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

***Géenna* (or *Gehenna*)** originates from the Hebrew word "*Gehinnom*," meaning the *Valley of Hinnom*, which is located outside Jerusalem. Historically, it was linked to the worship of Moloch, involving the sacrifice of children by fire, as well as to the city's garbage dump, where trash was continuously burned and dead bodies were disposed of. In Second Temple Judaism, the *Valley of Hinnom* became associated with shameful death and disgrace. [17] It could represent the ostracization or death of an individual, or the downfall and destruction of a city or nation.

In the New Testament, Jesus uses *Gehenna* as a symbol of disgrace and shameful death. In some Rabbinic literature, "*Gehinnom*" became associated with an afterlife disciplinary process, a destination for the wicked where they get to atone for their sins. [18]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

***Tartarus*,** in Greek mythology, is a deep abyss used to imprison the Titans far beneath Hades. It signifies the lowest part of the underworld, a jail-like place. In the New Testament, particularly in 2 Peter 2:4, Tartarus is used metaphorically to describe the gloomy, dark place where rebellious angels are held, awaiting judgment. Tartarus appears in the Septuagint translation of Job (40:20 and 41:24) and in Hellenistic Jewish literature, such as the Greek text of the ancient Book of Enoch. In Enoch, God places the archangel Uriel "*in charge of the world and of Tartarus*" (20:2), understood as the prison for 200 fallen Watchers (angels). [19]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

Clearly, none of these terms suggest a place of eternal conscious torment ("Hellfire"), and translating them all as "hell" should be reconsidered in future English

translations of the Bible. For now, the term "hell" will continue to cause confusion for readers of English translations that use it for some or all of the Hebrew and Greek concepts I described.

In the Concordant Expositions, [20] biblical scholar James Coram explains:

> The Old English "hell," denoted that which is covered (hidden or unseen). Consequently, it once served as a suitable translation of the Greek hades, which means "imperceptible" or "unseen." In modern English, however, due to the corrupting influence of human tradition, "hell" has come to mean "the abode of the dead; the place of punishment after death [in which the dead are alive]." Consequently, since in modern English the notion represented by the term "hell" constitutes, to say the least, interpretation, not translation, it is unconscionable for modern translators to render either the Hebrew sheol or the Greek hades by this expression.
>
> Yet it is worse still, whether in old English or modern English, to render the Greek tartarosas and especially the Greek geenna, also as "hell." Such "translations" are not translations at all; they are but the product of circular reasoning and hoary tradition. Whatever one's understanding may be concerning the matters to which these words make reference, as a translation of the Original, the rendering "hell," in all cases, is wholly unjustifiable. Yet it is this very rendering, the single term, "hell," for all these distinct words in the Original, which has spawned all the familiar talk concerning "hell" which prevails among "Bible-believing Christians" today.
>
> James Coram

Jesus Never Spoke of Hell—He Spoke of Gehenna

Jesus spoke more about hell than anybody else in the Bible. [21]

(John MacArthur)

John MacArthur is completely wrong. Jesus never spoke of the Augustinian–Calvinist vision of hell as Eternal Conscious Torment, so common in Western theology. He spoke of *Gehenna*—a term no first-century Jew would have understood in that way.

Gehenna (short for *Gey Ben Hinnom*—the Valley of Hinnom) was a real, physical place just outside Jerusalem. It appears repeatedly in the Hebrew Scriptures as a site associated with great shame, judgment, destruction, and death (e.g., Jeremiah 7:31–33; 19:2–7; 2 Kings 23:10). In ancient Israel, the valley served as the city's dump—a spot where trash was constantly burned, where dead animals and the bodies of the disgraced were tossed, giving worms a steady supply of food that never ends. It was also where the poorest and most marginalized searched through the refuse for scraps to survive.

Jesus described *Gehenna* as the place *"where the worms that eat them do not die, and the fire is not quenched"* (Mark 9:47-48) since the worms always had food to consume and the flames constantly burned the trash.

Thus, in the Jewish vocabulary, *Gehenna* symbolized a shameful or deadly outcome, not an afterlife torture chamber. It represented loss, exclusion, destruction, and the collapse of a meaningful life. A fate worse than honorable death—either living as an outcast (socially dead), or dead entirely.

When Jesus spoke about Gehenna (e.g., Matthew 5:22, 29–30; 10:28; Mark 9:43–48), He was drawing on a familiar Jewish image to convey real historical judgment, social breakdown, disgrace, and devastating consequences—not otherworldly torment after death.

Yeshua wasn't a 21st-century Bible Belt preacher in a suit and tie, but a first-century Prophet of Israel and Jewish rabbi living and teaching in Jewish Israel, ministering among His own people. His words were directed first and foremost at His Jewish audience in their specific context, while also prophetically calling the entire nation of Israel to repentance, justice, mercy, and faithfulness to the covenant.

Tragically, as a nation, Israel rejected that call. And within a generation, the warning became reality. In 70 AD, Jerusalem was destroyed by Rome, the Temple was burned, and according to ancient sources, over a million Jews were killed.[22] This was *eternal*

judgment in the most biblical sense—not endless, but total, decisive, and irreversible for that generation and system.

In short, Jesus' use of Gehenna was a prophetic warning about the consequences of injustice, violence, moral decay and covenant rebellion—not a blueprint for an afterlife torture chamber.

Hell—A Short Historical Overview

Talking about hell can make some Christians squirm in their chairs. Still, it may be one of the most important yet misunderstood teachings in Christian theology. A big part of the confusion comes from not taking time to study the verses often associated with hell in their original context, recognizing how metaphors get misused, spotting mistranslations of Hebrew and Greek words, or exploring alternative perspectives.

Hell in First Century Judaism

Ideas of the afterlife—whether imagined as a shadowy underworld or as a purifying fire—existed in many ancient cultures long before Christianity. These early notions were largely symbolic, primitive, and undeveloped. Even within ancient Israel, *Gehinnom* was not originally the fully formed "hell" of later Jewish theology. It developed over time, often understood as a temporary place where wrongdoing is confronted and dealt with—not as an eternal conscious torment.

Origen (185-253 AD) was an early Christian scholar, ascetic, theologian, and a prolific writer who wrote roughly 2,000 treatises. He has been described as *"the greatest genius the early church ever produced."*[23]

Origen wrote extensively about the Jewish context of the gospels and concluded:

> We find a certain confirmation of what is said regarding the place of punishment, intended for the purification of such souls as are to be purified by torments, agreeably to the saying: *"The Lord comes like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and He shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver and of gold."*
>
> Origen, Against Celsus, VI, 25.

In other words, even Jews who associated Gehenna or hell with afterlife punishment saw it as temporary rather than everlasting.

At its core, the imagery Jesus used was concrete and familiar: the refining of precious metals by fire. Scripture repeatedly draws on this metaphor. The Hebrew Bible speaks of God "refining" His people like silver and testing ("tormenting") them like gold in a furnace (Malachi 3:2–3; Zechariah 13:9; Psalm 66:10). The New Testament carries the same imagery forward: human works are tested "as through fire" (1 Corinthians 3:13–15), and trials are said to refine faith like gold (1 Peter 1:7).

In 1st-century Judaism, the metaphor of fire was associated not with eternal conscious torment, but with testing, cleansing, and purification.

According to HELPS Word-studies, the Greek word *basanizó*, often translated as "torment," can also mean "to test" or "to examine." Therefore, "tormented in fire" can be understood as "tested or refined in fire."

Jesus drew from this same vocabulary when speaking of *Gehenna*. To His original Jewish audience, fire symbolized a painful yet purposeful process—refining, reshaping, and restoring. Fire burns away dross so that what remains is clean, perfected, refined, and truly valuable. This is likely how His disciples understood it: not as never-ending sadism, but as a refining fire that ultimately serves a redemptive purpose.

Of course, some people accumulate far more "impurity" over a lifetime—hatred, cruelty, selfishness, violence. For them, the refining process may indeed be long and painful. But prolonged purification is not the same as everlasting despair. Fire was never meant to destroy the gold, only the dross—until what God always intended finally emerges in clarity and beauty.

Since God hates sin, not the sinner, He will destroy the sin, not the person.

Hell in Early Christian Schools

In the first centuries of the Church, theology was taught primarily through six major catechetical schools, and their views on hell varied significantly. These schools—much like modern seminaries—were the intellectual and spiritual centers of Christian formation in their day, each representing a distinct theological tradition rather than a single, uniform doctrine.

Alexandria: The Catechetical School of Alexandria (2nd century) was one of the most influential theological centers in early Christianity. It was known for its allegorical interpretation of Scripture and philosophical approach to theology. Alexandria's teachings, known as *"apokatastasis"* (the ultimate restoration of all things) proposed that hell served as a corrective and purifying phase, ultimately leading all souls to salvation through God's love and mercy. [24]

Antioch: The School of Antioch (3rd century) was known for its emphasis on the literal and historical interpretation of Scripture. This school also taught that hell was a temporary state designed to purify and ultimately restore all souls to God. This approach emphasized God's ultimate plan for the reconciliation and salvation of all creation. [25]

Cesarea: The theological school in Caesarea (3rd century), influenced by Origen (who first studied under Clement in Alexandria) and other prominent theologians, also believed and taught that God's judgment was not endless but rather a process through which souls would be purified and eventually restored to their original, sinless state. [26]

Eastern Syria: The Eastern Syrian school (4th century), part of the broader Syriac Christian tradition, taught that divine punishment was temporary and aimed at bringing about repentance and healing, emphasizing the compassionate nature of God. [27]

Asia Minor (Turkey): The theological school in Asia Minor (3rd century) took a different approach, teaching annihilationism. This view held that the wicked would ultimately be eliminated—cease to exist—rather than being restored or subjected to eternal torment. [28]

Hippo: The school in Hippo (late 4th–early 5th century), named after Augustine of Hippo, was located in North Western Africa and was the only one that taught eternal conscious torment. This school viewed afterlife punishment as "hellfire"—a place of never-ending torturous punishment and suffering for the unbeliever. It emphasized the severity of sin over God's grace and what was believed to be the absolute and punitive nature of divine wrath and judgment.[29]

Ironically, what was once considered an unusual belief about hell in the first few centuries has now become the dominant view in the West, largely because both Catholicism and Protestantism embraced Augustinian theology.

Hell in Modern Christianity

Here is a brief summary of the most prevalent views on hell in contemporary Christianity, detailing the main advocates and the evolution of each perspective:

Annihilationism (Conditionalism)

Annihilationism asserts that the wicked will ultimately be destroyed or cease to exist rather than suffer eternally. Annihilationism believes that only the saved are granted immortality, while the unsaved face complete and final annihilation. Some key proponents include early Christian theologian Arnobius (3rd century), as well as John Stott, Edward Fudge, and Clark Pinnock (20th century). Annihilationists argue that the wicked will be utterly destroyed after the final judgment, ensuring that they do not endure eternal, conscious torment. Instead, their punishment is seen as finite, culminating in extinction.

Development: This view gained traction in the modern era, particularly through Edward Fudge's influential book, *"The Fire That Consumes,"* which argued biblically and theologically for annihilationism. John Stott's endorsement also helped bring the perspective into mainstream evangelical discussions. Today, Annihilationism is popular among Seventh-day Adventists and other evangelical groups seeking a "less abusive" alternative to the hellfire view.

Universal Reconciliation (Universalism)

Universal Reconciliation posits that Jesus' blood covers the sins of all people; thereby, all souls will eventually be reconciled to God and attain salvation. Some Universalist perspectives suggest that salvation of all will occur instantly after death, whereas the majority view is that many will first undergo a purification process in a realm akin to purgatory or hell. Universal Reconciliation highlights Jesus's ultimate victory over sin and death, emphasizing God's love, grace, and mercy.

Key proponents include numerous Church Fathers such as Clement of Alexandria (2nd Century), Origen (2nd Century), and Gregory of Nyssa (c. 4th Century), and modern proponents like Hosea Ballou (18th Century), George MacDonald (19th century), Karl Barth (20th century), and David Bentley Hart (21st century). These theologians contend that God's love and justice will eventually result in the reconciliation of all souls, guaranteeing that no one is eternally barred from God's presence. They believe that an individual's faith and deeds influence their eternal rewards and roles rather than their salvation.

Development: Origen's early concept of *apokatastasis* suggested eventual restoration for all souls. Later, other Church Fathers, such as Gregory of Nyssa, further defended Universalism. Although some of Origen's views were later condemned, Universal Reconciliation persisted among many theologians and is gaining a new wave of proponents in modern times. Today, Universal Reconciliation, better known as Universalism, has supporters in different denominations, mainly in the Orthodox Church and non-conservative Protestant denominations, emphasizing a more inclusive understanding of salvation.

Purgatorial View

This Roman Catholic doctrine holds that some people will have to go through an intermediate state in which their souls will undergo purification before entering

heaven. This purification prepares souls to achieve the holiness necessary to enter God's presence.

Some key proponents include Augustine of Hippo (5th century), Thomas Aquinas (13th century), Dante Alighieri (14th century, in literature), and the Catholic church. These theologians view Purgatory as a merciful opportunity for some elected souls to be purified from residual sin before enjoying the beatific vision of God in heaven.

Development: The concept developed in early Christianity and was formally articulated by Catholic theologians, like Thomas Aquinas's *"Summa Theologica,"* which provided a systematic theological framework. Dante's *"Divine Comedy"* popularized the imagery. Today, Purgatory remains a distinctive doctrine of the Roman Catholic Church, also recognized to varying degrees by some Eastern Orthodox and Anglican traditions.

The Orthodox View (Mystery of Hell)

Eastern Orthodoxy views hell less as a place of ongoing torment punishment ("hellfire") and more as a state of being separated from God's love, with some nuances about potential eventual reconciliation.

Some key proponents include Isaac the Syrian (7th century), Gregory Palamas (14th century), and contemporary figures like Kallistos Ware (20th century). These theologians view hell as a consequence of rejecting God's love, with the potential for eventual reconciliation for all souls.

Development: Orthodox theology has traditionally focused on the transformative and purifying aspects of divine judgment, often viewing hell as a metaphorical state rather than a literal place. The concept of "the River of Fire" by Saint Isaac the Syrian describes hell as an experience of God's presence that is painful for those not in communion with Him. Today, this view is prevalent in Eastern Orthodox theology, emphasizing a more mystical and relational understanding of hell and judgment.

Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) or Hellfire

This perspective maintains that hell is a realm of perpetual, conscious torment—physical, mental, and emotional—for the unbeliever (e.g., Calvinism, Evangelicalism, Catholicism) and for the believer who has forfeited their salvation (e.g., Arminianism, Pentecostalism, Baptist, Catholicism), nuanced depending on the denomination's specific theology.

Some key proponents include Augustine of Hippo (5th century), Anselm of Canterbury (11th century), Thomas Aquinas (13th century), John Calvin (16th century), Jonathan Edwards (18th century), and, in modern times, figures such as John MacArthur, John Piper, R.C. Sproul, and Wayne Grudem (21st century).

Development: Augustine's works, such as *"The City of God,"* helped solidify this view in Western Christianity. Thomas Aquinas reinforced it in *"Summa Theologica,"* and Jonathan Edwards' fiery sermons during the Great Awakening embedded it in American Evangelicalism. Today, the concept of Eternal Conscious Torment (Hellfire) is predominantly held by conservative and fundamentalist Protestant denominations, as well as by many Catholics, who see Hellfire as an inevitable result of divine justice. In their doctrine, they maintain that sin is an offense against God's infinite dignity and thus merits perpetual and severe torturous punishment. They hold the belief that those who pass away in disbelief will experience everlasting separation from God and endure unending, conscious, physical, mental, and emotional torment in Hellfire as proper punishment for their earthly sins. Ironically, a particular theological view held by many conservative Protestants suggests that Catholics, despite accepting and believing in Jesus as the Messiah, will still be condemned to eternal damnation due to differing theological beliefs.

The ECT perspective is, to a large extent, consistent with the views of hell commonly held by Islam. The Sunni view of hell, especially, is almost identical to the Eternal Conscious Torment (Hellfire) view in Christianity. Sunni theology also underscores hell as a realm of perpetual firey punishment for the condemned, employing the same depictions found in ECT.

Nuanced Views

- **Metaphorical Fire**

While some Christians (mainly fundamental and conservative Protestants) believe in literal flames in hell, others interpret the fire metaphorically, representing spiritual suffering and separation from God.

Metaphorical Fire Proponents: C.S. Lewis (20th century) and modern theologians across denominations.

These theologians suggest fire should be understood as a metaphor, representing the profound anguish of being separated from God. The metaphorical view has gained acceptance in modern theological discussions, emphasizing the symbolic nature of biblical texts and descriptions.

- **Emergent Views**

Emerging Christian movements and some contemporary theologians question traditional doctrines of hell, especially Eternal Conscious Torment, advocating instead for different, more nuanced, or symbolic interpretations of hell.

Some key proponents include Peter Enns, Andy Stanley, Brian Zahnd, William Paul Young, Brian McLaren, and Rob Bell.

These figures argue for a reinterpretation of the concept of hell that aligns more closely with both contemporary theology and biblical values of justice, compassion, forgiveness, and inclusivity.

- **Mortalism (Soul Sleep)**

Mortalism, also known as Soul Sleep, holds that the soul becomes unconscious at death and remains so until the resurrection and final judgment. Thus, as of

today, most or all souls are not yet in either heaven or hell. This view suggests an intermediate state as a period of unconsciousness awaiting the final resurrection and judgment.

Conclusion

These and other less-known views reflect the diversity of thought within Christianity regarding the afterlife and the fate of the wicked, showcasing a range of interpretations from strict, eternal punishment to ultimate reconciliation with God. The development of these doctrines has been influenced by key theologians and historical contexts, shaping the varied landscape of Christian eschatology today. When compared, the concept of hell in Judaism can be best understood as a nuanced position, somewhat akin to the Universalist and Purgatorial perspectives within Christianity.

Understanding Biblical Genres

When you hear phrases like "financial meltdown," do you picture Wall Street skyscrapers literally dissolving into puddles? Or consider a "political battlefield" — does it bring to mind politicians wearing armor and dueling with swords? How about the "corporate jungle"? Perhaps you visualize business managers hunting junior employees as if they were wild prey. And the term "media circus" — does it conjure images of journalists dressed as bees and swans, performing outlandishly for attention? Clearly, these scenarios are not meant to be taken literally. Contemporary audiences understand these expressions as figures of speech that employ symbolism and analogy to communicate complex ideas vividly. This was even more true in the context of societies that were mostly illiterate and heavily dependent on illustrations, metaphors, stories, and parables for comprehension.

Imagine you are a basketball player, and your coach sends a message to the team's group chat saying, *"We grilled the Yankees so strong last week I can still smell the smoke and hear the sound of their cry echoing!"* Your brain, knowing the context, understands these are metaphorical and symbolic expressions. But imagine someone in the year 4025 reading your coach's text and interpreting it literally. This is the same fallacy modern readers of the Bible often commit when confusing its different genres.

Cultural and Theological Context

Any student of Judaism knows that Jewish teachers always used literary techniques

like figurative language, metaphors, symbolism, and analogies in their teachings. Jesus and Paul—Jewish rabbis themselves—also utilized these and other literary methods, often overlooked by Western non-Jewish readers. Consider these examples:

Jesus:

1. "*I am the bread of life.*" (John 6:35)—Jesus did not suggest that He was a piece of pastry. Instead, this was a known symbol of spiritual sustenance.
2. "*You are the light of the world.*" (Matthew 5:14)—Jesus did not imply that His followers are candles or light bulbs. Rather, a Jew would understand this as a metaphor for how they can provide guidance, truth, and influence in the world.

Paul:

1. "*You are God's field, God's building.*" (1 Corinthians 3:9)—This symbolizes the growth and community among believers, not a literal claim of them being soil or structures.
2. "*Put on the full armor of God.*" (Ephesians 6:11)—This analogy represents spiritual readiness, suggesting the use of faith-based virtues as armor rather than physical gear made of iron or metal.

These verses clearly demonstrate the use of literary devices to convey deeper meanings and teachings. When ignored, not only can much of the richness and layered significance embedded in these scriptural texts be lost, but it may also lead to superficial, misinformed, or even harmful interpretations that fail to grasp the full spiritual and ethical insights intended by the authors.

This, I believe, is partly due to the intentional historical separation of Jewish elements from Christianity. For example, Emperor Constantine (4th century) actively uprooted Christianity from its Jewish roots in his efforts to establish a distinct, "Jewish-free" identity. Such efforts included the removal of Jewish priests from the church, the promotion of new doctrines and practices, and the insertion of pagan ones, which diminished any Jewish influences and excluded Jewish believers from Christianity early on. "*Let us then have nothing in common with the detestable Jewish crowd...*" [30] declared Constantine.

The First Council of Nicaea, held in 325 AD in Turkey, is perhaps the most renowned in Christian history. This was a pivotal event in early Christianity. However, bishops with Jewish backgrounds were not allowed to join the council.[31] This had notable, long-lasting repercussions for Christian-Jewish relations.

The Council changed the celebration of the Resurrection from the Jewish Feast of First Fruits to Easter in an attempt to disassociate it from Jewish feasts, stating, "*For it is unbecoming beyond measure that on this holiest of festivals, we should follow the customs of the Jews. Henceforth, let us have nothing in common with this odious people.*"[32] It was also decided to replace Passover with Easter and the Saturday Sabbath with a Sunday Sabbath.[33]

The persecution of the Quartodecimans marked the beginning of a dark era. The term "Quartodeciman" is Latin for "fourteeners," referring to Jews who celebrated Passover on the 14th of Nisan. As time went on, performing circumcision was outlawed, with violations punishable by death. Eventually, Jews were prohibited from holding public office or serving as officers in the military.[34] Later, restrictions were put on where the Jewish people could live, with whom they could do business, and where they could travel.[35] It comes as no surprise that Christianity has completely distanced itself—theologically as well—from its Jewish context. This has profoundly influenced Christian theology and the lack of understanding of Jesus and Paul as Jewish teachers, as well as the entire Bible, which was largely authored by Jewish individuals. This historical disconnection solidified and had long-lasting effects on the interpretation of biblical texts. In this part of the book, I hope to undo some of it.

Biblical Context

When you hear the word "hell," what imagery springs to mind? Suppose you are a member of Catholic or Protestant Christianity. In that case, you likely envision an immensely dark realm (Matthew 22:13) dominated by a vast lake of searing fire (Matthew 8:12), where souls are being tortured eternally while their teeth gnash and they cry endless tears 24/7. At a glance, there's a seeming contradiction in such descriptions: how can a place be shrouded in darkness and ablaze with fire simultaneously, given that fire naturally emits light? But you see, Jesus's Jewish

audience wouldn't take these words in their literal sense but understand them as proverbial figures of speech, symbolism, analogies, etc.

Indeed, these descriptions were not intended to be taken literally. Jesus Himself acknowledged, "*I have been speaking figuratively*" (John 16:25), and that He "*speaks to the people in parables*" (Matthew 13:10). This language highlights the use of metaphors to impart deeper spiritual truths, which is ironically juxtaposed against how some modern Christians interpret certain directives.

Consider Jesus' statement in John 6:54: "*Only he who drinks my blood has eternal life.*" Interpreted literally, this statement would suggest that only those who physically consumed Jesus' blood could attain eternal life. Such a literal interpretation not only restricts eternal life to a very few who had that access but also conflicts with Jewish Law, which Jesus said he came to fulfill, not to abolish (Matthew 5:17). Jewish Law explicitly prohibits the consumption of blood, commanding that Israelies "*must not eat the blood of any creature.*" (Leviticus 17:14). This apparent contradiction highlights the importance of recognizing Jesus' uses of metaphors and symbolism, emphasizing the spiritual act of accepting his sacrifice rather than a literal consumption of blood.

Likewise, hardly anyone takes Jesus's warnings to "*gouge out your eye and throw it away*" (Matthew 18:9) or "*cut off your right hand and throw it away*" (Matthew 5:30) literally. This is particularly ironic given Jesus was also referencing "hell" (*Gehenna*) in these same verses, highlighting a selective literalism that points to the importance of careful interpretation when studying biblical scripture.

However, by the time of the first English translations of the New Testament, the hellfire tradition had been so well ingrained in some Church traditions that where the translators saw "*Gehenna.*" This led to many of today's misconceptions about hell.

Biblical Genres

The Bible—a narrative—employs a wide range of literary devices, including metaphors, parables, and allegories, to communicate its messages. These literary devices are seldom meant to be taken literally—contrasting with a textbook or manual—but rather to illustrate deeper spiritual truths and creatively express them.

When Jesus speaks of hell in parables, for instance, he is using already familiar concepts and vivid imagery to convey profound moral and life lessons.

The Augustinian-Calvinist view of hellfire relies heavily on interpreting metaphors, symbolism, hyperbole, parables, allegories, and other similar literary styles not according to their intended genres but rather literally. This approach can lead to a misunderstanding of the original context and meaning of the Biblical texts.

By examining the "hell" passages, we aim to uncover the intended message and genre-specific nuances that are often overlooked when interpreted literally. We will consider the historical and cultural contexts, the literary styles employed by the Biblical authors, and some of the fallacies committed in modern interpretations. By examining key passages and understanding their context and literary styles, we can gain a clearer and more nuanced understanding of what the Bible does and doesn't say about hell, encouraging a more thoughtful and informed reading of the Bible.

Hell in the Torah

The Hebrew Scriptures, which chronicle God's relationship with Israel over thousands of years, do not contain a Hebrew term equivalent to the concept of hellfire as understood in later Augustinian-Calvinist theology. Instead, the Old Testament's Hebrew word " *SHEOL*" simply refers to the realm of the dead, akin to a grave. For instance, Genesis 37:34-35:

> Then Jacob tore his clothes, put on sackcloth and mourned for his son many days. All his sons and all his daughters rose up to comfort him, but he refused to be comforted. And he said, "No, I shall go down to **Sheol** to my son, mourning." Thus his father wept for him.
>
> Genesis 37:34-35, ESV

The NIV translated Sheol as "grave":

> I will go down to the **grave** to my son in mourning.
>
> Genesis 37:35, NIV

If we read this verse in other translations, like that of Douay-Rheims Bible, for instance, it will make no sense: *"I will go down to my son into hell, mourning."* Why would Jacob want to go to hell, and why would he think his son is burning in hell? This

is the time to remind ourselves that the word "hell" did not always mean what most understand it as today (eternal conscious torment in fire).

In English bible translations, the Hebrew term *Sheol* is variably translated in English versions of the Old Testament[36] as "grave," "underworld," "pit," "death," and "hell." This variation in translation has led to significant theological confusion regarding the afterlife.

Deuteronomy 32:22

John MacArthur's interpretation of the hellfire doctrine illustrates the confusion that can arise from depending solely on a single translation, particularly when ignoring the context and disregarding the evolving meanings of words over time:

> [Hellfire] is not new. This is what the Bible has said. You can go back to Moses…In Deuteronomy 32:22, it reads this way in the Authorized Version, *"A fire is kindled…says God…in my anger and burns to the lowest part of **hell**."* The 1611 King James version made it clear even that early that the anger of God reached into hell.[37]
>
> John MacArthur

In Hebrew, however, the term "hell" does not appear in the Deuteronomy 32:22 text; rather, the word used is "*Sheol*." Consider the much more literal JPS translation of Deuteronomy 32:22:

> For a fire is kindled in My nostril,
> And burneth unto the depths of the **nether-world**,
> And devoureth the earth with her produce,
> And setteth ablaze the foundations of the mountains.
>
> Deuteronomy 32:22 (JPS)

Taken literally, it would imply that God has a nose from which, during Moses' time, fire erupted to set the mountain foundations ablaze. However, within its context, Deuteronomy 32:22 serves as a metaphor for God's wrath, extending even to the underworld.

The absence of a definitive concept of hellfire in the Old Testament texts partly explains why traditional Jewish views on the afterlife, including notions of punishment, differ markedly from those later developed in Christianity. In Judaism, *Sheol* is more neutrally seen as a place where all deceased souls rest until judgment day rather than a place of torment.

Moses and the Prophets never depicted *Sheol* as a place of torment after death, which reflects the overall focus of the Law of Moses on temporal, not eternal, rewards and punishments. In fact, the Torah and the Prophets always emphasize an immediate consequence of actions within one's lifetime rather than posthumous suffering or reward.

Was Hellfire the Consequence of Breaking the Ten Commandments?

You might be familiar with videos by fundamental Evangelical minister Ray Comfort, which have been widely advertised and amassed roughly half a billion views on social media. He is best known for his "Ten Commandments Interrogation" series. In these videos, Comfort approaches strangers in public and prompts them to confess their sins by asking if they've ever broken the Ten Commandments. His line of questioning includes: *"Have you ever lied?" "Have you ever stolen anything?" "Have you ever lusted after someone?"* Honestly, it's challenging for anyone to answer 'no' to these questions. For instance, calling a bride's unattractive dress 'beautiful' technically makes you a liar. Taking a pen from work and not returning it makes you a thief. Regarding lust, I recall a doctoral class where all attendees were men. The professor asked if there was someone in the class who had never fantasized about lesbians. Despite the embarrassment, no hands were raised. It seems theologians, pastors, ministers—we've all been there. This wasn't a liberal institution. It was Dallas Theological Seminary!

Then, Comfort continues by explaining God's holiness to his interviewees: "*You have to be perfect in God's eyes. Morally perfect!*" Says Comfort.[38] Otherwise, "*if God judges you according to the Ten Commandments,*" you are doomed forever. The punishment is everlasting condemnation "*in the lake of fire,*" concludes Comfort.

So, because you broke the Ten Commandments, God must torture you in fire for eternity. Or, to use the words of another reformed preacher: "*We owed a debt to God because of our sin. And that debt was eternal punishment.*"[39] (Paul Washer)

During an encounter in August 2022, Comfort questioned a young Israeli-Jewish man on the street, "*Have you ever looked at a woman with lust?*"[40] Upon receiving an affirmative response and a smile, Comfort responded that, according to Jesus, this is equivalent to committing adultery and would result in condemnation to hellfire on judgment day. Comfort's claim made no sense to the young Jewish guy, who politely said he believed otherwise.

Let's step back and analyze the reasoning behind Comfort's claim that violating any of the Ten Commandments results in eternal damnation by using one of Comfort's frequently cited commandments:

> You shall not commit adultery.
>
> Exodus 20:14

Once Comfort gets his interviewees to admit that they have previously looked at a woman with lust, he then continues by quoting the following verse:

> I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
>
> Matthew 5:28

Comfort's reasoning goes something like this: Any transgression of the Ten Commandments, no matter how minor, such as a fleeting lustful glance at a passing woman, warrants harsh and everlasting punishment—eternal torture in hellfire. Essentially, Comfort argues that God endowed you with strong sexual instincts as an integral part of your being. Yet, if you entertain a sexual thought for even a moment

—and it is inevitable that you will—God is left with no option but to subject you to eternal torment in hellfire. The logical next step in this direction is to mandate that women cover themselves with Hijabs to prevent anyone from being inadvertently attracted. While I'm not advocating for permissiveness, this example highlights how religious legalism thrives.

Let's consider applying Comfort's reasoning to everyday life. Imagine living in a country where parking in a no-parking zone could land you a lifetime prison sentence or where a parent is legally permitted to cut off their child's hand for watching pornography. This scenario illustrates a society with extremely severe and unbalanced moral codes, akin to the harshness found in regimes like North Korea or Iran. Yet, this parallels how some Christians interpret Biblical Law, portraying it as even more draconian as eternal torture in the fire for lusting in your mind is much worse than losing your hand (or eye).

The issue is not with Jesus or the Law but with the misinterpretation of Moses and Jesus and with the association of the Law with eternal life or punishment in hellfire.

For the sake of argument, let's hypothesize for a moment that in Matthew 5:28, where Jesus spoke of lustful looks being akin to adultery, he was indeed suggesting a literal, judicial sentence of death, as stated in Leviticus 20:10. Under this interpretation, we must also consider his earlier statements in Matthew 5:21-22, where he allegedly equates an insult (*"fool"*) with risking eternal damnation. Such an interpretation might lead one to believe Jesus frequently threatened his disciples with eternal torture for anything but perfection. However, understanding Jesus in this way would severely distort his message. As a Jewish rabbi, Jesus often taught using parables, metaphors, symbolism, and figurative language to convey deeper spiritual truths rather than acting as a human textbook for escaping hellfire.

So, what was Jesus trying to convey? Every company that has been established began as an idea, a concept in someone's mind. Every gun fired at a person was initiated by a thought in the shooter's mind. All actions are initially conceived in our minds. Adultery begins with harboring the thought. Cursing stems from first feeling anger. Murder is preceded by hatred in one's heart.

To quote Andy Woods, the president of Chafer Theological Seminary:

> Jesus warned you about murder happening in your heart long before physically anything else transpires. Because private thoughts will ultimately lead to public actions. That's why there is so much scripture about us guarding the mind.[41]

What's the Point of the Law?

Misusing the Law

The term "Torah" (or "Law") is among the most perplexing and debated terms in both Judaism and Christianity, mostly due to erroneous translations.[42] "Torah" primarily refers to the Pentateuch, the first five books of the Hebrew Bible. However, the same word is also often used to refer to the laws and commandments within the Pentateuch.

Although there are laws in the Torah, the literary genre of the Torah is not judicial but narrative. It's a story – a story written in one book, "The Book of Moses." Later, the book was divided into five books: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. The laws/commandments are only a small fraction of the Torah, which is a narrative story. Jewish Bible Professor Simeon Chavel explains:

> The Torah, which contains most of the laws, is not a collection of laws but rather a narrative that tells the history of the Jewish people in their earliest days…Therefore we can view the Torah as a source of laws and even construct a set of laws from it. But this is not adequate grounds to interpret the Torah outside of its literary genre, which is a narrative…The fact that the biblical laws are always found in a literary context and not in a legal context means that the laws are indisputably tied to the means and purposes of the literary context in which they are found…The Torah is, first and foremost, a narrative and not a law book, and it needs to be treated accordingly.[43]

Judaism doesn't consider the Law's commandments to be an instruction manual on "how to get saved from hellfire," but rather as encompassing rites, rituals, customs, morals, and justice, all impacting earthly daily life and carrying immediate consequences. These laws, provided in the context of establishing a new nation, functioned essentially as the constitution of Israel. In a similar vein, American citizens do not regard the U.S. Constitution and laws as a pathway to eternal life. While the Law may have significantly influenced an Israelite's earthly life, it clearly pertained to their existence in this temporal world:

> If you fully obey the LORD your God and carefully follow all his commands I give you today…You will be blessed in the city and blessed in the country. The fruit of your womb will be blessed, and the crops of your land and the young of your livestock–the calves of your herds and the lambs of your flocks. Your basket and your kneading trough will be blessed…The LORD will send a blessing on your barns and on everything you put your hand to. The LORD your God will bless you in the land he is giving you.
>
> Deuteronomy 28:1; 3-5; 8-10

Much like modern law, the Torah sets forth regulations on taxation (Leviticus 27:30; Deuteronomy 14:28), banking (Exodus 22:25; Deuteronomy 23:19), and labor laws (Leviticus 19:13; Deuteronomy 24:14-15), among others. Suppose the Torah were to be given in contemporary times. In that case, it might include mandates such as prohibiting smoking on airplanes or prohibiting pedestrians from crossing the street unless the walking signal light is green (for Israel, I think it's white in the USA). While there are fines and penalties for violating these statutes, they do not pertain to one's eternal fate.

Throughout the extensive history of Israel, none of its prophets, kings, or judges ever linked adherence to the commandments with eternal life or hellfire. It was rather about life's repercussions. Discussions of the afterlife, in terms of obeying the commandments, would have been alien to the people of Israel. Indeed, breaking a commandment incurred punishment, but this was related to their temporal existence,

not the everlasting fate of their souls. While sin did carry penalties, including death for certain transgressions, these were physical, not spiritual/eternal consequences.

For instance, let's look into another one of Comfort's favorite commandments to quote in his videos. The 8th commandment says: "*You shall not steal.*" (Exodus 20:15).

Here in the Middle East, lamb is a favored dish. Imagine a scenario where my neighbor, driven by hunger while I was abroad, steals and eats one of my sheep. Does this mean, as some might suggest following Comfort's logic, that he's destined for eternal torture in hell? Not quite. Exodus 22:1 offers clarity: *"If a man steals an ox or a sheep, and kills it or sells it, he shall repay five oxen for an ox, and four sheep for a sheep."* This scriptural context reveals that God's justice for theft involves restitution, not eternal torture in fire. Thus, instead of facing eternal doom, my neighbor now owes me four sheep, and they better be well-fed and chubby!

To complicate matters, consider a person in the era of Deuteronomy who violates two commandments at once by abducting a woman to engage in sexual relations with her. One might assume that such transgressions must result in eternal damnation in hell. However, the Law offers a pretty straightforward solution:

> If a man meets a virgin who is not betrothed, and seizes her and lies with her, and they are found, then the man who lay with her shall give to the father of the young woman fifty shekels of silver, and she shall be his wife, because he has violated her. He may not divorce her all his days.
>
> Deuteronomy 22:28-29

In such a case, the man must pay a fine to the young woman's father and provide for her for life. It appears one might have to atone for their wrongdoings, possibly for a lifetime. However, this had nothing to do with one's eternal life.

King David is another great example. David committed theft and adultery with Bathsheba and even orchestrated the murder of her husband, Uriah. David also failed to repent or make amends. Only after about a year or so did God, tired of waiting on David, finally send the prophet Nathan to confront David (2 Samuel 12). Still, Nathan made no threat or mentioned David's afterlife. Instead, he declared David's punishment, which did not involve hellfire. Only at this point did David finally repent,

hoping God would spare his child's life. It seems clear that both Nathan and David understood that David's afterlife was not at stake. Notably, God did not even demand David's resignation from his kingship.

Let's look into another commandment. The 5th commandment, *"Honor your father and mother"* (Exodus 20:12), which holds a much more severe punishment. What would happen if you didn't honor your parents? Several chapters later, in the book of Leviticus, we find the most extreme situation: *"For anyone who curses his father or his mother shall surely be put to death"* (Leviticus 20:9). Now the question is, what kind of death is Leviticus referring to? A spiritual one? An eternal torture in the fire, as some believe, or was it something of a different nature? In Deuteronomy 21, we find the answer:

> ...then his father and his mother shall take hold of him and bring him out to the elders of his city at the gate of the place where he lives, and they shall say to the elders of his city, "This our son is stubborn and rebellious; he will not obey our voice; he is a glutton and a drunkard." Then all the men of the city shall stone him to death with stones.
>
> Deuteronomy 21:18-21

In the Bible, while a physical death penalty may have excluded someone from society, it was never linked to a secondary, eternal punishment in the afterlife. As far as the Torah is concerned, our behavior on Earth affects our life on Earth.

Conclusion

Nowhere in the Torah is there a threat that violating a commandment will result in eternal condemnation in hellfire. The fact that the foundation of the entire Bible, the Pentateuch, says nothing about hell is significant enough to cast serious doubt on the doctrine of eternal hellfire. The Pentateuch, which lays the groundwork for all of biblical theology, is completely silent on the concept of hell as a place of eternal

torment. This absence strongly suggests that the idea of hellfire is not an original part of the biblical message but rather a later development that lacks grounding in the core scriptures of the Jewish and Christian faiths.

Hell in the Prophets

The Hebrew Prophets also do not contain a Hebrew term equivalent to the concept of hellfire as understood in later Augustine-Calvinist Christian theology. Instead, the Hebrew word " *SHEOL*," which simply refers to the realm of the dead, is variably translated in English versions of the Old Testament as "grave," "underworld," "pit," "death," and "hell." This variation in translation has led to significant theological confusion regarding the afterlife. In this chapter, I will examine the most popular verses used to establish hellfire in the Old Testament's prophets.

Isaiah 5:14

Isaiah's prophetic vision during the First Temple period emphasized moral justice. His prophecies often highlighted the failure of Israel's leaders and people to uphold these values, resulting in severe consequences as depicted in Isaiah 5:14. This focus on justice and the inevitability of divine consequences reflect the larger theme of Isaiah's ministry, which called for repentance and adherence to God's covenantal laws. Chapter 5 contains graphic prophetic warnings delivered by the prophet Isaiah, including a warning of impending judgment due to the moral and social decay in Israel and Judah, urging the people of Israel to repent before it is too late.

Isaiah 5:14 states,

> Therefore **Sheol** has enlarged its appetite and opened its mouth beyond measure; and the nobility of Jerusalem and her multitude will descend, her tumult and he who exults in her.
>
> Isaiah 5:14

While some translations translated *"Therefore **Death** expands its jaws"* (NIV) and *"The **grave** is licking its lips in anticipation"* (NLV), others, like the English Revised Version, translated *"Therefore **hell** hath enlarged her desire."*

As we already covered, Sheol is a Hebrew word used in the Old Testament to describe the realm of the dead, often translated as the grave, having nothing to do with the modern concept of hellfire.

Isaiah 5:14 metaphorically describes the soon-reaching consequences of Israel, where the grave is depicted as expanding to accommodate the numerous who will die if Israel doesn't repent.

In Isaiah 5:1-7, God likens Israel to a vineyard that has failed to produce good fruit despite His care. The following verses (8-23) contain a series of woes against various forms of social injustice and moral decay in Israel. Isaiah uses vivid imagery to depict the grave consequences of these sins. Has Isaiah's prophetic warning come true?

Key Events Following Isaiah's Prophecy:

1. **Assyrian Conquest of Israel (722 BCE)**: The Northern Kingdom of Israel fell to the Assyrian Empire in 722 BCE, only a few decades after Isaiah's prophecies. The Assyrians invaded, leading to the capture and deportation of many Israelites. This event marked a significant loss of life and the displacement of the population.
2. **Sennacherib's Campaign against Judah (701 BCE)**: King Sennacherib of Assyria launched a campaign against the Southern Kingdom of Judah, devastating many cities, including Lachish. Although Jerusalem was miraculously spared, the campaign caused substantial destruction and loss of life.
3. **Babylonian Exile (586 BCE)**: The ultimate fulfillment of many of Isaiah's prophecies of judgment came with the Babylonian conquest of Judah. In 586 BCE, Jerusalem was finally destroyed, the Temple was burned, and a significant portion of the population was killed or exiled to Babylon. This catastrophic event was a direct consequence of the continued moral and spiritual decline warned about by Isaiah.

To conclude, Isaiah's warnings in Chapter 5 about the dire consequences of Israel's and Judah's sins were realized through several significant historical events, highlighting the accuracy and gravity of Isaiah's prophetic warnings. Isaiah 5:14 uses the metaphor of a grave enlarging its size and readiness to receive many newcomers, depicting the extensive death casualties awaiting Israel. The depiction of *Sheol* underscores the severity of divine consequences in response to persistent injustice and disobedience. However, it was not perceived as related to the notion of everlasting torturous punishment in the afterlife.

Isaiah 66:23-24

Isaiah 66:23-24 is also often cited in discussions about hellfire judgment. However, a closer examination reveals a nuanced understanding that differs from some modern interpretations of eternal hellfire.

> "From one New Moon to another and from one Sabbath to another, all mankind will come and bow down before me," says the Lord. "And they will go out and look on the **dead bodies** of those who rebelled against me; **the worms that eat them will not die, the fire that burns them will not be quenched**, and they will be loathsome to all mankind."
>
> Isaiah 66:23-24

Isaiah 66 explores themes of divine sovereignty, judgment, and restoration, ultimately affirming God's grand vision for humanity. The chapter presents a powerful narrative that juxtaposes God's omnipotence with His expectations of true worship.

Section 1: God's Infinite Dwelling (Verses 1-2): Isaiah opens with a declaration of God's dominion, where the heavens serve as His throne and the earth as His footstool. This imagery underscores God's omnipotence and His desire for genuine and humble worship, seeking those who revere His word rather than grandiose temples.

Section 2: False Worship and Divine Judgement (Verses 3-4): The text criticizes the hypocrisy in religious practices, equating insincere rituals to abhorrent acts. God promises retribution for those who follow their own corrupt inclinations, forewarning of severe consequences.

Section 3: Encouragement for the Faithful (Verses 5-9): This section offers hope and encouragement, using the metaphor of a pain-free birth to symbolize the swift and peaceful emergence of a new era for Jerusalem, urging the faithful to trust in God's promise and timing.

Section 4: Future Glory for Jerusalem (Verses 10-14): Isaiah foretells a time of peace and prosperity for Jerusalem, drawing on the comforting image of a mother soothing her child to illustrate the deep, nurturing love God holds for His people.

Section 5: The Coming Judgement (Verses 15-17): A stark warning of imminent judgment is issued against the pagan nations.

Section 6: Gathering of the Nations and New Creation (Verses 18-24): The chapter concludes with a vision of universal gathering and renewal, contrasting peace with the grim fate of the pagan nations who did not listen and repent.

The imagery of unquenchable fire and undying worms is a potent metaphor often found in biblical texts, particularly used to describe the total and irrevocable destruction of nations. This symbolism, later to be used in the gospels, vividly portrays the aftermath of divine judgment, where the fire that consumes represents an unstoppable force of destruction that cannot be extinguished by human means. Simultaneously, the worms that do not die add a layer of ongoing decay, suggesting a perpetual state of ruin.

It is important to note, however, that Isaiah describes *"dead bodies,"* not "people ceaselessly tortured."

Unquenched fire symbolizes complete consumption—nothing is left salvageable, akin to a landscape devastated by an uncontrolled blaze that leaves only ash and char in its wake. Meanwhile, the undying worms represent various decomposers, including certain types of worms, maggots, and beetles, who are well-known for their role in consuming decaying flesh. These organisms are critical in the process of decomposition, helping to break down dead organic matter. In this context, *"worms that eat them will not die"* suggests these pagan nations or empires will not rise again.

Malachi 4:1

Malachi 4:1 provides a stark warning about an imminent day of judgment, emphasizing its severity through vivid imagery:

> “Surely the day is coming; it will burn like a furnace. All the arrogant and every evildoer will be stubble, and the day that is coming will set them on fire,” says the Lord Almighty. “Not a root or a branch will be left to them."
>
> Malachi 4:1

This imagery not only emphasizes the severity and decisiveness of the impending judgment but also anchors its significance firmly within the reality of post-exilic Israel, where the community grapples with moral and spiritual challenges.

The reference to a "day" that burns like a furnace—and there were many of these "judgment days" in Israel's history—indicates a period of purification and judgment that is imminent and inescapable, yet temporal and for the purpose of purification. This metaphorical language is typical of prophetic literature, where the motif of fire often symbolizes God’s purifying Israel's wickedness and the consuming wrath against sin. A few verses earlier, Malachi wrote:

> He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver; he will purify the Levites and refine them like gold and silver.
>
> Malachi 3:3

The specificity of the judgment against *"all the arrogant and every evildoer,"* in the context of God's relationship with Israel, highlights the comprehensive nature of divine justice, which targets all forms of unrighteousness within the community.

In Malachi's time, the Israelites struggled with disillusionment and spiritual apathy after returning from exile. The prophet's message serves as a stern reminder of the covenant obligations that the Israelites had neglected. The imagery of leaving neither *"root nor branch"* illustrates the total eradication of evil, ensuring that no vestige of corruption or defiance remains to corrupt the community anew.

Historically, its original audience would have understood this prophecy as a call to repentance and reform. It underscores the earthly judgments that God would meet within the community's lifetime rather than a threat of eternal damnation in the

afterlife—a concept unfamiliar to the Israelites. The prophetic warning is framed to galvanize the Israelites towards righteousness, contrasting their current complacency with the stark, destructive consequences of continued moral decay.

Thus, Malachi 4:1 serves as a prophetic warning and a promise of an unpleasant yet temporary purification. It reminds us that God's justice is imminent and aimed at cleansing iniquities, thereby restoring the community to a state where it can truly flourish under divine guidance. The verse ultimately reinforces the theme that God's interventions, though often severe, are meant to lead His people back to a path of righteousness, ensuring their long-term communal and spiritual health.

Hence, to interpret Malachi 4:1 as an allusion to eternal torment in hellfire would mean significantly overlooking the context of its composition. Even if one suggests that Malachi's prophecies address both immediate earthly consequences for Israel and the afterlife, it follows that since Israel's judgments were always temporary and aimed at purification, any analogous scenarios in the afterlife inferred from these verses would similarly be for purification's sake rather than eternal.

Daniel 12:1-2

The Book of Daniel, including its apocalyptic visions, reflects the concerns and events of that era, making it one of the later additions to the Hebrew Bible. Daniel 12:1-2 is often cited in discussions about the afterlife and the concept of eternal conscious torment:

> At that time shall arise Michael, the great prince who has charge of your people. And there shall be a time of trouble, such as never has been since there was a nation till that time. But at that time your people shall be delivered, everyone whose name shall be found written in the book. And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.
>
> Daniel 12:1-2

However, a closer examination of its context reveals a different understanding. There are a few things to consider regarding these verses:

1. The Book of Daniel is highly figurative, known for its rich use of allegory and symbolic imagery, such as the giant statue made of different materials (gold, silver, bronze, iron, and clay), the four beasts emerging from the sea, and the ram with two horns and a goat with a prominent horn. This context demands that interpretations consider these elements symbolic rather than literal textbook descriptions.
2. ***"Your people"*** refers specifically to Daniel's people, the Israelites. This targeting helps clarify the prophecies' intended audience within the historical and cultural context of the Hebrew people.
3. ***"MANY of them that sleep"*** will awaken, rather than *ALL*, indicates a selective process. This challenges the notion that Daniel speaks universally of last final judgment destinies like heaven or hell. This implies that the "waking up" may involve varied outcomes based on individual lives and actions rather than pointing to a universal or uniform judgment for all.
4. ***"Book"***: There are several references to "books" in the Hebrew Bible. For instance, Psalm 56:8 mentions a memory book: *"You have kept count of my tossings; put my tears in your bottle. Are they not in your book?"* while Malachi 3:16 speaks about the *"book of remembrance."* These books symbolize records of people's deeds and God's acknowledgment of them. In Daniel, the *"book"* likely signifies the ledger containing the names of those among the Israelites faithful to God who will be delivered in times of tribulation. Considering that the "end times" began with Jesus' birth, this reference could allude to various events, such as the catastrophes of 70-135 AD, during which Israel's temple was destroyed, and many Jewish individuals were executed and exiled while Jewish believers in Jesus were preserved.
5. Some scholars point to the clear allusions to Genesis 1-2 with terms like *"dust"* (*AFAR*) and *"earth"* (*ADAMAH*) found within this context. In this context, some interpret these as intertextual references to the ongoing conflict between good and evil—symbolized by the seed of the woman

and the serpent. According to this interpretation, in the *"day of the Lord"*—not limited to a singular apocalyptic event—there will be divisions within Israel. Some will align with the woman's seed, while others will align with the serpent's seed. These verses are also enriched with celestial imagery that ties back to Moses and the Genesis creation narrative, where heavenly bodies like the sun, moon, and stars symbolize spiritual entities. Those aligned with the seed of the woman are destined to rule in a god-like manner; they will shine brightly, enact justice, and do so eternally in the New Eden or New Jerusalem.

6. *"Everlasting"*: The Semitic term *"OLAM,"* often translated as "everlasting" or "forever," generally signifies a lengthy duration rather than literal infinity, a later philosophical concept that did not exist in biblical times (more on that in a later chapter). In the Torah, *"OLAM"* is frequently used concerning the Law and commandments, though many Christians believe these are no longer applicable. Jeremiah refers to *OLAM* as a 70-year period (Jer 25:9), while Isaiah (32:14) and Jonah (Jonah 2:6) also use it to describe specific time spans.
   In Daniel, the juxtaposition of "everlasting [OLAM] life" with "everlasting [OLAM] shame and contempt" raises questions about their duration. Although both terms imply some form of equivalency, this doesn't necessarily pertain to their length. Jewish tradition speaks of two eras: OLAM HAZEH (this current age/world) and OLAM HABA (the age/world to come). The reference to "OLAM" as pertaining to "the age to come," rather than an indefinite period, suggests that in Daniel 12:2, the terms "life" and "shame and contempt" might both belong to the age to come qualitatively, without necessarily implying a never-ending duration.

7. *"Shame"*: The distinction in Daniel 12 between life and disgrace does not create a strict bifurcation between two states of existence. While 'shame' is contrasted with 'life,' nothing suggests that 'shame' is inherently distinct from life itself. Since those experiencing shame and contempt are alive (or else they wouldn't be able to feel), at least in some sense, those who awaken to shame at the resurrection might be depicted as shocked and surprised, suddenly aware of their misdeeds. Unlike pride, shame arises from the recognition of wrongdoing. Biblically, shame and restoration

are compatible, as seen in passages like Ezekiel 16:63, where God forgives those who feel shame. This emotion, shame, symbolizes humility, remorse, and repentance—qualities valued by God. Most of today's religious culture in the West views shame negatively, yet both Judaism and biblical narratives like that of the Prodigal Son illustrate shame's positive role in prompting repentance and reconciliation (Luke 15:17).

In Ezekiel 16:63, shame facilitates atonement and restoration, demonstrating that it can be part of a purification process: *"that you may remember and be confounded, and never open your mouth again because of your shame, when I atone for you for all that you have done, declares the Lord GOD."*

Thus, Daniel 12:2's contrast between life and shame does not imply a clear bifurcation; rather, it suggests that individuals may experience both salvation and shame as part of their spiritual renewal. Therefore, even if taking Daniel 12:2 as speaking of the afterlife, it's possible to understand "shame" and "everlasting" as a period of repentance that does not necessarily equate to perpetual torment.

There is more that can be said, but when considered, these seven points are enough to challenge the simplistic Augustinian-Calvinist interpretation of Daniel 12, highlighting its disregard for the context and meanings of the words involved.

Conclusion

As we have examined, the Torah and the rest of the Old Testament do not articulate a definitive doctrine of hellfire. Rather, proponents of the ECT hellfire theory, in the absence of explicit teaching, extrapolate from a handful of disparate verses to support their perspective, which is not substantiated by the text itself.

We also saw that the penalty for eating from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil was physical death, manifesting in the expulsion of Adam and Eve from Eden and the loss of access to the Tree of Life (Genesis 2:17; 3:22-24). God warned Adam and

Eve, "for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die" (Genesis 2:17), and on that day, they were banished from the Garden and denied access to the Tree of Life. This punishment is purely physical and immediate, with no indication of eternal torment in the afterlife.

The Hebrew Bible text consistently describes destruction as physical and immediate, affecting both individuals and nations. This is evident in the various divine judgments recorded, such as the flood (Genesis 6-9), the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19), and the numerous military defeats of Israel's enemies.

If hellfire were a reality, we would expect Moses to mention it explicitly in the extensive laws and warnings given to Israel. The Mosaic Covenant, including the Ten Commandments and over 600 laws, delineates blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience, all within the context of this life (Deuteronomy 28). There is no mention of eternal torment in the afterlife as a consequence.

Furthermore, in Jeremiah 32:35, God harshly condemns the practice of burning people (as a sacrifice to Molech), stating that such an act *"never entered His mind."* This declaration would be contradictory if God intended to subject the majority of humanity to eternal fire, as such an idea would inherently be in His mind.

The Hebrew Scriptures simply do not contain a concept of hellfire as understood in later Christian theology. This absence is significant because it suggests that the idea of eternal hellfire was not part of ancient Israel's theology. Any doctrine that does not appear in the foundational texts of the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings cannot be considered a core biblical doctrine. This also begs the question—if the doctrine of hellfire did not originate from God, where did it originate from?

Additionally, we observed that the Hebrew word "*Sheol*," often inconsistently translated in English Bibles as "hell," among other words, actually symbolizes the grave (the realm of the dead, the underworld), not a place of eternal torment. The continued translation of *"Sheol"* as "hell" in some modern Bibles perpetuates misunderstandings, suggesting an interpretation of eternal torment that is not present in the original Hebrew text. This mistranslation obscures the original context and intent of the Scriptures, leading to a distorted view of biblical teachings on the afterlife.

As we move into the New Testament, it's essential to recall that when the gospels and letters were composed, the Hebrew Scriptures were the only Bible. Jesus and his Jewish disciples' teachings were rooted in these texts. The subsequent chapters'

analysis of New Testament passages will clarify whether the New Testament presents a novel doctrine, that of eternal hellfire, or maintains the themes established in the Old Testament.

"To be thrown into Gehenna"

You very likely heard the claim that "Jesus talked more about hell than He did about heaven." Take, for example, the words of famous Calvinist Pastor John MacArthur:

> Yes, Jesus was a Hellfire preacher… Jesus spoke more about hell than anybody else in the Bible. In fact, He spoke more about hell than everybody else in the Bible combined…. He continually spoke about hell and He warned sinners to escape hell because of its horrible reality.[44]
>
> The gospels and the writers of the New Testament describe hell as a fiery place, and its fire is the fire of torture and torment. It's also described as darkness, outer darkness, like being lost in the most infinite corner of space under horrible torture and pain, a place of weeping, wailing, teeth-grinding agony.[45]
>
> John MacArthur

This statement, however, is incorrect. In fact, Jesus not once spoke of "hell" but spoke of "Gehenna," a term well-known in Judaism.

The term "Gehenna," used by Jesus in the New Testament as a metaphor to describe the condition of suffering and divine consequences, was understood by Jews of the first and second centuries primarily as symbolizing harsh consequences rather than a destination in the afterlife.

In Matthew 23:15, Jesus condemns the religious leaders for making their converts *"twice as much a child of hell"* as themselves. Here, Jesus uses "hell" (*Gehenna*) as a present reality rather than a future destination, suggesting that He viewed *Gehenna* as a condition of moral, spiritual, physical, mental, or emotional corruption occurring in this life. This indicates that Jesus understood *Gehenna* more as an earthly state of separation from God's ways and its consequences, characterized by hypocrisy and spiritual blindness, rather than an eternal place of torment awaiting sinners in the afterlife.

This interpretation aligns with the views of early Jewish and Christian thinkers, including Saint Origen. Origen, a Church Father from the second century, engaged extensively with Jewish scholars and writings, which influenced his understanding of scriptural texts. In his work '*Against Celsus*,' Origen discusses Gehenna, suggesting that Jews who did use it in terms of afterlife reality in his time viewed it more as a temporary process or place intended for purification and correction rather than eternal damnation.

Origin was a prolific writer who wrote roughly 2,000 treatises in multiple branches of theology, including textual criticism, biblical exegesis, hermeneutics, and homiletics. He was one of the most influential and controversial figures in early Christian theology and apologetics. He has been described as *"the greatest genius the early church ever produced."*[46]

Origen wrote extensively about the New Testament gospels and his interactions with Jews, but the most pertinent section is as follows:

> Now as we found that Gehenna was mentioned in the Gospel as a place of punishment, we searched to see whether it is mentioned anywhere in the ancient Scriptures, and especially because the Jews too use the word. And we ascertained that where the valley of the son of Ennom was named in Scripture in the Hebrew, instead of valley, with fundamentally the same meaning, it was termed both the valley of Ennom and also Gehenna. And continuing our researches, we find that what was termed Gehenna, or the valley of Ennom, was included in the lot of the tribe of Benjamin, in which Jerusalem also was situated. And seeking to ascertain what might be the inference from the heavenly Jerusalem belonging to the lot

> of Benjamin and the valley of Ennom, we find a certain confirmation of what is said regarding the place of punishment, **intended for the purification of such souls as are to be purified** by torments, agreeably to the saying: *"The Lord comes like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and He shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver and of gold."*
>
> Origen, Against Celsus, VI, 25.

This context is crucial for interpreting New Testament references to Gehenna, as it underscores the idea that early interpretations of this term, even when using it as an afterlife concept, might have leaned towards a temporary, corrective punishment rather than an unending torment.

"Valley of Hinnom" (Gehenna/Géenna)

Gehenna comes from the Hebrew phrase "*GEY HINNOM*," which means the "valley of wailing." It's an actual valley, here in Israel, on the southwest side of Jerusalem (Joshua 15:8).

In that valley, in the gorge known as *Topheth*, worshipers performed child sacrifices in the fire (2 Kings 23:10). This site was dedicated to the god Molech, to whom Israel's kings like Ahaz and Manasseh sacrificed their children (2 Chronicles 28:1-3; 2 Chronicles 33:6). The prophets confronted this evil, saying that God would send enemy nations to conquer Jerusalem, and Israel's leaders would be killed and their dead bodies thrown into that valley to be burned (Jeremiah 7:30-33). The fires that those kings started to consume the innocent would one day turn and consume them. While Israel experienced many purifying fires from God for their sins (e.g., Isaiah 1:25, Isaiah 48:10, Jeremiah 9:7, Malachi 3:2-3, Zechariah 13:9.), the act of burning young children as offerings to pagan idols was the most abhorrent of them all. In ancient Israel, Gehenna was essentially synonymous with shame and disgrace, representing a dark and ignominious chapter in Israel's history that led to significant purifying

judgment. For example, Jeremiah said that this place would become "the valley of slaughter," for in that ditch, the Babylonians would dump the corpses of Israelites:

> So beware, the days are coming, declares the Lord, when people will no longer call this place Topheth or the Valley of Ben Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter.
>
> Jeremiah 19:6

In later Jewish literature, such as 1 Enoch, which predates the New Testament, the Valley of Hinnom symbolized Israel's purifying punishments. God frequently punished Israel, but the biblical punishments were always for the sake of purification; otherwise, Israel would have long ceased to exist. God's punishment is real, but it is not akin to Calvin's or Luther's ideas of punishment, explicitly enticing to burn and eliminate the Jewish people once and for all.

Jesus, also a prophet of Israel, used these same images of 'fire' and 'Gehenna' to describe horrible evils and shame and God's response to them. God promised He wouldn't let evil go unchecked (Isaiah 13:11, Nahum 1:3, Proverbs 11:21, Jeremiah 25:31, Ezekiel 18:30, Malachi 4:1). Therefore, the fire of God's justice will ultimately consume all evil and remove it from His beloved nation. Likewise, He will purify His creation once and for all (Revelation 21:1-4; 2 Peter 3:3-9).

This Jewish term symbolizing shame and punishment, Gehenna, occurs 12 times in the New Testament and is translated as "hell," misunderstood by many modern readers as an afterlife torturous destination.

The Valley of Unpleasant Odors

The Kidron Valley, now a national park in Jerusalem, encompasses the Valley of Hinnom, also known as Gehenna, within its borders.[47]

The presence of urban garbage dumps, where city residents would burn waste, is widely recognized, although their exact locations have been unclear and debatable. To ensure you are well-informed of the ongoing heated debate, primarily between

Calvinists and non-Calvinists, regarding Hellfire and whether Hinnom was a garbage dump, consider the following: In 2011, Francis Chan, a Calvinist pastor, authored "*Erasing Hell,*" aiming to disprove the garbage dump theory. Subsequently, in 2015, DL Kennedy penned "*Gehenna Revisited: Rebutting Francis Chan*," which sought to counter Chan's claims.

A recent excavation, however, has confirmed the existence of a substantial city garbage dump in the Kidron area:

> The chance discovery of an Early Roman city dump (1st century CE) in Jerusalem has yielded for the first time ever quantitative data on garbage components that introduce us to the mundane daily life Jerusalemites led and the kind of animals that were featured in their diet. Most of the garbage consists of pottery shards, all common tableware, while prestige objects are entirely absent. Other significant garbage components include numerous fragments of cooking ovens, wall plaster, animal bones and plant remains. Of the pottery vessels, cooking pots are the most abundant type. Most of the refuse turns out to be "household garbage" originating in the domestic areas of the city...[48]

Rabbi David Kimhi (1160–1235), in his commentary on Psalms 27:13, noted that fires were perpetually maintained in the valley of Hinnom to consume the waste and corpses deposited there. Likewise, the Jewish Talmud links the location with fire and smoke (Erovin 19).

As with all city dumps, the poor, including lepers, often scavenged through the garbage. The waste and refuse that accumulated were often incinerated to be disposed of. Since there was always someone throwing their trash in this worms' paradise, the fires never ceased.

Quoting Isaiah 66:24, Jesus reminded his audience that:

> Gehenna, where "the worms that eat them do not die, and the fire is not quenched."

Worms do die; however, the metaphorical notion that they never perish is possibly linked to the abundant, continuous "food" (either corpses, garbage, or both) they consume. This could represent the numerous individuals who perished and were cast into the valley at various times in history, both before and after Christ's time.

The central issue is not whether the Valley of Hinnom served as the city's refuse site or merely as a location for discarding dead bodies (as mentioned in Jeremiah 7:31-32, 9:6-7, 19:11-12, and Isaiah 30:33). The significance lies in its symbolism of Israel's disgraceful past and the dire consequences that followed.

Jesus' summoning of Isaiah 66:24 likely evoked memories in the Jewish consciousness of Isaiah and Jeremiah's descriptions of numerous corpses thrown into the Valley of Hinnom during the Babylonian siege.

Jesus wasn't trying to describe some horrific afterlife cosmic scenario but was referring to a place well-known to Jews. A place symbolizing shame, humiliation, degradation, and divine consequences on Israel when failing to walk in God's ways. It was a way for Jesus to warn the nation of Israel of the upcoming repercussions of their failure to repent and change their ways.

American theologian, Edward William Fudge, explains:

> The term conveyed a sense of total horror and disgust...Gehenna was a place of undying worm and irresistible fire, an abhorrent place where crawling maggots and smoldering heat raced each other to consume the putrefying fare served them each day.[49]

Unfortunately, Jesus' caution to Israel became a reality. The first-century historian Josephus documents that, during the Roman siege of Jerusalem, corpses were thrown over the city walls into the adjacent valleys due to the lack of burial space within the city (Jos. War 5.12.3).

Clearly, to first-century Jews, Gehenna was a tangible location infamous for its disgustingness, repulsiveness, and revulsion. It was emblematic of shame and

humiliation, accompanied by images of fire, refuse, and death. It was the same national warning as before, only this time coming from the Prophet of prophets.

To Be Thrown Into Gehenna (Matthew 5:27-29)

Let's examine Matthew 5:27-29 as a case study:

> You have heard that it was said, "You shall not commit adultery." But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart. If your right eye causes you to stumble, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.
>
> Matthew 5:27-29

What did Jesus mean when he said that men looking at a woman with lust will end up in Gehenna? Was Jesus really promoting self-mutilation and teaching—as some believe—that looking at a woman lustfully will result in eternal punishment in Hellfire?

It's hard for me to imagine that Jesus, who only a few verses earlier said, "*Do not think that I have come to abolish Law or the Prophets*" (5:17), would contradict both himself and Moses in suggesting eternal Hellfire torment for anyone lusting in their mind, a concept utterly foreign to the Law and to Jews.

Clearly, Rabbi Jesus, a master of using parables, symbolism, and metaphors to convey deeper spiritual truths, was speaking figuratively. Otherwise, if we interpret Jesus' words in Matthew 5:29 about plucking out one's eye literally, we face an ethical and theological contradiction, as it seems unimaginable that Jesus would advocate for self-mutilation.

In his commentary on Matthew, theologian Francis Wright Beare points to the challenges in giving a literal interpretation to these words of Jesus:

> If this [Mt. 5:29-30] is to be taken as a 'demand' of Jesus, then it must be said that he is demanding the impossible, for it is the universal experience that the sexual impulses are uncontrollable.[50]
>
> Francis Wright Beare

It is improbable that Jesus was saying that if you were sexually aroused by looking at another person or fantasizing about them, even momentarily, you'd literally end up tortured in Hellfire forever. Jesus likely had children and teenagers—such as his disciples—in his audience.[51] Was he teaching them to literally dismember body parts, like their eyes, to ensure they would be saved from eternal torture in fire? If so, didn't Jesus know we don't need eyes to imagine and fantasize? People who become blind are still capable of lusting in their minds. Would Jesus actually instruct these young men that they would be eternally punished just for having sexual thoughts? Considering that sexual thoughts are a common human experience, why would God design us with these impulses and then imply eternal torture for entertaining them? How could that be considered just? A literal interpretation of Jesus's hyperbolic metaphors in Matthew 5 is nonsensical and misrepresents God's character, yet it does explain some of the religious legalism observed in the world.

Jesus often used hyperbolic language—a common rhetorical technique in Jewish teachings—to emphasize that evil begins with our thoughts. The use of such vivid metaphors was not to instill a fear of eternal damnation for typical human experiences like sexual thoughts but to stress the ethical life choices expected in his teachings. Lust was merely an example of something much bigger. Recognizing that lust is a common human experience his audience would relate to, Jesus highlighted the need for accountability and the pursuit of a higher moral standard, which Israel often failed to uphold. Jesus, knowing that probably all of his listeners lust in their minds, used it to make a point. Remember, Jesus wasn't speaking to a specific individual. His audience was a "crowd of Jews" (verse 1); he was a Prophet addressing the nation of Israel.

Why Threaten With Gehenna?

Suppose you were judged and condemned by society and, therefore, had to scavenge for leftovers in Gehenna to survive; it meant you got to the lowest point in your life—a place of great shame. You've likely lost everything and become an outcast. When New Testament texts using Gehenna are considered,[52] things become even more apparent. Jesus symbolically uses Gehenna to teach about consequences. Imagine the kind of shame people who lived in or scavenged through Gehenna Valley felt—constant shame and embarrassment. For that reason, missing one eye is better "*than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of Gehenna*" (Matthew 18:9). Losing a body part is preferable to scavenging for food amidst Gehenna's trash and flames for the rest of your life.

Now, let's connect the dots—If you were an Israelite caught committing adultery, you would either be stoned or become an outcast of society and find yourself living in shame in a dumpster—Gehenna. New Testament scholar N.T. Wright explains:

> When Jesus was warning his hearers about Gehenna, he was not, as a general rule, telling them that unless they repented in this life, they would burn in the next one. As with God's kingdom, so with its opposite: it is on earth that things matter, not somewhere else.[53]
>
> N.T. Wright

Every act of adultery ever committed started with a lustful thought, but not all lustful thoughts led to adultery. Harboring lustful thoughts might lead to dire consequences, as thoughts can manifest into actions. In a rigid religious society, such as that of second-temple Judaism, certain actions may provoke severe repercussions, stripping you of all you hold dear and casting you out to scavenge in the city's dump—Gehenna—as no one is willing to hire or work with you.

God's Gehenna is Restorative

The ability to control one's thoughts is essential, but there's an even deeper lesson to be learned. It was not God who threw individuals into the Valley of Hinnom; it was the people—a hyper-religious society. While God desires that even sinners live with dignity, be rebuilt, and become self-sufficient, it is religious leaders who often cancel, boycott, degrade, and essentially lead sinners into the Valley of Shame.

In contrast, when God witnesses sinners committing adultery, He does not seek to shame or abandon them. How do I know? Well, because when religious people brought a woman caught in adultery before Christ, suggesting she needed to be severely punished, Jesus did the very opposite of what the religious leaders hoped for. He forgave her: *"Then neither do I condemn you,"* Jesus declared. *"Go now and leave your life of sin."* (John 8:11). She did indeed sin. But Jesus did not condemn her. The religious legalists did. Similarly, while some religious individuals may be quick to condemn others to Hellfire, Jesus chose to show grace instead of passing judgment. He recognized that love is a much more potent force for renewing the human heart and conscience than the threat of Hellfire.

Worms and Maggots

Even when we consider the metaphors used, such as worms, who indeed inhabit garbage dumps and consume decaying matter, we can see God's grace. What is often lacking in modern Western thought is the Jewish context. For example, the Talmud (Shabbat 151b) mentions that maggots are formed for the deceased's benefit, indicating their role in the natural decomposition process. This is seen as a component of the life and death cycle established by God. Such a view acknowledges the presence of worms as an integral part of the natural world and essential in the body's return to the earth: *"…till you return to the ground, for out of it you were taken; for you are dust, and to dust you shall return."* (Genesis 3:19)

Worms and maggots play a vital role in our ecosystem, contributing to the decomposition process and facilitating the recycling of nutrients. Historically, worm (larval) therapy has been very successful in treating wounds.[54][55] However, in the modern era, sulfa drugs, also known as sulfur or brimstone drugs, became the popular method for treating infections in the 1940s. This led to the decline of worm therapy, which the public viewed with distaste. Subsequently, antibiotics became the preferred treatment. This all suggests that the predominantly negative view of these metaphors in the modern Western mindset was, in fact, more intricate and nuanced in ancient Israel. The metaphors of fire, sulfur, and brimstone, which we will explore later, are also included in this complexity.

Even if everything I have said so far is false... Even if Gehenna were to be taken literally as an afterlife cosmic fire chamber that endlessly burns people, this interpretation clashes with biblical prophecies. Jeremiah proclaims that one day "*the whole valley where dead bodies and ashes are thrown, and all the terraces out to the Kidron Valley on the east as far as the corner of the Horse Gate, will be holy to the LORD*" (Jeremiah 31:40), while the Psalmist envisions the Valley of Baka (weeping)[56] transformed into a place where *"thirsty hearts journey to appear before God in Zion, the valley of Gehenna will become a place of springs"* (Psalm 84:5-7). These passages suggest a restoration and sanctification of Gehenna, not its perpetuation as a place of eternal torment. How, then, could Gehenna be a literal and unending Hellfire if it is destined to become holy and rejuvenated? These Old Testament prophecies seem to directly contradict the idea of Gehenna as a place of eternal suffering in fire, as conceived by adherents of the ECT Hellfire doctrine.

Conclusion

To conclude, in Jewish thought, Gehenna symbolized the severe consequences of straying from God's path. On a national level, this concept represented the tangible loss of divine blessings and protection. On an individual level, it represented the outcome of sin, especially in an unforgiving religious society. As a result, those who deviated faced vulnerability and adversity, akin to being left to fend for themselves in

a desolate wasteland. Jesus used Gehenna both as a reminder and a threat for Israel —Your enemies will consume you, and you will be left to scavenge in the ruins.

Akin to the prophets of Israel before him, Jesus issued a direct warning to Israel: Turn away from your evil ways, or you will once again be consumed by Gehenna's flames, scavenging through the ashes to survive. His admonition to Israel was a tangible threat. This prophecy's fulfillment began 40 years later, starting in 70 AD, after a relentless five-month siege, with the Romans razing Jerusalem and the Second Temple. Rome decimated Jerusalem, killing and reducing the people of Israel to starvation amidst the ruins. According to first-century historian Josephus, over one million people, mostly Jews, were killed during the siege, with many corpses thrown into Gehenna.[57]

'Eternal' Punishment

Justice demands punishment; without it, crimes such as murder and theft would go unchecked, leading to chaos and lawlessness. Retribution is a necessary deterrent to maintain order and protect society.

While the opposite extreme of ECT hellfire are those who do not anticipate any form of punishment in the afterlife, to me, the gravity of certain human actions implies that consequences are unavoidable. It is unknown, and perhaps unknowable, what measures will be taken and against whom. However, suppose we entertain the notion of a period of correction for at least some actions or individuals. In that case, we must then consider the nature of this process, its intent, and its duration. This chapter will primarily focus on the concept of duration.

The Biblical Concept of Time

One of the risks in interpreting an ancient Jewish Middle Eastern text—the Bible—from a Western perspective is the anachronism fallacy, which involves injecting modern ideas into the ancient text. This issue becomes particularly apparent when considering the concept of time. In Western philosophy, eternity is a subject of extensive debate, but the concept, as understood today, essentially does not exist in the Near Eastern biblical context.

The concept of hell as a place of abusive torment with no end has been a cornerstone of a few Christian denominations, including the Baptist, Calvinist,

Fundamental Evangelicalism, Pentecostal, and other conservative Protestant and Catholic groups for centuries. This view has deeply influenced the religious worldview of individuals and churches alike. However, a careful study of the original languages of the Bible—Greek and Hebrew—reveals significant nuances in the terms translated as "eternal" or "everlasting." These terms, when properly understood, challenge the view of hell as an endless state of punishment.

According to the Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible:

> **Time:** The Old Testament and the New Testament are not acquainted with the conception of eternity as timelessness. The Old Testament has not developed a special term for "eternity." The word *aion* originally meant "vital force," "life," then "age," "lifetime."
>
> The Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible (vol. IV, p. 641-655)

The 19th-century theologian Charles Ellicott explains:

> ***Everlasting punishment–life eternal*:** The two adjectives represent the same Greek word, *aionios*-it must be admitted that the Greek word which is rendered "eternal" does not, in itself, involve endlessness, but rather, duration, whether through an age or succession of ages, and that it is therefore applied in the New Testament to periods of time that have had both a beginning and ending.
>
> Commentary on the Whole Bible (Matt. 25:46)

In James Hasting's Dictionary of the New Testament, it says:

> ***Eternity***: There is no word either in the Old Testament Hebrew or the New Testament Greek to express the abstract idea of eternity.[58]
>
> James Hasting

In the Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Bible, it is written:

> ***ETERNITY***: The Bible hardly speaks of eternity in the philosophical sense of infinite duration without beginning or end. The Hebrew word *OLAM*, which is used alone (Ps. 61:8; etc.) or with various prepositions (Gen. 3:22; etc.) in contexts where it is traditionally translated as 'forever,' means in itself no more than *"for an indefinitely long period."* Thus *OLAM* does not mean 'from eternity' but 'of old' Gen. 6:4; etc. In the New Testament *aion* is used as the equivalent of *olam.* [59]
>
> Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Bible

Richard Francis Weymouth, Doctor of Literature and a Bible translator, explains:

> **Eternal**: Greek: *"aeonion,"* i.e., *"of the ages."* Etymologically this adjective, like others similarly formed, does not signify *"during,"* but *"belong to"* the aeons or ages. [60]
>
> R. F. Weymouth

Theologian and Professor Herman Oldhausen says:

> The Bible has no expression for endlessness. All the Biblical terms imply or denote long periods. [61]
>
> Herman Oldhausen

Professor Knappe of Halle wrote:

> The Hebrew was destitute of any single word to express endless duration. The pure idea of eternity is not found in any of the ancient languages. [62]

Knappe of Halle

Charles H. Welch, editor of The Berean Expositor:

> Eternity is not a Biblical theme...What we have to learn is that the Bible does not speak of eternity. It is not written to tell us of eternity. Such a consideration is entirely outside the scope of revelation.[63]
>
> Charles H. Welch

G. Campbell Morgan, a British Doctor of Divinity and a conservative pastor who was the president of Cheshunt College in Cambridge wrote:

> Let me say to Bible students that we must be very careful how we use the word 'eternity.' We have fallen into great error in our constant usage of that word. There is no word in the whole Book of God corresponding with our eternal.[64]
>
> Campbell Morgan

OLAM

The Hebrew word *"OLAM"* is crucial in understanding the temporal nature of many biblical concepts, sometimes translated or interpreted as eternal. While "olam" is often translated as "forever" or "eternal" in some English versions of the Bible, a closer examination reveals that it generally means '**an age**' or '**agelong.**' A long duration without necessarily implying an infinite, unending span of time. Incidentally, even in contemporary Hebrew, "*OLAM* imprisonment," or a *life sentence*, spans only 25 years (17 years with good behavior). Not "everlasting."

The term *Olam* is frequently used in the Hebrew Scriptures in contexts that clearly indicate a finite period, further supporting the argument against the concept of eternal hellfire. Below are a few examples.

Jonah 2:6

> To the roots of the mountains I sank down; the earth beneath barred me in forever [*olam*]. But you, LORD my God, brought my life up from the pit.
>
> Jonah 2:6, NIV

In this verse, Jonah describes his experience in the belly of the fish, using the word *"olam"* to convey the seemingly interminable nature of his ordeal. However, we know from the narrative that Jonah was in the fish for three days and three nights (Jonah 1:17). The use of *"olam"* here underscores a period that felt exceedingly long to Jonah but was finite. This example illustrates how *"olam"* can describe an experience that is intense and seemingly endless but ultimately limited in duration.

Isaiah 32:14-15

> Because the palaces will be forsaken, the bustling city will be deserted. The forts and towers will become lairs forever [*olam*], a joy of wild donkeys, a pasture of flocks—Until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high, and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field, and the fruitful field is counted as a forest.
>
> Isaiah 32:14-15, NKJV

In this prophecy, Isaiah uses "*olam*" to describe the desolation of cities and palaces, implying a long period of abandonment. However, this state of desolation is clearly

finite, as it is set to last *"until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high."* The prophecy foresees a time when the wilderness will become a fruitful field, indicating a restoration that ends the "*olam*" of desolation. Here, "*olam*" conveys a significant but temporary period.

Leviticus 24:8

> Every Sabbath day Aaron shall arrange it before the LORD regularly;
> it is from the people of Israel as a covenant forever [*olam*].
>
> Leviticus 24:8, ESV

The context here is the showbread in the Tabernacle, in which the priests are to set out every Sabbath as a part of an "everlasting" (*olam*) covenant. This practice, which no longer takes place, was part of the Mosaic Law, which, according to later prophets (e.g., Jeremiah 31:31-32) and the New Testament (Hebrews 8:7-13), was fulfilled and replaced by the New Covenant through Jesus Christ. Thus, the "forever" was indeed long-lasting but not infinite, ending with the advent of the New Covenant. This demonstrates how "*olam*" refers to a covenantal period that, while enduring, is not eternal.

Ecclesiastes 1:4

> A generation goes and a generation comes, But the earth remains
> forever (*olam*).
>
> Ecclesiastes 1:4, NASB

Solomon's reflection in Ecclesiastes uses *"olam"* to describe the enduring nature of the earth. However, other biblical passages suggest that the current heavens and earth will eventually be replaced by a new creation (2 Peter 3:10-13, Revelation 21:1).

Therefore, *"olam"* in this context highlights the earth's long-lasting stability relative to human generations, but not an eternal unchangeability. This usage reinforces the idea that *"olam"* signifies an extended but finite duration.

Jeremiah 25:9

> "I will summon all the peoples of the north and my servant Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon," declares the LORD, "and I will bring them against this land and its inhabitants and against all the surrounding nations. I will completely destroy them and make them an object of horror and scorn, and an everlasting [*olam*] ruin.
>
> Jeremiah 25:9, NIV

In this passage, Jeremiah uses *"olam"* to describe the desolation that will come upon the land and the servitude of the king of Babylon. Here, *"olam"* refers to a period of seventy years, demonstrating once again that "olam" signifies a significant but finite period. This prophecy further illustrates that *"olam"* does not inherently mean an unending duration, as the desolation and servitude in chapter 25 are explicitly limited to seventy years.

Daniel 7:18

> But the holy ones of the Most High shall receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever [*olam*]—forever [*olam*] and ever [*olam*].
>
> Daniel 7:18, NRSV

Daniel's vision describes the saints' possession of the kingdom as *"for olam—for olam and olam,"* using the Aramaic equivalent of 'olam' **three** consequent times. In

contemporary understanding, this phrase might be translated as *'for an age, and another age, and another age,'* or *'for all ages,'* suggesting a continuation through multiple distinct periods. The repetition of 'olam' thrice, rather than a singular instance, could imply a progression or extension that goes 'on and on and on,' hyperbolically describing eternity. This stylistic choice might have been used to emphasize the concept of continuity beyond a typical duration, indicating a perpetual succession of ages that collectively approach the idea of eternity. This could possibly be the sole instance in the Scriptures where the concept of eternity is referenced.

Conclusion

The Hebrew word "*olam*," sometimes mistakenly translated as "forever," "everlasting," or "eternal," more accurately denotes an age or a long, yet finite, period. The various biblical examples illustrate that "*olam*" encompasses durations that are significant and enduring but ultimately limited. Recognizing this nuance is essential for accurately interpreting biblical texts and understanding the nature of divine promises and judgments. This understanding is particularly relevant in the discussion of hell, where the term "eternal" may have been traditionally misapplied, obscuring the true nature of God's judgment, justice, and mercy.

Aion and Aionios

The Greek words "*AION*" (αἰών) or "*AIONIOS*" (αἰώνιος) translate the Hebrew word "*olam*." They are used in the Septuagint (Greek translation of the Old Testament) for '*olam*' and New Testament writings. *"Aion"* means "age," referring to a specific period with a beginning and an end. *"Aionios,"* derived from *"aion,"* describes something pertaining to an age.

Strong's Concordance explains:

aión: a space of time, an age
Definition: a space of time, an age
Usage: an age, a cycle (of time), especially of the present age as contrasted with the future age, and of one of a series of ages stretching to infinity.

Strong's 165

HELPS Word-Studies explains:

aiŏn (see also the cognate adjective, 166 /aiōnios, "age-long") – properly, an age (era, "time-span"), characterized by a specific quality (type of existence).

HELPS, 165

Importantly, much like 'olam,' these words do not inherently mean "without end" or "eternal" in the sense of unending time. For example, Romans 16:25-26 states:

> Now to him who is able to establish you in accordance with my gospel, the message I proclaim about Jesus Christ, in keeping with the revelation of the mystery hidden for long ages [aionios] past, but now revealed and made known...
>
> Romans 16:25-26, NIV

The term "aionios" refers to a secret kept for ages, not eternally.

This does not mean aion-aionios can never mean "time with no end," but it would be the exception and is limited by context. Much like with Daniel 7:18, Ephesians 3:21 seems to indicate eternity by the repetitive *"all generations, forever and ever"*:

> To him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever. Amen.
>
> Ephesians 3:21, NIV

This doxology expresses "aion" in a plural form, often translated as "forever and ever" but literally meaning "to the ages of the ages." This phrasing might suggest a succession of ages or periods, each with its start and end but extending into a horizon beyond human comprehension. This stylistic choice might have been used to emphasize the concept of continuity beyond a typical duration, indicating a perpetual succession of ages that collectively approach the idea of eternity.

Misinterpretations and Translation Bias

The terms *aion* and *aionios* have historically been subject to various interpretations and biases in translation, often reflecting the theological predispositions of translators rather than the intrinsic meaning of the words. This issue is not just a matter of linguistic accuracy but also influences theological beliefs and how we view God's character.

Early translations of the Bible, including the Septuagint and the Latin Vulgate, had to grapple with how to represent Hebrew and Greek concepts of time and duration. Due to Roman philosophical influences on the concept of eternity, translators' choices have echoed through centuries in various Christian doctrines. For example, Jerome's Latin Vulgate (4th-century Latin translation of the Bible initiated by the Roman Catholic church) often used the Latin word *"aeternum"* to translate aionios, a choice that implied an unending state. This has significantly shaped Western Christian thought, where "eternal" is understood as everlasting.

For this and other reasons, scholars have debated the interpretation of words like "aion" and "aionios" as "eternal" in many English translations. Some translations, such as Young's Literal Translation and the Concordant Literal Translation, choose terms like "age-during" or "eon" to more accurately reflect the original meanings. These

choices highlight the variability in understanding these key terms and suggest that eternal punishment is not an inherent concept in the original texts.

Augustine of Hippo

The interpretation of *aion* and *aionios* has been heavily influenced by Platonic and later Neoplatonic thought, which viewed time as a degraded form of eternity. This philosophical overlay added a layer of infinity to the term that was not necessarily present in its original context.

Augustine of Hippo, widely known to be influenced by Neoplatonism,[65] argued that because God is eternal, any attribute of God, including punishments or rewards, must also be eternal in the sense of being timeless and unending.

Influenced by Neoplatonism, Augustine's argument that God's eternal nature necessitates eternal punishment commits the Fallacy of Equivocation by conflating God's timeless existence with the finite nature of human sins, leading to the mistaken conclusion that finite actions deserve infinite punishment. This reasoning undermines the principles of justice and proportionality and misrepresents God's nature as infinitely vengeful rather than just and merciful. Additionally, Augustine's argument commits the fallacy of False Analogy by assuming that because God's attributes, like love and justice, are eternal, their expression must also be eternal in the same way. This overlooks the finite and temporal nature of human life and the principle of proportional justice.

Augustine argued that because "aionios" was used for both *life* and *punishment* in Matthew 25:46, both must be eternal. However, this interpretation fails to recognize that the duration of "aionios" is contingent upon the subject it modifies. For instance, "aionios" life refers to the life of the age to come, while "aionios" punishment refers to corrective measures within a defined period.

Augustine's views were far from being universally accepted. The Eastern Orthodox Church, for example, rejected Augustine's new interpretation and continued to retain a more nuanced view of time, the afterlife, and punishment, often focusing on the transformative and purifying aspects of divine judgment. This divergence illustrates

that Augustine's doctrine of eternal punishment was not a settled matter even in the early centuries of Christianity.

During the Middle Ages, the doctrine of eternal hellfire became more entrenched, partly due to the works of influential theologians like Thomas Aquinas, who systematized Catholic theology. The medieval church used the fear of eternal damnation as a tool for moral manipulation and herd control, emphasizing the horrors of hellfire in sermons and art.

The Protestant Reformation brought renewed scrutiny to many established doctrines, including the nature of hell. Reformers like Martin Luther and John Calvin challenged the Catholic church's use of fear and the sale of indulgences as a means to manipulate the faithful. However, they did not reform the Catholic view on hellfire.

In modern times, several translations and scholars have recognized the need to correct the mistranslations of *"aionios"* and *"olam."* For instance, in Young's Literal Translation, Robert Young consistently translated *"aionios"* as *"age-during"* to reflect its true meaning. Likewise, the Rotherham text also chose *"age-abiding"* for *"aionios,"* aligning with the context of the original texts, and Concordant Literal Translation renders *"aionios"* as *"eonian,"* emphasizing its association with ages rather than eternity.

Aïdios

Aidios is another word often translated as "eternal" (or "everlasting") in English Bibles, but the word itself does not inherently mean endless duration. Its core idea is that of something unbroken, enduring, or unrelenting.

Remarkably, *aidios* appears only twice in the New Testament. Epistle to the Romans uses it once to describe God's power (Romans 1:20), and Epistle of Jude uses it once to describe the chains of the fallen angels (Jude 6).

> For his invisible attributes, namely, his ***eternal*** [*aïdios*] **power** and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse.

Romans 1:20, ESV

And:

> And the angels who did not stay within their own position of authority, but left their proper dwelling, he has kept in ***eternal*** [*aïdios*] **chains** under gloomy darkness until the judgment of the great day
>
> Jude 1:6, ESV

In Romans, God's power is *aidios* because nothing can limit, weaken, or overcome God. The emphasis is not primarily on duration but on the unbroken and inexhaustible nature of His power.

In Jude, the fallen angels are kept in *aidios* chains, yet the very same verse gives those chains a definite endpoint: they are held *"until the judgment of the great day."* A chain that lasts until a specified day is not eternal in the modern/timeless sense. It is unbroken and inescapable for as long as it is meant to last, but it is still bounded by the purpose for which it exists.

In both occurrences, then, *aidios* describes the enduring nature (power) of a condition rather than creating the idea of endless duration by itself. God's power is everlasting because there's nothing more powerful than Him. The angels' chains are *aidios* because they remain unbroken ***until*** the appointed day. Thus, not endless time.

Kolasis

The other word in question in *"Eternal **punishment**"* is the word "kolasis," translated as "punishment." The Greek word "κολασις" (*kolasis*) carries a profound significance that has often been overlooked in translations of biblical texts. Originally, "kolasis" was used in the context of chastisement and correction, and even in horticulture, it refers to the pruning of plants. In this sense, pruning involves cutting off certain parts of a

plant to correct its growth, ensuring that the plant remains healthy and productive. This punitive process may be viewed as a corrective punishment, not with the intent of being wholly destructive, as in "to torture and kill," but rather with the aim of providing chastisement and discipline.

For instance, the works of the philosopher Plato often reference "kolasis" in discussions about justice and moral education.[66] In his dialogues, Plato suggests that true punishment (*kolasis*) aims to reform the offender, thereby restoring them to a state of moral and social health. Rather than mere retribution, this perspective aligns closely with the original horticultural meaning of the term, emphasizing correction and rehabilitation, which is impossible if the punishment is endless.

Likewise, in "*Gorgias*," Plato discusses the concept of punishment and justice, highlighting that punishment (*kolasis*) should be remedial.[67] He contrasts it with retribution (τιμωρια), which is punishment for the sake of satisfying the anger or desire for vengeance of the one who punishes. Likewise, Aristotle[68] distinguishes between different types of punishment, noting that "*kolasis*" is administered for the sake of the one who is being punished, to correct their behavior, as opposed to punitive actions taken for the sake of retribution or deterrence.

In other words, *kolasis* was perceived as a form of punishment that was both temporary and corrective.

If we take "*kolasis*" to mean corrective punishment, the implication is that the kolasis punishment described in the New Testament is intended to bring about correction and, ultimately, restoration. This understanding aligns with the broader biblical themes of redemption and reconciliation. By viewing divine punishment as corrective, we gain a deeper appreciation for the nature of God's justice and mercy, which aims not at mere retribution but at ultimate restoration. For instance, in 1 John 4:18, *Kolasis* implies correction and improvement, not unending torment:

> There is no fear in love; but perfect love casts out fear, because fear involves ***kolasis***. But he who fears has not been made perfect in love.
>
> 1 John 4:18, NKJV

Therefore, instead of "eternal punishment," it could be argued that Jesus' words might be better translated as "an age of corrective punishment."

Conclusion

Augustine's interpretation of *"aionios"* as eternal set a precedent that influenced Western Christianity—primarily Catholic and Protestant—for centuries. However, his lack of proficiency in Greek led to significant misunderstandings perpetuated in later theological developments.

Unfortunately, many popular English translations render "*kolasin aionion*" as *"eternal punishment."* However, literal translations such as Young's "The Concordant," Weymouth, or Yale's "The New Testament: A Translation" render these words "*an age-long chastisement*" or "*the discipline of that age.*"

Consistency in translation is crucial for accurately conveying the meaning of biblical texts. Variations in translating *aion* and *aionios* across different Bible passages have led to inconsistencies in how readers understand the concept of time in scripture. The translation of *aionios* as "forever" in one context and "age-lasting" in another can confuse readers and lead to contradictory interpretations of scripture, affecting theological conclusions about the nature and duration of divine judgment.

The Sheep and Goats

In Matthew 25, Jesus presents three parables: The Parable of the Ten Virgins (verses 1-13), The Parable of the Bags of Gold (verses 14-28), and the one we focus on today, The Parable of the Sheep and the Goats (verses 31-46). Some, Augustine himself included, interpret a section of this parable (verses 41-46) as evidence allegedly supporting the Augustinian-Calvinist Hellfire. Let's read the entire parable:

When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, he will sit on his glorious throne. All the nations will be gathered before him, and he will separate the people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats. He will put the sheep on his right and the goats on his left. Then the King will say to those on his right, "Come, you who are blessed by my Father; take your inheritance, the kingdom prepared for you since the creation of the world. For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink, I was a stranger and you invited me in, I needed clothes and you clothed me, I was sick and you looked after me, I was in prison and you came to visit me."

Then the righteous will answer him, "Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you something to drink? When did we see you a stranger and invite you in, or needing clothes and clothe you? When did we see you sick or in prison and go to visit you?"

The King will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."

Then he will say to those on his left, "Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the *aiōnion [age-long]* fire prepared for the devil and his angels. For I was hungry and you gave me nothing to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me nothing to drink, I was a stranger and you did not invite me in, I needed clothes and you did not clothe me, I was sick and in prison and you did not look after me." They also will answer, "Lord, when did we see you hungry or thirsty or a stranger or needing clothes or sick or in prison, and did not help you?"

> He will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did not do for one of the least of these, you did not do for me." Then they will go away to aiōnion punishment, but the righteous to aiōnion life.

Firstly, it's important to recognize that this, like the preceding two, is a parable, not a historiographical account of events.

Secondly, it is significant that Jesus' warnings are not aimed at those with flawed Soteriology or Christology or at those completely devoid of faith in him. Instead, Jesus cautions those who show indifference to society's marginalized, impoverished, and needy individuals. Furthermore, the initial audience and critique of the parable were directed not at the secular, non-believing society, but rather at the religious community.

Thirdly, verse 32 states that *"the nations will be gathered before him."* Nations cannot "burn in hell," but they can collapse and be consumed by enemies in an "everlasting fire," similar to empires that were permanently destroyed. Historically,

the downfall of nations that neglected their poor and needy often foreshadowed their eventual destruction.

According to Abbott's An Analytical Study of Words:

> Matthew 25:31-46 concerns the judgment of NATIONS, not individuals. It is to be distinguished from other judgments mentioned in Scripture. [69]

Fourthly, the text lacks a redemptive quality. There is no apparent indication of post-mortem salvation within the entire context of the parable. If it were about salvation from hell, it would suggest that salvation comes not through faith—which is never mentioned in the text—but through deeds, such as visiting prisons and clothing the homeless. This presents a dilemma for proponents of the Augustinian-Calvinist concept of eternal damnation. If the text indeed refers to torment in hellfire, it appears to be contingent not on faith but on actions, a concept at odds with the Reformed doctrine of *sola fide* ("by faith alone").

The Sheep and the Goats

As everyone over here in the Middle East can testify, sheep are way cuter (and tastier) than goats. However, these are not the primary distinctions between the two. The key to understanding this parable and who the goats are lies in, of course, the Hebrew Scriptures. Ezekiel 34 similarly employs the sheep and goats metaphor:

> Son of man, prophesy against the shepherds of Israel; prophesy and say to them: "This is what the Sovereign Lord says: Woe to you shepherds of Israel who only take care of yourselves! Should not shepherds take care of the flock?"...As for you, my flock, this is what the Sovereign Lord says: "I will judge between one sheep and another, and between rams and goats."

Ezekiel 34:2, 17

Ezekiel's parable is not a contrast between believers ascending to heaven and seculars descending into hellfire but rather a critique of Israel's leadership and their poor stewardship.

Similarly, Zechariah 10:3 underscores the theme of selfishness represented by the shepherds/goats (the mention of 'goats' is oddly missing from the popular NIV and ESV):

> Mine anger was kindled against the shepherds, and I punished the goats: for the LORD of hosts hath visited his flock the house of Judah, and hath made them as his goodly horse in the battle.
>
> Zechariah 10:3, KJV

Like the prophets who preceded him, Jesus' parables of judgment target Israel and its religious leaders. This aligns with the role of Hebrew prophets, who held Israel's leadership accountable for their stewardship of the flock entrusted to them, especially regarding the poor, widows, and orphans.

In the same vein, only two chapters earlier (Matthew 23), Jesus sharply reproaches the leadership of Israel, using the same language of "woes" that Ezekiel employs to denounce those who neglect their duty to the flock.

His original audience clearly understood the target of Jesus' parables as a criticism being directed at Israel's religious leaders:

> When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard Jesus' parables, they understood that he was speaking about them.
>
> Matthew 21:45

Conversely, interpreting these parables as addressing unbelievers vs. believers (In what? Jesus hadn't even died yet) rather than critiquing the leadership's treatment of the poor and needy misrepresents their broader context. Jesus, the ultimate prophet

of Israel, judged the house of Israel, particularly its leadership. This insight is further reinforced by Jesus's other parables.

Matthew 21 further supports this interpretation:

> Therefore I say to you, the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people producing its fruit…When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard Jesus' parables, they knew he was talking about them.
>
> Matthew 21:43,45

Indeed, Jesus entrusted the keys to the Kingdom to his Jewish followers, effectively transferring God's presence from man-made Jewish sects to one made by Jesus himself. Acts 2:42-47 illustrates that the first church consisted predominantly of Israeli Jews. This counters the notion of Replacement Theology; God did not replace Israel with the Gentiles but instead created a new Jewish denomination into which Gentiles were later integrated (Acts 15, Romans 11).

In summary, a shepherd does not torture his goats with fire or kill them when they are annoying; rather, he disciplines them. Goats may symbolize wicked leadership, bad nations, or both—subject to individual interpretation—destined to endure disciplinary punishment.

Verse 46 in earlier Bible translations:

The topic of "eternal punishment" (kolasin aionion) was addressed in another chapter; however, consider how Matthew 25:46 has been rendered in previous Bible translations.

The New Covenant by Dr. J.W. Hanson, 1884:

> And these shall go away into onian chastisement, and the just into onian life.

Young's Literal Translation of the Holy Bible, 1898:

> And these shall go away to punishment age-during, but the righteous to life age-during.

The Holy Bible in Modern English, 1903:

> And these He will dismiss into a long correction, but the well-doers to an enduring life.

The People's New Covenant, 1925:

> And these will depart into age-continuing correction, but the righteous, into age-continuing life.

The New Testament, a Translation, 1938:

> And these will go away into eonian correction, but the righteous into eonian life.

Rotherham Emphasized Bible, 1959:

> And these shall go away into age-abiding correction, But the righteous into age-abiding life.

The Restoration of Original Sacred Name Bible, 1976:

> And these shall go away into age-abiding correction, but the righteous into age-abiding life.

The New Testament, A New Translation, 1980:

> Then they will begin to serve a new period of suffering, but God's faithful will enter upon their heavenly life.

With more than 900 translations of the Bible in English, it's always beneficial to explore multiple versions to gain a broader understanding. For more insights on Bible hermeneutics, consider exploring my book: "*Read Like a Jew: 8 Rules of Basic Bible Interpretation for the Christian.*"

Outer Darkness, Weeping and Gnashing of Teeth

Indeed, when these metaphors are taken literally and out of context, their imagery might appear quite terrifying, akin to a vivid depiction of the Augustinian-Calvinist hellfire:

> But the subjects of the kingdom will be thrown outside, into the darkness, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**.
>
> Matthew 8:12

> They will throw them into the blazing furnace, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**.
>
> Matthew 13:42

> Then the king told the attendants, "Tie him hand and foot, and throw him outside, into the darkness, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**."
>
> Matthew 22:13

Many Christians envision Hellfire as a place where millions perpetually weep and gnash their teeth day and night forever and ever. I hope they will have sufficient hydration to replenish their bodily fluids and that their teeth, which would otherwise

require monthly replacement, will be silicone or steel. I also hope they have some decent dentists there.

Jokes aside, we must not take these metaphors literally. Otherwise, in Matthew 22:13, *"outer darkness"* is referred to as the place of weeping and gnashing of teeth, while in Matthew 13:50, Jesus calls that same place *"a furnace of fire."* Again, if we interpret these passages literally, we have a contradiction because fire produces light in contrast with complete darkness.

According to the Physics Department at the University of Illinois:

> We usually keep the name "flame" for something that's burning and giving off light. If we use the word that way, there can't be a black flame, since "black" means that no visible light is coming from it.[70]

Though I'm not a scientist, I know that for a first-century Jew, there couldn't be both fire and darkness. But let's continue to take the literal line of thinking further. If we look at the context of Matthew 13, we see that it actually rejects ECT in hellfire and supports annihilation: *"Just as the weeds are gathered and burned with fire, so will it be at the end of the age."* (verse 40). When a weed is burned, it leaves nothing. Again, if taken literally, this contradicts the idea of eternal torment and supports the view of annihilation.

However, suppose I wasn't convincing enough. In that same chapter, Matthew 13, it is also mentioned that *"Jesus spoke all these things to the crowds in parables. He did not say anything to them without using a parable."* (Matthew 13:34). Thus, it might be wise to take Matthew's advice and interpret these as metaphors.

Wise people, especially rabbis, often speak using metaphors and parables. It is the uninformed who misunderstand and take their words literally:

> This is why I speak to them in parables: Though seeing, they do not see; though hearing, they do not hear or understand.
>
> Matthew 13:13

The uninformed were, ironically, the most religious people on the planet. Nevertheless, the ensuing question is, what exactly do these metaphors represent—not to us but to the original Jewish hearers?

Gnashing of Teeth

By now, you might not be surprised to hear that the phrase "gnashing of teeth" already appears in the Hebrew Scriptures in contexts beyond pain or abuse, often symbolizing envy, anguish, despair, or frustration.

Psalm 35:16 says, *"With godless mockery they gnashed their teeth at me."* Here, the gnashing of teeth is depicted as an expression of animosity and derision from King David's enemies. The enemies are portrayed as mocking him while gnashing their teeth. This usage emphasizes the extreme disdain and viciousness of the mockers, possibly stemming from feelings of great jealousy towards the king.

Psalm 37:12 says, *"The wicked plot against the righteous and gnash their teeth at them."* In these verses, the wicked are depicted gnashing their teeth at the righteous as they conspire against them. Here, the gnashing of teeth seems to symbolize envy and jealousy.

Psalm 112:10 contrasts the righteous and the wicked: *"The wicked man will see and be vexed, he will gnash his teeth and waste away; the desire of the wicked will perish."* In this verse, gnashing of teeth symbolizes the frustration and helpless rage of the wicked, again possibly stemming from jealousy as they witness the success and blessedness of the righteous. They are consumed by envy, leading them to gnash their teeth.

In all these instances, "gnashing of teeth" is associated with strong negative emotions, possibly envy, jealousy, and frustration. It reflects intense mental and emotional responses rather than physical pain. These contexts provide a richer understanding of the term when it appears in the New Testament, particularly in describing the fate of the wicked in eschatological judgments. Rather than indicating eternal torment in fire, it suggests a state of profound emotional and psychological distress that possibly resembles the feelings of envy, jealousy, or regret.

Likewise, in Acts 7:54, some of the *"members of the Sanhedrin"* were frustrated by what Stephen had said and "*gnashed their teeth at him.*"

In conclusion, the biblical term "gnashing of teeth" appears to be unrelated to physical suffering or torment but rather symbolizes intense emotions like envy,

jealousy, regret, or frustration. Perhaps "gnashing of teeth" can be best understood as the ancient version of FOMO:

> Fear of missing out (FOMO) is the feeling of apprehension that one is either not in the know about or missing out on information, events, experiences, or life decisions that could make one's life better.
>
> "Fear of missing out (FOMO)", Wikipedia

Have you ever been offered an early opportunity to invest in Bitcoin, only to scoff at the idea and later realize you missed out on becoming a millionaire? That regret, symbolized by the gnashing of teeth, is what we call FOMO, or the Fear of Missing Out. The emotional sting comes from recognizing what you could have achieved had you made different decisions in the past.

This is not about people trembling because they are whipped endlessly in hellfire. Rather, it's about the regret—by Christians too—over the rewards and honor they could have secured had they chosen differently in life.

In biblical terms, this concept possibly refers to individuals who missed their opportunity to accumulate significant rewards in God's kingdom. In this life, you have a unique opportunity to gather rewards and treasures that will await you in the world to come. You can spend your money on a luxury boat, but you can also "invest" in your spiritual future by, for instance, feeding the poor, building wells for the less fortunate, or supporting a struggling, cheeky Bible scholar in Israel. This spiritual investment is likely to yield far greater returns in your eternal future:

> Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
>
> Matthew 6:19-21

When you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Matthew 6:3-4

Jesus answered, "If you want to be perfect, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven."

Matthew 19:21

Look, I am coming soon! My reward is with me, and I will give to each person according to what they have done.

Revelation 22:12

Consider also: Matthew 5:12, 6:1-4, 6:19-21, 10:42, 18:4, 19:21, 20:26-28, 25:21 25:34-40; Mark 9:41, 10:29-30; Luke 6:22-23, 12:33-34, 18:22; Revelation 22:12.

One day, the stingy, mean, unkind, uncaring, unempathetic, and arrogant will gnash their teeth in regret. In contrast, those who are lovingly sacrificial, kind, generous, caring, empathetic, and understanding will inherit all the blessings the Kingdom has to offer. Yes, it's that simple![71]

It is my personal belief that in the future Kingdom, much like in our worldly ones, there will be a variety of roles and hierarchical positions. It is, after all, God's Kingdom, not a communist country. Many Christians will have had the opportunity to secure—not their salvation from hellfire—but an elevated status in this forthcoming Kingdom through acts of sacrifices, generosity, and kindness. When they eventually recognize that their malevolent and self-centered deeds have relegated them to the lowest echelon in the impending Kingdom, they will gnash their teeth in remorse. This anguish will be so profound that it will, metaphorically, sear their hearts like an unquenchable flame, for there will be no further chances to ascend the ranks. Spiritually, this is the ultimate Fear of Missing Out.

Outer Darkness

In the Old Testament, the term "darkness" has multiple meanings depending on the context. It can signify despair, ignorance, or the state of being excluded from God's protection and blessings. For instance, the Torah parallels lack of prosperity and misfortune with darkness:

> And you shall grope at noonday, as a blind man gropes in darkness; you shall not prosper in your ways; you shall be only oppressed and plundered continually, and no one shall save you.
>
> Deuteronomy 28:29

In the New Testament, the term *"outer darkness"* metaphorically represents exclusion. It is depicted as an exclusion from a vibrant banquet or celebration. Envision an ancient town in first-century Israel where, at night, darkness envelops all but one place—a radiant banquet hall in the center of the town square. In ancient times, much like today, banquets and celebrations were celebrated at night, often offering the only source of light in the area.

Being outside a kingdom at night during those ancient days meant complete darkness, as there were no modern light sources or electricity. Thus, being in the *"outer darkness"* symbolized being excluded from the joyful, light-filled celebration. This state is described as one of "weeping and gnashing of teeth," indicating profound frustration, perhaps stemming from the regret of those left out of the party. This image bears a resemblance to the contemporary expression "being kept in the dark." Missing out on a party, however, does not mean that you will be tortured in fire forever. It simply means you were not considered worthy to be invited to the banquet.

Conclusion

The images discussed, like that of gnashing of teeth or outer darkness, convey the emotional and spiritual distress associated with being excluded from the most significant celebration imaginable. It is akin to the feelings of isolation and desolation one might experience when not invited to an important social gathering while feeling they deserve to partake.

If the link between celebrations and darkness seems unclear, reflect on the employment of these metaphors in Jesus' parable in Matthew 22:8-14, where an invitation is extended to all, but only the deserving—represented by wedding garments—will be found worthy to dine and dance in the grand festivity. In Middle Eastern tradition, such celebratory imagery is not associated with hellfire but rather signifies esteemed roles, honor, dignity, glory, tribute, rank, and social standing. These signify those who will be found worthy. This doesn't mean others won't possess eternal life and partake in the everlasting dominion of Jesus Christ on earth and across the cosmos. Yet, they will forgo the initial coronation festivity marking the establishment of His throne on earth. Not being invited to a celebration does not imply one will be subjected to eternal torment. It simply means they were not found worthy of this kind of blessing: *"Blessed is the one who will eat at the feast in the kingdom of God."* (Luke 14:15)

Lazarus and the Rich Man

Jesus, having just concluded The Parable of the Shrewd Manager (verses 1-13) with the statement that *"You cannot serve God and wealth,"* proceeded to exemplify godly stewardship with yet another parable:

> There was a rich man who was dressed in purple and fine linen and lived in luxury every day. At his gate was laid a beggar named Lazarus, covered with sores and longing to eat what fell from the rich man's table. Even the dogs came and licked his sores. The time came when the beggar died and the angels carried him to Abraham's *KOLPON* [bosom]. The rich man also died and was buried. In Hades, where he was in *BASANOS* [touchstone, testing], he looked up and saw Abraham far away, with Lazarus by his *KOLPON* [bosom]. So he called to him, *"Father Abraham, have pity on me and send Lazarus to dip the tip of his finger in water and cool my tongue, because I am in agony in this fire."* But Abraham replied, *"Son, remember that in your lifetime you received your good things, while Lazarus received bad things, but now he is comforted here and you are in agony. And besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has been set in place, so that those who want to go from here to you cannot, nor can anyone cross over from there to us."* He answered, *"Then I beg you, father, send Lazarus to my family, for I have five brothers. Let him warn them, so that they will not also come to this place of BASANOS* [touchstone, testing]." Abraham replied, *"They have Moses and the Prophets; let*

them listen to them." "No, father Abraham," he said, *"but if someone from the dead goes to them, they will repent."* He said to him, *"If they do not listen to Moses and the Prophets, they will not be convinced even if someone rises from the dead."*

Luke 16:19-31

How do we know it's a parable? First, because *"Jesus said all these things to the crowds in parables, and he spoke to them only in parables."* (Matthew 13:34). Second, because it uses key terms and imagery that are characteristic of ancient Jewish parables.

In the Bible, the term "Abraham's Bosom" (sometimes translated as "Abraham's side") is a unique expression found only once. In Jewish tradition, however, "Abraham's Bosom" is a well-known metaphor (e.g., Apocalypse of Zephaniah 11:1-2; Kiddushin 72b; Genesis Rabba 67), not regarded as a literal place or as a historical account of events but a metaphor for being in a state of peace and blessing.

Nothing in the parable speaks about the quality of faith of the characters involved. In fact, this parable isn't about faith at all. The Rich Man, representing the Pharisees, is religious, as he calls Abraham "father," who in return calls him "son." On the other hand, Lazarus clearly represents the poor and marginalized, those who suffer in this life but are ultimately vindicated, as Jesus' earlier Beatitudes promise. The Rich Man symbolizes those—often religious—who live in luxury and neglect the needs of others, losing rewards in the afterlife.

What If It's Not a Parable?

The Augustine-Calvinist interpretation is compelled to view this narrative as a factual historical record due to the literal understanding of the imagery of heat and fire ("hellfire"). However, this interpretation involves a selective literal approach to the narrative, treating certain elements as figurative while others as literal descriptions. For example, John MacArthur asserts that the poor man is in Heaven, suggesting he views the term 'Abraham's Bosom' as a metaphor:

> "…Abraham's bosom. That's kind of an Old Testament reference to a place of comfort, a place of peace where Abraham is and Abraham, of course, was a true believer…So this would be heaven." [72]
>
> John MacArthur

False. The phrase Abraham's Bosom does not appear in the Old Testament. Yet, notice how John MacArthur says, *"That's **kind of** an Old Testament reference."* That was an interesting choice of words, *"Kind of."* How about *not at all* an Old Testament reference? Additionally, John MacArthur added a theological layer by saying, *"Abraham, of course, was a true believer…So this would be heaven."*

By interpreting it that way, MacArthur shifted the parable's focus from a critique of the love of money (verse 14) to the question of who is a true believer. In his view, Lazarus was a "true believer," while the Rich Man was not. However, the parable's original intent is not to define true belief, as it doesn't even address faith. This is evident also through Jesus' choice of the "Rich Man" over the "True Believer." In fact, Christ had just shared The Parable of the Shrewd Manager (verses 1-12) about the unjust steward who had mishandled his master's money. This second parable was told to illustrate further what proper stewardship is. Jesus did not abruptly switch from one genre to another; he did not go from telling a parable to narrating a historical event.

"Bosom" means a person's chest area. If we interpret this parable literally instead, then did Lazarus literally sit on Abraham's chest? There wouldn't be room to breathe, let alone stretch one's arms. Clearly, Christ is using symbolism. John MacArthur's interpretation that equates Abraham's bosom with heaven highlights a tendency among some preachers to selectively interpret this parable metaphorically where it fits their theological narratives about hellfire. However, Abraham's Bosom, a term unique to this parable and Jewish tradition and not found elsewhere in scripture, complicates literal interpretations, suggesting a symbolic reading was intended.

Interpreted literally, the parable appears to say that heaven and hell are separated by merely a short walk, with inhabitants of both sides able to communicate—a notion at odds with other beliefs positing hell as a distant, inaccessible realm below and heaven as an elevated sanctuary above. Instead, the parable should be considered

as metaphorically highlighting the consequences of ignoring divine commandments —represented metaphorically by the impassable chasm between the Rich Man and Lazarus. This chasm underscores the finality of one's earthly actions and their implications for the afterlife, yet it remains a vehicle for moral teaching rather than a doctrinal statement on the geography of the afterlife. The *"great chasm* (or *gulf*)*"* referred to the Jordan Rift Valley, symbolizing the division between Gentile lands and the Holy Land of promise, which Jews recognized as a symbol of salvation (divine blessing and protection).

A few chapters earlier, Jesus, possibly concerned that his words might be interpreted literally, clarified, "I speak in parables" (Luke 8:10). Nevertheless, some persist in interpreting these parables as literal historical events to align with their theological views.

Lazarus-Eleazar

Jesus's use of a real name in parables is not typical. For this reason, advocates of ECT in Hellfire often suggest that when real names are used, they ground the story in reality and, therefore, are not parables but actual historical events. This, however, represents a misconception of the function and significance of names in Judaism.

In contrast with non-Hebrew names, Hebrew names always carry a meaning. Hebrew names are often descriptive and reflect characteristics, divine attributes, or significant events associated with the individual. For instance, "Isaac" means "he will laugh," referencing Sarah's laughter upon learning she would bear a child in her old age. Similarly, "Samuel" means "heard by God," reflecting Hannah's prayer for a son. This tradition underscores the significance and intentionality behind Hebrew naming in Israel's culture, which is less common in most other naming traditions.

Lazarus, the Greek form of the Hebrew name "Eleazar," was already assigned in the Old Testament. In Hebrew, "Eleazar" means "God's Help." For a Jewish audience, this name—as with all other Hebrew names—bears allegorical significance and theological implications, suggesting Divine aid and fortitude, aligning with the parable's theme.

The expression *"desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table"* commonly identified Gentiles, as seen in Matthew 15:22–28. Similarly, the term *"laid at his gate"* echoes the typical Jewish reference to a Gentile convert known as a "Proselyte of the Gate," who embraced Jewish ethics, rejected pagan beliefs, and adhered to certain Jewish rituals yet did not undergo circumcision or baptism. However, they were often viewed as "second class" in religious terms.

The use of Lazarus-Eleazar and Abraham in the parable reminds the Jewish audience of Eleazar of Damascus, Abraham's chief steward mentioned in Genesis 15:2-3. Eleazar, also a Gentile steward, was initially the heir to Abraham's estate until Isaac was born. Despite this, Eleazar faithfully executed Abraham's wishes, even at the cost of his own inheritance. This disinheritance is symbolically captured in the parable, where Lazarus-Eleazar, representing Eleazar, is depicted as a "beggar" who has nothing of earthly value. The connection between Abraham and Eleazar adds depth to Jesus's parable, highlighting previous themes of stewardship.

The employment of a specific name to evoke Jewish tradition, something Jewish rabbis often do, suggests that Lazarus-Eleazar is the focus of the parable rather than the fictional setting. This technique highlights the importance of the character and the underlying message, drawing from familiar traditions and teachings to convey a deeper meaning and ongoing themes. In this parable, likely the concept that *"Some who are last will be first, and some who are first will be last."* (Luke 13:30), according to their life decisions.

The Rich Man

On the other hand, the Rich Man, unnamed, donned purple linen, a fabric traditionally associated with royalty, nobility, and affluence due to the costly nature of the purple dye in those days. This signified wealth and elevated status. The "Rich Man" remains unnamed because the parable is meant to elevate Lazarus-Eleazar.

The Rich Man was portrayed as an actual son of Abraham, with Christ having him call Abraham "father" (Luke 16:24) and Abraham acknowledging him as "son" (verse 25). In Judaism, this sonship implied that the Rich Man was a legal possessor of Abraham's inheritance, not necessarily a literal son, enjoying all the physical blessings promised to Abraham's seed. He wore purple, symbolizing kingship, and linen, representing priesthood—indicating the rich religious and royal heritage of Israel, specifically Judah, which assumed possession of both the kingdom and priesthood, embodying the promises given to Abraham. Essentially, beneath the surface, this served as Jesus's critique of Israel's religious and affluent leadership (e.g., verse 14).

Though the Rich Man was given Abraham's blessings, he was shown to be unfaithful. In contrast, Lazarus (Eleazar, the faithful steward) was now in Abraham's bosom, received into the "everlasting habitations" (verse 9). In a sense, this parable can be seen as Jesus' sarcastic answer to the Pharisees' declaration, *"We are Abraham's descendants"* (John 8:33) and *"Abraham is our father"* (John 8:39). This theme emerges early in Luke's gospel, where John the Baptist proclaims, *"do not begin to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father.'"* (Luke 3:8)

Fire, a symbol of the Rich Man's punishment, does not signify the duration of his punishment. Rather, "fire" carries profound symbolism of purification in Judaism and the Hebrew Scriptures, which will be the subject of a subsequent chapter.

BASANOS

The Greek word "*BASANOS*" is often translated as "*place of torment*" (NIV), "*horrible place*" (CEV), and "*place of pain*" (GNT), depending on the English translation. However, 'HELPS Word-Studies' defines '*BASANOS*' as follows:

> **Basanos:** a touchstone (a dark stone used in testing metals), hence examination by torture.
> **Cognate:** 931 básanos – originally, a black, silicon-based stone used as "a touchstone" to test the purity of precious metals (like silver and gold). See 928 (basanízō).
> In the papyri, basanos also means, "touchstone," "test" (so P Oxy I. 58.25, ad 288). 931 (basanois) was "originally (from oriental origin) a touchstone; a 'Lydian stone' used for testing gold because pure gold rubbed on it left a peculiar mark. Then it was used for examination by torture. Sickness was often regarded as 'torture' " (WP, 1, 37).
>
> HELPS Word-studies; 931 BASANOS

In essence, '*basanos*' signifies not gratuitous vengeful torture but rather a form that purifies precious metals, thereby cleansing them—a punishment of temporary and corrective nature rather than sadistic neverending torment.

Conclusion

The Lazarus of the parable is identified as Eleazar, Abraham's steward (Genesis

15:2), a Gentile from Damascus who "ate the crumbs." Despite being disinherited and becoming a beggar, Eleazar remained a faithful steward to Abraham and God. Upon his death, he received Abraham's inheritance in "everlasting habitations." The Rich Man in the parable is possibly Judah, representing Israel's religious aristocracy, who had five literal brothers and was a son of Abraham, unlike Eleazar. Judah also possessed kingship (symbolized by purple) and priesthood (symbolized by linen). However, Judah was not the true steward of Abrahamic blessings. Despite having the "oracles of God" (the Old Testament), Israel did not respond to their own Messiah.

The parable, set against the socio-religious backdrop of the Pharisees' love for money (Luke 16:13), serves as a critique of materialism and a call to ethical living according to Moses and the prophets, who often stressed God's mandate of taking care of the poor and needy (Exodus 22:22-23, Leviticus 19:9-10, Deuteronomy 14:28-29, 15:7, Isaiah 58:7, Proverbs 19:17, 22:9, Psalm 82:3-4, Zechariah 7:9-10, Jeremiah 22:16). The irony of the names in the parable is striking – religious wealth is personified by the "Rich Man," while the poor, needy and outcasts are given a more personal touch with a surname, epitomized by the remarkable Hebrew name "God Helps"!

The narrative does not attempt to develop a "hellfire" doctrine but to challenge the false yet prevailing notion of wealth as a sign of divine favor on religious people, subverting it to critique those who neglect justice and mercy. Jesus' engagement with Pharisaic hypocrisy does not endorse their views but utilizes traditionally familiar concepts in Judaism to challenge their practices and beliefs.

Thus, interpreting this parable should consider its role within Luke's broader narrative, its Jewish context, and Jesus' ministry, focusing on its ethical teachings and its use as a tool for spiritual reflection rather than a literal description of people being forever tortured in fire in the afterlife. This approach aligns with the broader scriptural context where parables function as illustrative tools rather than doctrinal textbook treatises.

"Unquenchable Fire"

When the Western mind encounters the word "fire," it often conjures images of witches being burned at the stake, nuclear bombs, or Dante's depictions of individuals tormented by flames, which has significantly influenced Western Christian theology. However, in the Bible, Judaism, and other ancient civilizations, fire, though potentially painful, primarily symbolized purification.

In ancient agricultural societies, including those in the Near East, fire was sometimes used to clear fields of stubble and weeds after the harvest. This practice helped prepare the soil for the next planting season and could also control pests and diseases.

According to HELPS Word-Studies, the Bible use of "fire":

> **4442 pýr – fire:** In Scripture, fire is often used figuratively – like with the "fire of God" which transforms all it touches into light and likeness with itself.
>
> God's Spirit, like a holy fire, enlightens and purifies so that believers can share more and more in His likeness. Indeed the fire of God brings the uninterrupted privilege of being transformed which happens by experiencing faith from Him.

Fire in the Hebrew Scriptures and Jewish Thought

In the Hebrew Bible (E.g., Isaiah 1:25, Isaiah 48:10, Jeremiah 9:7, Malachi 3:2-3, Zechariah 13:9.), fire is never depicted as a symbol of eternal torture in Hellfire. Still, it does represent many other significant concepts, particularly purification. One notable instance is the ritual of burning the Red Heifer described in Numbers 19:1-10. In this ritual, a completely red heifer without blemish is slaughtered and burned entirely with fire. The resulting ashes are then used to create water for ceremonial cleansing.

Similarly, Numbers 31:23 details the purification process for items taken from non-Jews. The passage indicates that items are required to undergo purification by being subjected to fire. This process underscores the symbolic use of fire in purification rituals.

In Malachi 3:2-3, the passage uses fire as a metaphor for Israel's purification, similar to how a refiner uses fire to purify metals:

> But who can endure the day of his coming? Who can stand when he appears? For he will be like a refiner's fire or a launderer's soap. He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver; he will purify the Levites and refine them like gold and silver.
>
> Malachi 3:2-3

In Jewish thought (e.g., Avoda Zara 75b), fire often symbolizes a process of purification and refinement. It is used to cleanse impurities and sanctify both objects and individuals. This is evident in various rituals and symbolic acts described in the Torah, where fire removes impurities and makes something pure and holy.

In the Hebrew Bible and Jewish tradition, fire also signifies God's presence, divine judgment, and transformative power. For instance, the burning bush encountered by Moses (Exodus 3:2) symbolizes God's holy presence, while the fire on Mount Sinai

represents divine revelation and covenant (Exodus 19:18). These instances illustrate the multifaceted symbolism of fire in biblical and Jewish thought, emphasizing purification, sanctity, and divine interaction with humanity. However, the Hebrew Scriptures never use "fire" in reference to an ongoing torture in hell.

Jesus, also a prophet of Israel, used these same familiar images of 'fire' to metaphorically describe God's response to the horrible evils in our world. He won't let them go unchecked. The fire of God's justice will one day consume evil and purify His beloved children once and for all (2 Peter 3:3-9; Revelation 21:1-4).

Matthew 3:10-12

In contrast with the Hebrew Bible and Jewish thought, the Augustinian-Calvinist perspective frequently employs the symbol of fire in a literal sense to endorse their belief in the perpetual torment of Hellfire. John the Baptist's words in Matthew 3:10-12, for instance, are commonly cited in this context:

> And even now the ax is laid to the root of the trees. Therefore every tree which does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire. I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I, whose sandals I am not worthy to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire. His winnowing fan is in His hand, and He will thoroughly clean out His threshing floor, and gather His wheat into the barn; but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire.
>
> Matthew 3:10-12

Jewish parables are deeply rooted in the agricultural context, resonating with a society whose daily life and economy were intricately tied to farming. This background is crucial for interpreting parables about master-servant relationships, wheat and chaff, and other agricultural metaphors. In Matthew 3:10-12, John the

Baptist employs these familiar agricultural images to convey his message of Israel's looming judgment.

In context, John the Baptist is speaking about impending judgment on Israel if it fails to repent. In Matthew 3:7-8, John warns the religious leaders that wrath (which, in Old Testament terms, often meant the violent conquest of Israel by its enemies) is coming upon the nation. However, Israel could escape it if it bore fruits worthy of repentance. When John speaks of the axe being laid at the root of the tree, he is saying that Israel's judgment is imminent.

Wheat and Chaff

Then, John goes on to speak about Jesus. The imagery of wheat and chaff is particularly telling. In agriculture, wheat grows as a single plant with both grain and chaff. The process of winnowing and threshing involves separating the valuable grain from the worthless chaff. This metaphor suggests that within each individual, there is a mixture of good and bad. The good (wheat) is preserved, while the bad (chaff) is destroyed.

When John uses the image of the wheat and the chaff, he describes the common practice of farmers gathering the harvest on their threshing floor, where the wheat is separated from the chaff with a winnowing fork. This tool was a cross between a rake and a shovel so that large scoops of grain could be tossed into the air while also creating a bit of a breeze. The heavier grain would fall back to the ground, while the lighter chaff would get blown off to one side, where it would pile up against a low wall of the threshing floor. Once the wheat and chaff had been separated in this way, the grain would be taken away for storage, while the useless chaff would be set on fire. Since chaff is light and insubstantial, it's not even usable as fuel as it burns very quickly, leaving almost no ash behind and very little evidence that it ever existed. If we are to take John's illustration as speaking of Hellfire, then we once again end up with a case for final annihilation, not eternal torture.

In the metaphor of wheat and chaff, the wheat could be seen as representing the good within us, intertwined with chaff—undesirable elements like sin and imperfections. This imagery aligns with Paul's teachings about the unworthy parts of

ourselves being refined through fire, *"if it is burned up, the builder will suffer loss but yet will be saved—even though only as one escaping through the flames"* (1 Corinthians 3:15), highlighting a purification process where our sins and flawed nature are eradicated, leaving only what is pure, even if the only good left is God's image.

This process is not about inflicting torment on individuals, a concept often oversimplified in teachings as a dichotomy of the saved and the damned, but rather a process of purification. This idea resonates with the core Christian doctrine of transformation, which calls believers to partake in the divine nature (2 Peter 1:4) by casting off the old self for a renewed existence in Christ. This metamorphosis entails separating the spiritual wheat from the fleshly chaff, retaining the soul's intrinsic worth while eliminating sinful traits.

The act of winnowing and threshing, integral to this metaphor, could symbolize the meticulous separation of one's virtues (the wheat) from one's vices (the chaff), which can be seen in Christ's admonition in Luke 22:31, where Simon Peter is told that Satan has desired to sift him as wheat—testing his faith and character. Likewise, Paul's epistles to the Galatians (2:20) and Colossians (3:9-10) echo this sentiment, illustrating how Christians should manifest their faith by adopting the new self, constantly rejuvenated to mirror the image of God.

Ultimately, the imagery highlights not eternal damnation in Hellfire but rather spiritual cleansing and purification, accentuating the transformative path of faith we are invited to embark upon. This process is immensely beneficial in realizing the blessings that God intends for us in this life. However, those who fail to repent will face their sins' dire and ruinous outcomes. This is the warning John delivers to the leaders and the entire nation of Israel. John employs the metaphor of fire to denote this destruction. In other words, John is warning: If you won't repent—remove your chaff—God will do it for you!

Burning of Chaff and Unquenchable Fire

When John says that the "trees will be thrown into the fire" (Matt 3:10), he is not literally talking about actual plants punished in Hellfire but is using the imagery of cutting down a tree, which then gets burned. Many trees are cut down and then used

to make planks of wood for building and construction. The trees of the lowest quality are, however, harvested and utilized as fuel for cooking and heating.

John states that those who won't repent will be symbolically cut down and burned. This signifies their worthlessness, as they will not be of any significant use when judgment arrives, representing their misdeeds.

The term *"baptism by the Holy Spirit and fire"* mentioned in Matthew 3:11 is similarly interpreted. The Holy Spirit and the fire are not at odds but complement each other. Baptism, meaning "immersion," suggests that just as metals are purified when immersed in fire, so too is this a metaphor for cleansing. The passage indicating Jesus will administer this baptism by fire does not imply Jesus will literally stand in hell with a massive flamethrower, burning people forever, but rather alludes to the symbolic purification of Israel.

Fire naturally dies out slowly. In contrast, unquenchable fire, unlike quenchable fire that must be maintained, suggests it will not stop until it fully completes its task. It burns all it is meant to burn and fully consumes everything fed into it. Chaff does not burn eternally; it burns quickly and then is gone. Thus, describing this fire as unquenchable indicates it burns hot and fast until there is nothing left to burn: *"For everyone will be salted with fire."* (Mark 9:49)

Gregory of Nyssa's beliefs may indeed reflect this view:

> God has one goal...some straightway even in this life purified from evil; others healed hereafter through fire for the appropriate length of time. [73]

Eusebius, in his Ecclesiastical History, [74] writes about a Christian named Julian who was burned to death for being a Christian. Eusebius describes this fire as being an immense fire. The Greek words he uses are *puri asbestō*, exactly the same words used by John in Matthew 3:12. Eusebius goes on to use the exact same term to describe how other Christian martyrs were killed. Clearly, when Eusebius used this phrase, he was certainly not saying that these Christian martyrs went to Hellfire. The bodies of these Christians were reduced to ash in the fire, not sent to everlasting torment.

Conclusion

Matthew 3:10-12, when understood in its historical and cultural context, along with the agricultural metaphors used by Jesus, points towards a punishment of purification and transformation rather than eternal conscious torment. The fire mentioned symbolizes refining and cleansing, which is necessary for sanctification. This interpretation aligns with the broader biblical narrative of redemption and restoration rather than unending torture.

Similar to 1 Corinthians 3:12-15, where works are tested by fire, the "chaff" represents the sinful, unworthy parts of ourselves. This metaphorical fire purifies by burning away sin and impurities, leaving only what is good and valuable. The core message of Christianity revolves around transformation—becoming “partakers of the Divine Nature” (2 Peter 1:4). This involves shedding the old nature and embracing the new nature, as emphasized in Galatians 2:20 and Colossians 3:9-10. The imagery of winnowing and threshing, along with the "unquenchable fire," can be understood as a process of refinement, separating what is usable (e.g., our souls, God's image, good deeds, and faith) from what is not (sin and falsehood).

Aren't we "Born Again" to Avoid Hellfire?

Evangelicals, commonly self-identified as "Born-again Evangelicals," generally interpret "born again" as a profound experience of repentance and faith in Jesus's sacrifice for sins. This experience is often specific, memorable, and pivotal to their personal testimony. These experiences, usually emotionally charged, can look like reciting a "salvation prayer" from a pamphlet in order to escape eternal damnation by "inviting" Jesus into one's heart or undergoing an emotionally intense "born again" experience, such as speaking in tongues in the case of pentecostal and charismatic groups.

Finding a comprehensive definition is challenging; however, the following statement serves as a good example of the Evangelical concept of being "born again":

> Being born again means starting over as a new creation in Christ. It's a personal and spiritual renewal, where your sins are forgiven and your heart is transformed by the Holy Spirit. In John 3:3, Jesus said to Nicodemus, *"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God."*[75]

The term "born again," however, could not have originally referred to accepting Jesus's death for one's sins to escape hellfire when it was first used in John 3:3, as Jesus had not yet died, nor was his death foreseen at that time. If anything, Jesus' disciples expected Him to lead a revolt against the Romans and establish His reign (Luke 24:21). This suggests that initially, the phrase "born again" held a completely

different meaning. Therefore, to assert that "to be born again" means "to avoid hellfire by accepting Jesus's death for one's sins" would constitute an anachronism fallacy, as it retroactively applies a concept or event (Jesus' death and its theological interpretation) to a period before it actually happened or was comprehended in such a manner.

To Be Born Again

> Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.
>
> John 3:3

So, what did Jesus mean by the term 'born again'?
To answer, we must consider two terms:

1. “Born Again”

2. “See [or ‘enter’] the Kingdom of God.”

1 Peter 1:23 states, ***“For you have been born again, not of perishable seed, but of imperishable, through the living and enduring word [logos] of God.”*** Here, Peter addressed an audience during a period when the New Testament, as we know it today, did not yet exist. At that time, only the "Old Testament" had been canonized. Thus, the question is, what was the "word" Peter spoke of?

Some Christians today view the Bible as God's word. However, John’s Gospel begins by identifying Jesus—not the Bible—as the “word” (logos) of God. This influenced early Christian thought to see Jesus’ life, ministry, and teaching as the ultimate expression of God’s word. Therefore, the “word of God” likely refers to Jesus's ministry, life, and teachings, particularly his parables and Sermon on the Mount, which were initially passed down orally.

In this context, to be born again is to educate oneself with Jesus’s teachings, values, and instructions and adjust oneself's life, attitude, and actions accordingly. This isn’t

a one-time mystical-emotional experience or a line one recites from a pamphlet but a lifelong mental journey of becoming Christ-like, including aiding the sick, helping the poor, embracing the outcast, loving enemies, forgiving trespassers, loving sacrificially, growing in empathy and compassion, becoming kinder, etc. This journey must begin with an initial realization of who our loving God is and what He truly desires from us through His word—Jesus Christ—leading to a lifelong pursuit.

Now, is "born again" supposed to lead us into paradise and away from eternal fiery torture?

The Kingdom of God

Some Christians view the "*Kingdom of God*" as a mystical afterlife paradise. However, this idea also diverges from Jesus's teachings.

In Matthew 4:17 and Mark 1:15, Jesus mentions that "*the kingdom of God has come near.*" Luke 17:21 states, "*The kingdom of God is within you,*" and Matthew 12:28 and Luke 11:20 assert, "*The kingdom of God has come upon you.*"

"*Near,*" "*within you,*" and "*upon you*" make the Kingdom of God very different from a heavenly destination far away in the afterlife.

In Matthew 5:3, Jesus said, "*Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the **kingdom of heaven**.*" and in Matthew 6:33: "*Seek first his **kingdom** and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.*" In Luke 8:1, we read that "*Jesus traveled about from one town and village to another, proclaiming the good news of the **kingdom of God**.*" He also sent out His disciples, in Luke 9:2, "*to proclaim the **kingdom of God** and to heal the sick.*"

Clearly, the "Kingdom of God" Jesus was referring to at the time was a present reality – a spiritual mindset, lifestyle, and attitude to life —here and now. This is, in fact, a very Jewish view known as *TIKKUN OLAM*. The Hebrew phrase *Tikkun Olam* means "world repair." In Jewish circles, Tikkun Olam has become synonymous with social action and the pursuit of justice, especially for the poor and needy.

To summarize, Jesus wasn't a 21st-century evangelical pastor from the West preaching you must go through a mystical-emotional experience that will—once you die—help you escape Hellfire. Instead, the parables of Jesus, a Jewish rabbi, were

concerned with the present. According to Rabbi Jesus, to “be born again” and “see/enter the kingdom of God” (John 3:3) means stepping into a living reality that represents Jesus' teachings and values:

> The kingdom of God is…righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit.
>
> Romans 14:17

My book, *"The Kingdom of Yeshua: Christ's Timeless Wisdom to Revive Your Spiritual Life,"* offers an in-depth exploration of the concepts of "being born again" and "seeing/entering the kingdom of God" and what living in that kingdom looks like.

"Away from me, you evildoers!"

There are two kinds of "Christianity." One is a religion that, on paper, intellectually adheres to all the correct theological recipes and doctrines about Jesus' Lordship and Divinity. The other is a way of life—represented by *the kingdom of heaven*—embodied by Christ-like individuals who live out the values Jesus taught and demonstrated. These values include loving-kindness, empathy, justice, compassion, extending grace, forgiveness, humility, and selflessness. While the former is frequently motivated by a desire for political power and concentrates on theoretical religious formulas, the latter embodies a transformative way of living that mirrors the heart and character of Jesus through an individual's worldview, values, actions, and relationships.

With that in mind, let's read one of the most frequently quoted portions from Jesus's Sermon on the Mount:

> Not everyone who says to me, "Lord, Lord," will enter the kingdom of heaven, but only the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. Many will say to me on that day, "Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name and in your name drive out demons and in your name perform many miracles?" Then I will tell them plainly, "I never knew you. Away from me, you evildoers!"
>
> Matthew 7:21-23

"Lord, Lord"

Many people intellectually affirm sound theology and acknowledge Jesus as their "Lord." This title, especially when used for Jesus, is a mark of respect and signifies deity. Let's use an extreme yet relevant example. The Ku Klux Klan has historically portrayed itself as a Christian organization, using Christian symbols and rhetoric to justify its ideology and actions. Most of its leaders identified as Christians, including preachers and ministers.[76] For instance, William Joseph Simmons, a Methodist preacher, was involved in the founding of the second Ku Klux Klan in 1915.[77] Other preachers and ministers like him contributed to the Klan's efforts to present itself as a defender of Protestant Christian values despite the organization's actions and beliefs being fundamentally opposed to Jesus's teachings.

Many individuals, today and throughout history, are intellectually submitted to the Lordship of Jesus, as evidenced by the way Jesus describes their enthusiastic proclamation, *"Lord, Lord."* They appear to be aligned in their understanding of who Christ is and seem fully committed to religious conduct. They probably attend church every Sunday and are actively involved in commendable "good works;" they preach, teach, prophesy, perform exorcisms, and even exhibit supernatural signs (Matthew 7:22). This resembles the same attitude Paul spoke of:

> If I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing.
>
> 1 Corinthians 13:2

"Many Will Say To Me"

Moreover, they are not a mere handful but *"many"* in number, highlighting that this form of religious self-deception is not a rare phenomenon but rather widespread—

the "wide road" of religion. Consider the irony: Many televangelists boast about the miracles they have performed in Jesus's name, and many pastors and theologians take pride in prophesying and teaching in Jesus's name (verse 22), yet Jesus disapproves of their ministry and points out that they are *evildoers*. The root of their lawlessness is not found in women donning colorful shorts and dancing with long-haired men to blaring music; it lies elsewhere entirely.

Recall what Jesus taught his crowd in his Sermon on the Mountain: humility, meekness, righteousness, mercy, peacemaking, compassion, forgiveness, and loving-kindness. These teachings encapsulate "doing the will of the Father," which they crucially did not practice. Their lack of this practice hindered them from entering the kingdom of God.

"Enter the Kingdom"

In Jesus's time, societal divisions were stark. The wealthy often resided within the safety and prosperity of kingdom walls, while those outside lived in relative poverty and vulnerability. Metaphorically speaking, real estate within the walls is always highly sought after. This societal setup is an analogy for the spiritual kingdom, suggesting that, spiritually and metaphorically speaking, some might end up in conditions akin to those less fortunate living outside the kingdom walls, essentially losing their privileged status, struggling, and perhaps in shame.

Entering the kingdom, therefore, symbolically signifies gaining a status of respect and honor for being close to God. Yet, not every Christian will automatically receive a privileged position in this kingdom; only those Jesus said he "knows."

"I Never Knew You!"

In Judaism, to "know" someone means to have a close, intimate relationship with and support what they stand for. Being an admired pastor and teacher with millions of followers on social media, leading a Bible College or renowned evangelistic ministry,

or pastoring a church doesn't guarantee that Jesus "acknowledges" you or, in other words, approves of your ministry. Merely proclaiming, *"I was 'born again' 20 years ago,"* or boasting about numerical accomplishments in Christian ministry does not ensure special recognition from Jesus or attest to having a genuine intimacy with God. By "intimacy," I'm not speaking of mystical charismatic experiences but about knowledge—of God and His will—that translates to fruit; *"Ye shall know them by their fruits."* (verse 16). Do they exhibit the fruit of love—such as being kind, gracious, compassionate, and forgiving even towards their adversaries? Or is their fruit limited to religious legalism, condescension, and residing in a religious ivory tower? Are the individuals under their leadership spiritually flourishing and emotionally thriving, or are they experiencing depression, stubbornness, and anxiety?

The teachings of Jesus underscore the crucial element of spiritual life: it's not about religious piety and outward performance but about the essential transformation of one's heart to align with God's will and its expanding ability to love and bless others truly. Merely performing religious acts or proclaiming Jesus's name is not enough to gain respect and honor that would secure a place in His Kingdom. Jesus's caution is not regarding salvation from hellfire—which is not at all implied in the context—but rather about the rewards and responsibilities that await those who act according to God's will.

Conclusion

If Jesus' teachings indicated that "many" would be rejected concerning their salvation from hellfire, it could seem that a significant number of Christians might be at risk of eternal damnation. This interpretation could seem at odds with Paul's teachings, which indicate that *"all are justified freely by his grace,"* (Romans 3:24) not merely a select few, since salvation is a free *"gift of God not by works, so that no one can boast."* (Ephesians 2:8-9).

In this context, however, being 'known' by Jesus, 'seeing,' or 'entering' the Kingdom serve as metaphors not for escaping hellfire but for being in close communion with God, a reward for the manner in which we live our lives. Unlike salvation, the rewards,

treasures, honor, and respect are to be earned through *"doing the will of my Father who is in heaven."* (Matthew 7:21).

Assuming Jesus's declaration that *"many"* have it wrong in his name is true, don't be surprised to find *many* churchgoers, ministers, seminary students, theologians, and pastors in that category.

"Narrow Gates" That Lead Where?

Matthew 7:13–29 concludes the Sermon on the Mount, where Jesus discusses the choices that lead to a blessed and prosperous life when living a life of righteousness. He emphasizes the importance of not only hearing His words but also acting on them, likening those who do to a wise man who built his house on the rock and, therefore, can stand through life's trials. In Matthew 7:13-14 Jesus stresses:

> Enter through the narrow gate. For wide is the gate and broad is the road that leads to destruction, and many enter through it. But small is the gate and narrow the road that leads to life, and only a few find it.
>
> Matthew 7:13-14

Augustinian-Calvinist preachers often interpret these verses out of context, suggesting that Jesus was implicitly threatening people with hellfire. For instance, in his sermon, *"The Way to Heaven: Matthew 7:13–29."* John MacArthur preached:

> Jesus Himself warned that many will deceive themselves into thinking they're going to heaven when they're really on the path to hell.[78]...The word destruction here simply refers to ultimate, eternal judgment in hell, everlasting torment.[79]

However, the context of Matthew 7:13-14 within the Sermon on the Mount does not suggest in any way that *"broad"* and *"destruction"* refer to eternal torture in hellfire, nor that *"narrow"* and *"life"* indicate heaven for those who accept Jesus as their crucified Savior. When Jesus declared, *"I am the gate"* (John 10:9), it would not have been understood as Him stating, "Believe that I died for your sins." The people who heard Jesus speak were not yet aware of his impending crucifixion and the theological implications of accepting his sacrifice for their sins. Therefore, interpreting Yeshua's metaphors in this way seems improbable and misaligned with the original message. This modern Western interpretation is not only anachronistic but also overlooks the historical and cultural context in which Jesus' original audience understood his teachings.

Narrow Is the Road

In this often taken-out-of-context verse, rabbi Jesus employs the metaphor of two paths (or ways), well-known imagery that echoes a common theme in both the Hebrew Scriptures (e.g., Deuteronomy 30:19, Proverbs 4:18-19, Psalm 1:6, Psalm 118:19-20) and in Jewish wisdom literature (e.g., Berakhot 28b:6, Pirkei Avot 2:1), contrasting the path of righteousness that brings blessings and prosperity with the path of wickedness leading to destructive consequences in life. This aligns with the Jewish concept of *'Derech Hashem'* (God's Way), where following God's law is viewed as a narrow path that demands dedication and, at times, sacrifice—but leads to great blessings!

Small Is the Gate

The imagery of gates in the context of ancient kingdoms, particularly as used in biblical texts, is rich in symbolic meaning (e.g., Isaiah 60:11, Jeremiah 7:2, Psalm 24:7, Nehemiah 3:1, Proverbs 8:34). For instance, gates could symbolize a righteous way of living that brings blessings and prosperity:

> Open the gates that the righteous nation may enter, the nation that keeps faith.
>
> Isaiah 26:2

To better understand the symbolism of gates, it's helpful to consider the roles gates played in ancient times. Ancient kingdoms were typically fortified with walls, and gates were crucial entry and exit points. Most people would enter through the wide gate. It was easier to pass through and could accommodate larger groups of people and carriages with goods or large animals. It was used for regular, everyday traffic, like a modern highway.

In contrast, a narrow gate was smaller, more exclusive, and harder to find. It was often controlled or guarded and led quicker into the most private parts where the king would reside. Only privileged ones could enter it. It was much less used and represented an exclusive status and a personal, intimate relationship with the king.

The "wide gate" and the "narrow gate" are metaphorically used to represent two different paths in life. Jesus contrasts the wide gate, symbolizing most people (remember, people were religious back then; secularism did not exist), with the narrow gate, symbolizing the more exclusive remnant.

The narrow road/gate symbolizes the closeness and intimacy with God that those who walk in righteousness experience, not an escape from an eternal cosmic fire chamber—a concept that was utterly foreign to the young Jewish disciples and hearers. The narrow road/gate represents the challenging but fulfilling path of living a righteous, godly life.

The narrow gate also symbolizes a difficult, seldom-traveled path demanding diligence, discipline, ethical fortitude, and spiritual dedication. Within the framework of ancient realms, this metaphor may be interpreted as a representation of decisions and their repercussions. The broader gate, bustling with trade, might signify the common pursuit of power and riches. It was also the place where religious leaders convened, epitomizing the quest for prestige and communal endorsement. Conversely, the narrow gate might represent a life embodying the principles of Jesus' teachings, as illustrated in his parables and the Sermon on the Mount.

Destruction

The Wide Gate symbolizes the easy, popular path that aligns with societal norms, including indulging in worldly pleasures, obstructing justice for self-gain, or following the common religious worldviews, which ultimately diverts from true spiritual fulfillment and leads to destruction. "Destruction," much like "gates" and "roads," was a metaphor implemented by Jesus to describe a life wasted, not an attempt to threaten us with an eternal cosmic holocaust.

I had a Jewish friend in high school who was fond of gambling and gradually became addicted to sports betting. He was frequently cautioned that this path could lead to his life's destruction—not in the afterlife, but in his earthly future. Sadly, he lost everything and faced real ruin. On the other hand, I had another Jewish friend whose life was devastated by drug addiction. His life was literally a hell he could not escape. It is pointless to threaten people with addiction to hell; they are already there and can teach us what it feels like. He recognized the need for change but couldn't do anything about it. One day, a Christian in recovery offered him a helping hand, and he embarked on a journey to overcome his addiction by following "the narrow way." He triumphed, finding a new lease on life. Now, he runs a thriving business and has a wonderful family.

For the sake of argument, if we entertain the Augustinian-Calvinist perspective, we face a contradiction since most Protestants believe salvation or justification comes through faith alone. However, if Jesus's words ("only a few find it") were about avoiding eternal torture in hellfire, it would indicate he was promoting a salvation that requires work. Hard work. Yet, if salvation is truly a free gift of grace, these verses may be interpreted as referring to the immediate consequences of our choices and actions in this life.

Destruction transcends the mere physical realm; its reach extends into the spiritual and emotional aspects of life. I have observed numerous individuals, both from my Jewish and Christian circles, who have been ensnared by an excessive devotion to religious formalities. This adherence to strict legalism often breeds a host of negative traits. Initially, it may start with a rigid adherence to rituals and rules, but gradually,

this can lead to deeper psychological impacts. These individuals become increasingly anxious, struggling with the fear of not meeting high religious standards. They often turn unkind, their compassion overshadowed by judgment and criticism of those who do not adhere as strictly to religious norms. Ultimately, this path can lead to profound sadness and depression, as the joy that faith is supposed to bring gets lost in the relentless pursuit of religious perfection. This transformation is a poignant reminder of the destructive power of misapplied religious fervor, affecting the mind and spirit just as profoundly as physical forces can ravage the body.

Conclusion

The contrast between the wide and narrow gates and roads in ancient parables symbolizes life decisions, ethical courses, and spiritual passages that influence our daily existence. The wide gate symbolizes the effortless, common route many select, whereas the narrow gate represents the arduous, seldom-trodden path that leads to genuine satisfaction in accordance with the principles of God's Kingdom.

Jesus likely employs kingdom imagery to distinguish between earthly and spiritual accomplishments. Choosing the narrow gate might not yield immediate worldly acclaim, but it fosters a more intimate, profound connection with God and a more lasting form of esteem and honor—one that aligns with the divine will and timeless spiritual tenets.

The "Gates of Hell"

In Matthew 16, Jesus finally introduces the concept of his death and resurrection to his disciples. In verse 18, Jesus declares something that confused many:

> And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it.
>
> Matthew 16:18

This statement, often misinterpreted to imply the fires of hellfire, actually speaks to the resurrection and the defeat of death. Understanding the historical and cultural context and examining the language used reveal a profound promise of victory over death rather than a reference to eternal conscious torment in hellfire.

Hades, sometimes confusingly translated to the English "hell," is actually the Greek word equivalent of Sheol, representing the underworld or the realm of the dead (the grave). In the New Testament, Hades similarly denotes the unseen place where souls go after death, awaiting resurrection. Like Sheol, Hades is not inherently a place of torment or bliss but a temporary holding place for the dead.

Considering the use of metaphors, interpreting "the gates of Hades" in Matthew 16:18 as referring to a literal fight against hellfire is not feasible. The imagery of gates fighting against a building is nonsensical. Instead, the gates of Hades, understood in the context of ancient Jewish and Old Testament writings, symbolize the power of death (the grave). Jesus is proclaiming that the power of death will not overcome His church. This is a promise of resurrection and future perseverance of Jesus's ministry/

Church rather than a reference to hellfire or eternal conscious torment. The Church, built on the recognition of Jesus as the Messiah, will ultimately triumph, liberating those held captive, much like an army breaking through the gates of a walled city to free its inhabitants.

The Gates of Death

Taken literally, the idea of gates fighting against a building is absurd. A gate is a defensive structure, not an offensive weapon. The imagery of the "gates of Hades" suggests something that confines or restrains, as if keeping the dead from leaving. In the context of Jesus' promise, the gates symbolize the obstacles of death and the grave. This interpretation aligns with their usage in the Hebrew Scriptures, where they are referred to as "the gates of death" (Job 17:16, Psalm 9:13, Isaiah 38:10).

The gates of death—like the gates of a cemetery—are a metaphor for the grave, not for a place of eternal hellfire torture.

Jesus' statement in Matthew 16:18 is a proclamation of His impending victory over death. By saying that the gates of Hades will not overcome His church, He assures that death—perhaps persecution—will not prevail against him, his ministry, and his disciples. This aligns with the broader biblical narrative of resurrection and eternal life:

> I am the Living One; I was dead, and now look, I am alive for ever and ever! And I hold the keys of death and Hades.
>
> Revelation 1:18

> Death has been swallowed up in victory. Where, O death, is your victory? Where, O death, is your sting?
>
> 1 Corinthians 15:54-55

These verses reinforce the idea that Jesus' mission was to conquer and defeat death—not hellfire—once and for all, thus inverting the Genesis 3 consequence of death.

Additionally, if the gates of Hades are meant to keep souls confined, Jesus' statement that they will not overcome his church implies liberation, not further confinement. The Church's role would be to break these gates and free the captives, aligning more with the concept of resurrection and liberation from death. In conclusion, Matthew 16:18's reference to the "gates of Hades" is best understood as a metaphor for death and the grave, not a place of eternal fiery punishment.

Fear Whom?

This chapter will explore two verses frequently cited by proponents of the Augustinian-Calvinist doctrine of hellfire. The first verse, from the Old Testament, is Proverbs 1:7, which states, *"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge."* The second verse, unrelated to the first, is from the New Testament, Luke 12:5, which is also referenced in Matthew 10:28: *"Fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell."*

Old Testament Fear

Have you ever ascended to the summit of the Eiffel Tower or stood at the prow of a boat amidst the vast ocean? Maybe you've perched on the edge of a mountain cliff or lain under a star-studded sky in the desert. If you have, you might remember the deep sense of awe, reverence, and sheer wonder that enveloped you. Undoubtedly, even the most courageous adventurer standing at the edge of an Olympic springboard would be hard-pressed to keep their heart from trembling. All of these feelings could be best described as *YIR'AH*.

While some English translations choose the English word "fear" to translate *YIR'AH*, other translations use "Awe,"[80] "Respect,"[81] and "Reverence."[82]

Moses was overcome with *YIR'AH* when he pleaded with God to witness His glory (Exodus 33). Similarly, the Israelites were steeped in *YIR'AH* when Moses descended from Mount Sinai with a shining face (Exodus 34).

In short, *YIR'AH* most often relates to experiencing something that surpasses one's abilities and comprehension.

To the modern eye, the concept of "fearing God" may initially appear to imply being scared, terrified, or afraid of God, but this isn't the biblical meaning. Being scared of someone doesn't entail knowledge. Instead, *YIR'AH* of God encapsulates a sense of awe, respect, and reverence toward God's majesty. You only want to study something —or someone—thoughtfully when you are in awe of them.

YIR'AH is an acknowledgment of God's sovereignty over all things, being all-powerful, etc. In the Old Testament, a Hebrew root with multiple meanings—Y-R-A —conveys different ideas depending on the context. *YARE* & *YIR'AH* are examples of Hebrew words derived from this root, meaning reverence, respect, or awe. In Genesis 22:12, it is used to describe Abraham's respect and trust in God:

> "Do not lay a hand on the boy," he said. "Do not do anything to him. Now I know that you *YIR'AH* God, because you have not withheld from me your son, your only son."
>
> Genesis 22:12

Proverbs 1:7

In Proverbs 1:7, *YIR'AH* is used to describe wisdom and knowledge:

> The fear of (*YIRAT*) the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; but fools despise wisdom and instruction.
>
> Proverbs 1:7

In this Proverb, the contrast of knowledge is despising wisdom and instruction, while the contrast of *YIR'AH* is a foolish person. If *YIR'AH* were about being scared-terrified, then the opposite would not be a foolish person who despises wisdom but

fearlessness. In this context, having *YIR'AH* —or being impressed with God—is the opposite of a fool: someone who rejects wisdom and instruction.

For illustration's sake, imagine a master craftsman and an apprentice. The apprentice must approach the master with respect and a willingness to learn, recognizing the master's expertise and authority. If the apprentice despises the master's instruction, they are unlikely to gain the skills and knowledge needed to become a craftsman themselves. *YIR'AH*, in this case, represents the apprentice's awe and respect for the master, which is essential for true learning. In contrast, a fool is like an apprentice who rejects the master's wisdom, thereby missing the opportunity to grow and develop.

The Hebrew words in the Hebrew Scriptures that describe what we in modern language consider "fear" are *EIMAH* (terror) and *PACHAD* (scare). These are when you are afraid for your life, fearing someone will want to hurt you or kill you. However, the words used in Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 are different, meaning "awe" or "reverence." In other words, wisdom begins with awe and respect for God, not with fearing he'll kill you…

In the New Testament, when Paul delivered his sermon in the synagogue at Antioch, he addressed two distinct groups: *"Men of Israel and* ***you who fear God****, listen"* (Acts 13:16). "God-fearers" is a known phrase meant to describe Gentiles who demonstrated deep respect and reverence for the God of Israel. In the Book of Acts, *"God-fearing Gentiles"* (Acts 13:26) refers to Gentiles (non-Jews) who were attracted to Judaism and its teachings but had not fully converted to Judaism.

Paul didn't refer in his sermon to people who were scared-terrified of the God of Israel. On the contrary, they were drawn to Him because they were in awe and respected Him. They admired the God of Israel's power, justice, and goodness. Their "fear" was not one that repels but one that attracts and motivates obedience, encourages humility and fosters a more profound, respectful relationship with God.

New Testament Fear

Luke 12:5 (Matthew 10:28)

> Meanwhile, when a crowd of many thousands had gathered, so that they were trampling on one another, Jesus began to speak first to his disciples, saying: **“Be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy.** 2 There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. 3 What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs.” 4 “I tell you, my friends, do not be afraid of those who kill the body and after that can do no more. 5 But I will show you whom you should fear: **Fear him who, after your body has been killed, has authority to throw you into hell [Gehenna].** Yes, I tell you, **fear him**. 6 Are not five sparrows sold for two pennies? Yet not one of them is forgotten by God. 7 Indeed, the very hairs of your head are all numbered. **Don’t be afraid**; you are worth more than many sparrows.
>
> Luke 12:1-7

If you've been around the hell discussion long enough, you may have heard some advocates of the Augusinian-Calvinist hellfire explain that it's not really God who will send you to hellfire or torture you forever but Satan and his demons or that God doesn't cast anyone to hell because we send ourselves there. However, these same people also often cite Luke 12, contradictingly arguing for the necessity to fear God, who allegedly may throw you into the fire to consume your flesh forever for misdeeds. Luke 12:5, along with Matthew 10:28, has been a subject of intense debate among devout Christians. Some English Bible translations reflect that view well:

> But I will warn you whom to fear: fear the **One** who, after **He** has killed, has the power to throw that person into hell; yes, I tell you, fear **Him**!
>
> NASB

Notice that "One," "Him," and "He" are capitalized, indicating the translator's theological belief that these words speak of God. The NLV takes it a step further, explicitly using the word "God":

> But I'll tell you whom to fear. Fear **God**, who has the power to kill and then throw you into hell. Yes, he's the one to fear.
>
> NLV

However, many other translations have refrained from interpreting the verse, instead adhering to the original Greek text. For instance:

> But I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear: Fear **him**, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear **him**.
>
> KJV

> But I will warn you whom ye shall fear: Fear **him**, who after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear **him**.
>
> ASV

> But I will show you whom you should fear: Fear **him** who, after your body has been killed, has authority to throw you into hell. Yes, I tell you, fear **him**.
>
> NIV

The meaning of the Greek word *τὸν (ton)* means "to/he/the" (definite article). As you can see, some translations have decided to translate the word "τὸν" in Luke 12:5 as God, while most others have kept it neutral.

The word *μετά (meta)* in verse 5, often translated as "after," can also be translated as "also" or "not only." In that case, the audience is to fear X, who can destroy not only their body but also their soul.

Context

Understanding any verse in the Bible necessitates considering its context. Luke 12 is embedded within a broader dialogue where Jesus discusses matters of the heart. In this segment, the focus is on being wise (12:1) while not being fearful (12:4,7).

The verse in question is part of a passage where Jesus exhorts his followers not to fear their persecutors. Subsequently, Jesus reassures his disciples not to live in fear (12:6-7), emphasizing God's care for them.

It seems illogical and contradictory to suggest that Jesus, having devoted this teaching to the theme of not being afraid, would simultaneously attempt to instill cosmic fear in his young Jewish disciples.

Jesus never attempted to emotionally manipulate His young followers; instead, He approached them with sincerity, compassion, and respect for their understanding. He valued the purity of their faith, teaching them with kindness rather than pressure or coercion. His message focused on love, truth, and genuine connection, free from emotional manipulation..

In verses 22-32, Jesus reiterates again his teaching not to fear, emphasizing God's care for them. Ignoring Luke 12's context has led to confusing and contradictory statements, such as the one expressed by R.C. Sproul in his commentary: *"On the one hand, we should fear Him. On the other hand, we should not fear."* [83]

What if Jesus Did Speak of God?

For the sake of argument, let's assume Jesus was speaking not of Satan or some human authority like a priest, judge, or Roman officials—as some theologians believe

—but of God. How, then, can we understand Luke 12:1-7?

Luke 12 begins with Jesus's warning against the *"leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy."* (12:1). Here, Jesus is warning against the sin of religious hypocrisy. Hypocrisy involves living a double life. On the outside, you exhibit a façade of righteousness and judge others according to religious standards you yourself don't live up to, but behind closed doors, you are filled with evil. That's why Jesus called the Pharisees *"whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside but on the inside are full of the bones of the dead and everything unclean"* (Matthew 23:27).

In Judaism, shame is regarded as equally detrimental as death, if not more so (Bava Metzia 59a). Given that Gehenna-hell was an actual geographical location historically associated with shame and still repletes with repulsive waste incinerated in fire and worms-consuming remnants—also symbolizing profound shame—it can be construed as a cautionary tale that God might expose religious hypocrisy, potentially leading individuals to a life of shame.

Long story short, you may be able to fool people but not God, who can and will expose your hypocrisy if you fail to repent. And when He does, society may turn you into an outcast. This is precisely the warning Jesus gives in verse 2:

> There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs.
>
> Luke 12:2-3

In summary, Luke 12 can be seen as a caution against the sin of hypocrisy, which has the potential to ruin one's soul and lead to being an outcast. Sin's influence extends beyond mere physical death; it can corrupt the soul.

At the national level, this was precisely Israel's fate. The religious leaders of Israel failed to turn away from their hypocrisy, resulting in the devastation of Jerusalem and the temple, followed by exile. Consequently, numerous Jews faced poverty and homelessness, forced to forage for sustenance, enduring what could be described as a literal hell.

Destroy the Soul?

Matthew 10:28 echoes the message of Jesus found in Luke 12, almost verbatim, stating:

> And do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can **destroy [*apollumi*]** both soul and body in hell [Gehenna].
>
> Matthew 10:28 (ESV)

Here, the Greek word for "destroy" is *"apollumi,"* which, according to Strong's Concordance, means *"to destroy, destroy utterly."*[84] Suppose we follow a literal interpretation of this verse and interpret it as speaking of Hellfire. In that case, the implication is not that of eternal conscious torment but rather the complete cessation of existence—both physical and spiritual annihilation. This stands in contrast to the notion of Eternal Conscious Torment, which suggests ongoing, unending suffering.

Alternative Interpretations

Some scholars suggest that verse 5 refers not to God but to the reality of evil or the social consequences of one's actions. This interpretation aligns with the broader moral and spiritual vigilance theme in Luke's Gospel. Other scholars suggest that the verse speaks of Satan. For instance, N.T. Wright argues:

> Some have seen "the one who can cast into Gehenna" as YHWH; but this is unrealistic. Jesus did not perceive Israel's God as a kindly liberal godfather who would never hurt a fly, let alone send anyone to Gehenna. But again and again—not least in the very next verse of this paragraph—Israel's God is portrayed as the creator and

> sustainer, one who can be lovingly trusted in all circumstances, not one who waits with a large stick to beat anyone who steps out of line. Rather, here we have a redefinition of the battle in terms of the identification of the real enemy. The one who can kill the body is the imagined enemy, Rome. Who, then, is the real enemy? Surely not Israel's own God. The real enemy is the accuser, the satan.[85]
>
> N.T. Wright

Another possible interpretation suggests this verse speaks of people in authority, those who can both order the killing of your body, put your memory to shame or turn you into an outcast scavenging for leftovers in the Valley of Hinnom just to survive another day. Regardless of the interpretation you feel most comfortable with, it's very unlikely that Jesus alluded to the Augustinian-Calvinist concept of Hellfire.

Fear and Trembling?

Another loved verse by fundamentalists is Philippians 2:12:

> Therefore, my dear friends, as you have always obeyed—not only in my presence, but now much more in my absence—continue to work out your salvation with **fear and trembling**.
>
> Philippians 2:12, NIV

John Bertram Phillips, most noted for his The New Testament in Modern English, wrote:

> I had for some time been worried about the expression "fear and trembling." It did not seem likely to me that Paul in writing to the Philippians could have meant literally that they were to work out their salvation in a condition of anxiety and nervousness. We all

know that fear destroys love and spoils relationships, and a great deal of the New Testament is taken up with getting rid of the old ideas of fear and substituting the new ideas of love and trust. I realized that the Greek word translated 'fear' can equally well mean 'reverence' or 'awe' or even 'respect,' but I was bothered about the 'trembling.' Surely the same Spirit who inspired Paul to write to Timothy that 'God has not given us the spirit of fear; but of power and of love and of a sound mind' could not also have meant us to live our entire lives in a state of nervous terror.... When Paul wrote to the Corinthians and reported that Titus had been encouraged and refreshed by their reception of him, he then went on to say that the Corinthian Christians received him with 'fear and trembling'! (2 Cor. 7:15) Now this makes nonsense, unless it is a purely conventional verbal form implying proper respect. [86]

Resurrection of Judgment

Jesus confirms that a day of judgment awaits, when each person will be rewarded according to what they have done:

> *Do not marvel at this, for an hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, those who have done good to the* ***resurrection of life****, and those who have done evil to the* ***resurrection of judgment****.*
>
> (John 5:28–29)

Notice that *both* groups—the righteous and the unrighteous—are resurrected. The difference lies not in whether one group is made alive again, but in the *nature* of that resurrection: *life* or *judgment*.

Resurrection of Life

Here, "life" isn't about biology, since both have been resurrected and brought back to life. Instead, *"resurrection of* ***life****"* signifies reward, honor, and greatness—what Jesus elsewhere calls being "great in the kingdom" (Matthew 5:19). The New Testament describes "life" in multiple ways: receiving treasure (Matthew 6:20), winning the race (1 Corinthians 9:24), gaining rewards (1 Corinthians 3:14), inheriting the kingdom

(Matthew 25:34), entering the kingdom (Matthew 7:21), or walking the narrow path (Matthew 7:14). These are biblical idioms and Jewish expressions that speak of spiritual blessings and achievements—depicting those who not only accepted Christ intellectually but also lived out His way with faithfulness and love.

Resurrection of Judgment

By contrast, the *"resurrection of **judgment**"* implies shame, regret, chastisement, and sanction. There's a big difference between feeling the sting of shame and condemnation when your sins come to light and facing eternal conscious torment in hellfire.

Imagine a Christian family with two young siblings returning home from summer camp. One behaved well, and everyone has nothing but praise for them; the other behaved terribly. When they walk through the door, one is met with warmth and celebration, while the other faces correction and discipline. Yet no one imagines that the parents would throw the misbehaving child into a fiery pit in the backyard.

When a child is punished for wrongdoing and feels "damned," it does not mean they are literally cast away or destroyed. It means they are being corrected within a relationship of love. If that's true about a loving parent, then why would we believe a merciful God would behave in a way that only an abusive, psychopathic parent would?

The *resurrection of judgment* represents those who failed to live according to God's ways—not a sentence to unending torture, but a form of loss. Jesus described it using culturally understood symbols like *"weeping and gnashing of teeth"* (Luke 13:28), a known Jewish/biblical idiom expressing deep remorse or jealousy (e.g., Psalm 35:16, 37:12, 112:10), much like the modern feeling of FOMO. Other terms like *"outer darkness"* (Matthew 22:13) or *"will not inherit the kingdom"* (1 Corinthians 6:9–10) don't refer to annihilation or hellfire, but to missing out on the great honor, reward, and joy of being close to God in His kingdom.

In the ancient world, living inside a kingdom's walls was a privilege reserved for the wealthy, the inheritors, and those honored by the king. Those not granted entry would remain outside after dark, missing out on the safety, light, and feasting within. *"Outer darkness"* was a Jewish metaphor for missing out on blessings (e.g.,

Deuteronomy 28:29) or being left outside the celebration—not executed or tortured, but distanced.

Likewise, Paul writes about the wicked who will be spared *"but only as through fire"* (1 Corinthians 3:15)—they suffer loss, but are not condemned forever. They are still alive, yet without honor, reward, or inheritance.

The final judgment, then, is not simply a binary verdict of paradise or inferno, but a revelation of the quality of each life—its fruit, its faithfulness, its alignment with God's love. Resurrection is God's free gift to all, but reward is to be earned and based on how we lived.

Hell in the Book of Acts

If Hellfire were real and thus most central to humanity and Jesus' mission, one might expect primary apostles like Peter and Paul to have emphasized it in their teachings. The Book of Acts, which details the founding of the Christian Church and the spread of its message throughout the Roman Empire, would logically be filled with references to hell. Surprisingly, hell is never mentioned in Acts—not even once. This absence suggests that the apostles never considered the concept a critical element of their Gospel message.

The various books of the Bible are intended to deliver distinct messages. The Book of Acts, for instance, focuses heavily on the dissemination of the gospel, as demonstrated by its documentation of the gospel being preached approximately 25 times!

Acts 2:14-41 - Peter's sermon at Pentecost
Acts 3:11-26 - Peter's sermon at Solomon's Colonnade
Acts 4:8-12 - Peter before the Sanhedrin
Acts 5:29-32 - Peter and the apostles before the Sanhedrin
Acts 7:1-53 - Stephen's speech before the Sanhedrin
Acts 8:4-8 - Philip in Samaria
Acts 8:26-40 - Philip and the Ethiopian eunuch
Acts 9:20-22 - Saul (Paul) in Damascus
Acts 10:34-43 - Peter at Cornelius' house
Acts 13:16-41 - Paul in Pisidian Antioch
Acts 14:1-7 - Paul and Barnabas in Iconium
Acts 14:8-18 - Paul and Barnabas in Lystra

Acts 16:13-15 - Paul in Philippi with Lydia
Acts 16:25-34 - Paul and Silas with the Philippian jailer
Acts 17:2-4 - Paul in Thessalonica
Acts 17:10-12 - Paul in Berea
Acts 17:22-31 - Paul in Athens at the Areopagus
Acts 18:4-11 - Paul in Corinth
Acts 19:8-10 - Paul in Ephesus
Acts 20:17-38 - Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders
Acts 22:1-21 - Paul's defense in Jerusalem
Acts 24:10-21 - Paul before Felix
Acts 26:1-29 - Paul before King Agrippa
Acts 28:23-31 - Paul in Rome

These references illustrate the widespread and varied contexts in which the early apostles shared the gospel, emphasizing its central role in the Book of Acts.

Paul, known as *"the apostle to the Gentiles"* (Romans 11:13), clearly believed that the Gospel should be proclaimed *"to the Jew first"* (Romans 1:16). This belief was evident in his practice of first seeking out the local synagogue to preach the Gospel in every Gentile city he visited (E.g., Acts 9:20, 13:5, 13:14, 14:1, 17:1-2, 18:4).

The Book of Acts documents many occasions where the apostles shared the gospel with both Jews and Gentiles. Notably, they never use the concept of hellfire as a tool for persuasion or mention it at all. For example, Peter's sermon at Pentecost in Acts 2 focuses on the resurrection of Jesus and the fulfillment of prophecy, urging for the adoption of the Christian message. Similarly, in Acts 17, Paul *"reasoned in the synagogue with both Jews and God-fearing Greeks, as well as in the marketplace day by day with those who happened to be there."* Paul's public speech at the Areopagus likewise emphasizes the nature of God, the need for repentance from pagan idols, and the resurrection of the dead, yet makes no mention of hellfire.

Walter Balfour, an 18th-century theologian, wrote:

> If Gehenna means a place of endless misery for the wicked, it is a fact that the apostles never preached it, either to Jews or Gentiles. The history of the Acts of the apostles, contains an account of their preaching for thirty years, but not once is the subject of hell or Gehenna torments, mentioned by them. They were commanded

> to preach the gospel to every creature, and they did so, but to no creature under heaven, did they ever preach this [hellfire] doctrine. No living being did they ever threaten with such a punishment. They addressed the worst of characters, but to none of them did they ever say, "How can ye escape the damnation of hell?" They did threaten men sometimes with punishment, but never with eternal punishment in hell.[87]

The central themes in the apostolic message are the resurrection of Jesus, the fulfillment of Old Testament prophecies, the call to repentance from pagan idols, the forgiveness of sins, and the promise of eternal life. The focus is on the individual and social transformative power of Jesus' resurrection and the establishment of God's kingdom on earth. For instance, in Acts 10, Peter preaches to Cornelius, a non-religious Roman Gentile centurion, and his household about Jesus' life, death, and resurrection, being Lord of all, and even mentioning forgiveness of sins through faith in Jesus, without any reference to hell.

The nonexistence of hellfire in apostolic preaching suggests that the early Christians preached a gospel different from the one that was later formed by Augustine, Calvin, and other thinkers. Instead, their original Gospel message centered on the hope and renewal found in Jesus Christ for individuals and communities alike. This is evident in passages such as Acts 13:38-39, where Paul speaks about justification through Jesus, contrasting it with the inability of the Law of Moses to justify. However, there were no threats or any mention of hellfire.

Understanding the historical and cultural context of the New Testament helps explain why hell was nonexistent in apostolic preaching. The concept of hell as a place of eternal torment evolved much later, over centuries, influenced by various cultural and theological developments. In the first-century Jewish context, the primary concerns were adherence to the Law, the coming of the Messiah, and the resurrection of the dead. The apostles addressed these concerns by presenting Jesus as the fulfillment of the Law and the prophets and by emphasizing the hope of resurrection, never mentioning hell in their preaching.

Conclusion

The Book of Acts gives us valuable insight into the early Christian message. The apostles, in their mission to spread the gospel, did not rely on the concept of hellfire to persuade their listeners. Instead, they emphasized the resurrection, forgiveness of sins, repentance from idols, and the fulfillment of God's promises. This absence suggests a focus on hope, transformation, and the realization of God's kingdom rather than fear of eternal punishment, challenging some modern interpretations of the gospel's core message.

If hellfire wasn't central to Jesus or the apostles, its origin warrants questioning. It may stem from human imagination, perhaps as a method to instill fear or, worse, as a deceptive tool that shifts attention from God's love and mercy to a fear-driven view of the Creator. The lack of hellfire in the early Christian message invites a reconsideration of its validity as a doctrine within the Christian faith.

Racing for What?

The Apostle Paul, once a Jewish Pharisee of the strictest order (Acts 26:5), was certainly familiar with the concept of an afterlife. Unlike the Sadducees (a sect of Jews active in Judea during the Second Temple period), the Pharisees believed in the resurrection of the dead. Paul is considered by many to be the Bible's most prolific and scholarly writer, with nearly half of the New Testament credited to him. However, Paul, despite dedicating thousands of words to teaching theological doctrine, did not once systematically address the concept of hellfire. It would seem that an eternal place of relentless torment would merit a dedicated portion, if not several, by such an apostle. Rather, there are only a few instances where Paul allegedly alluded to or hinted at the concept of hell, at least in the view of some preachers. Let's examine his letter to the Corinthians first.

1 Corinthians 9:24-27

> Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize? So run that you may obtain it. Every athlete exercises self-control in all things. They do it to receive a perishable wreath, but we an imperishable.
>
> 1 Corinthians 9:24

According to Calvinist preacher Tim Conway, *"What Paul is saying in these verses is this: Eternal life hangs on the way we run the race!"*[88] Likewise, according to John Piper, *"Eternal life hangs on the way we run and the way we fight."*[89]

Evidently, some may overstretch Paul's use of this analogy by reading a hellfire threat into his message. This approach risks several problematic and even bizarre outcomes.

For instance, if Paul were speaking of being saved from hellfire, it would imply he advocates for salvation based on strenuous effort rather than grace. Salvation, according to Ephesians 2:8-9, is a free gift from God through faith in Jesus Christ, not a prize earned through human effort. You work hard and compete for prizes, respect, honor, etc., not for freely given gifts, which is what salvation is. Interpreting Paul's analogy as a warning of hellfire may cause unnecessary anxiety and promote legalism, suggesting that one's salvation is contingent upon one's performance rather than God's grace. Additionally, a literal interpretation might imply that Paul believes salvation is reserved for a single individual, as he says, *"All the runners run, but **only one** receives the prize."*

Paul's True Message

Indeed, there is much to gain and lose in the Christian journey, yet it has nothing to do with hellfire. Paul's analogy is meant to encourage believers to pursue their Christian walk with the same dedication and discipline as an athlete training for a race. The focus is on striving for spiritual growth and living a life that honors God. The "prize" Paul speaks of is not to be rescued from hellfire and eternal torture but the rewards and honor that come from a life of faithful service and perseverance. Or, if using Jesus' words, *"Whoever practices and teaches these commands will be called great in the kingdom of heaven."* (Matthew 5:19).

Unfortunately, many Christians seem more concerned with securing a golden ticket into heaven and avoiding an alleged eternal cosmic toaster than actually living out their calling. If we truly love God and understand His love for us, we wouldn't be so obsessed with saving our own skins from Him. Instead, we'd focus on growing the

kingdom—not through fear tactics terrorizing people's souls, but by reflecting the love of God—not the sadomasochistic Augustinian-Calvinist god some conjured up.

Paul's emphasis on self-control and discipline reflects the importance of living out one's faith in a tangible way. However, this does not mean that eternal life is contingent upon human effort. Instead, Paul encourages believers to fully engage in their spiritual journey, aiming for the rewards that come from a life well-lived in accordance with God's will. This echoes the earlier teaching of Paul from a few chapters before: *"The one who plants and the one who waters have one purpose, and each will be rewarded according to their own labor."* (1 Corinthians 3:8). Just as running, racing, and receiving prizes are rewarded for effort, so are planting, watering, and earning wages. Thus, it is about the reward for one's work, not about avoiding neverending torture.

Racing for the "Crown of Life"

Modern cultures rarely use crowns; when they do, they're typically reserved for royalty. However, the term "crown" in the original text is "*Stephanos*," which also means "reward" or "laurel wreath." In ancient Greek Olympics, the Stephanos were given to the victors of athletic competitions.

Scripture mentions several different crowns (rewards). For instance, the *Everlasting Crown*, the *Crown for the One who Wins Souls*, the *Crown of Righteousness*, the *Crown of Glory*, and the *Crown of Life*.[90]

Thus, much like modern Olympic medals, each crown represented a reward for specific acts of service or excellence in God's Kingdom. It seems these crowns will be rewarded to believers at Christ's Judgment Seat. Hence, these crowns are not synonymous with escaping hellfire or receiving eternal life but are additional rewards for Christians who fulfill certain tasks and exhibit particular behaviors.

As an example, let's take the Crown of Life (not to be confused with "eternal life"), mentioned in James 1:12 and Revelation 2:10. This crown represents a special reward for those who persevere, especially through trials and persecutions. Revelation 2:10 reads, *"Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life."* Jesus promises

special honor to those who remain steadfast in their faith despite severe persecution or death due to their faith in him.

Conclusion

In conclusion, by employing the metaphor of a race, Paul vividly illustrates that the Christian journey requires sustained effort, self-control, and a focus on the eternal rewards that God promises to those who diligently follow Him. This perspective shifts the focus from a fear-based motivation to one of striving for greatness in God's Kingdom. Interpreting passages such as 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 as hinting at a warning of hellfire is a misreading that leads to incorrect theological assumptions with unfortunate implications on mental and emotional health. Paul's message is about the importance of dedication and discipline in the Christian life, encouraging believers to strive for spiritual rewards. Salvation remains a gift of grace, not a prize earned through human effort. Therefore, it is essential to understand Paul's analogy in its proper context, recognizing the metaphorical language used to inspire believers to live faithfully and purposefully.

Everlasting Destruction

2 Thessalonians 1:8-9 is often cited by proponents of Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) as a key passage supporting the doctrine of hellfire. However, a careful analysis of the text within its context and its numerous intertextual allusions reveals that Paul is not teaching about eternal torture in fire. Let's explore why this is the case.

> This will happen when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven in blazing fire with his powerful angels. He will punish those who do not know God and do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus. They will be punished with everlasting destruction and shut out from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of his might.
>
> 2 Thessalonians 1:7-9

At first glance, taken literally, *"punished with everlasting destruction"* appears, once again, to support the final annihilation view, not an ongoing torment in fire. However, a deeper analysis suggests a different interpretation. While we have covered some of these phrases before, I will offer a quick analysis in this chapter.

Paul's words in these verses are rich with allusions to other parts of Scripture. For instance, the imagery of Jesus being *"revealed from heaven with His mighty angels"* (2 Thessalonians 1:7) echoes similar imagery used by Jesus in Matthew 13:36-43 and Matthew 25:31-46. Both of these passages refer to the destruction of nations and

communities that ignore God's ways and neglect the needy, not to eternal torment in fire.

Additionally, when Paul writes about *"the presence of the Lord and the glory of His power,"* he likely has texts such as Isaiah 2:19-21 and Isaiah 66:15-16, 24 in view. Isaiah 2:19-21 describes people hiding from the terror of the Lord and the splendor of His majesty when He rises to shake the earth. Isaiah 66:15-16 speaks of the Lord coming in fire to execute judgment. Both passages emphasize God's judgment and the complete destruction of the wickedness from the earth, but not eternal conscious torment in the afterlife.

The phrase *"from the presence of the Lord"* is key to understanding Paul's point. The Greek term for "presence" (*prosōpou*) literally means "face." This was a specific idiom referring to the honor and majesty of God. Therefore, the destruction mentioned is linked to the violation of God's honor rather than a physical separation from His presence.

In biblical times, honor and shame were paramount cultural values. To be in the presence of the Lord (before His face) meant to be in a state of honor and approval. Conversely, to be removed from His presence signified disgrace and dishonor. Thus, Paul is talking about the consequences of dishonoring God, which leads to earthly ruin, the absence of blessings and protection, and loss of honor, not eternal fiery torment.

Temporal Consequences, Not Eternal Torment

In verse 7, Paul suggests that the judgment he speaks of will not occur in another dimension after death. Rather, *"This will happen when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven."*

Paul uses three key phrases: *"repay with tribulation," "vengeance with flaming fire,"* and *"punished with everlasting destruction."* All these phrases describe immediate consequences rather than eternal punishment in the afterlife.

1. **Repay with Tribulation:** The Greek word for tribulation (thlipsis) refers to temporal calamity or trouble in this life, not eternal suffering. It implies the immediate hardships and distress faced by those who oppose God's ways.

2. **Vengeance with Flaming Fire:** The concept of vengeance is parallel to the idea of repayment. The flaming fire represents the immediate destructive consequences of sin in this life. As seen throughout Scripture, fire often symbolizes God's purifying judgment, not eternal torment (e.g., Malachi 3:2-3, Hebrews 12:29).

3. **Punished with Everlasting Destruction:** The word "punishment" (*dikēn tisousin*) is better translated as "pay the penalty." This penalty refers to the natural outcomes of sin. The term "everlasting destruction" (*olethron aiōnon*) signifies irreversible ruin in this life. Like a car totaled in an accident or a vessel shattered on the floor, the destruction is complete and cannot be undone, but it does not imply ongoing torment in the afterlife. If it does speak of the afterlife, it would advocate for annihilation.

Paul previously used the same word translated as "destruction" in 1 Corinthians 5:5:

> Hand this man over to Satan for the **destruction** of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved on the day of the Lord.
>
> 1 Corinthians 5:5

Clearly, "destruction" for Paul indicated physical ruin in the earthly life rather than a fiery torment of the soul in the afterlife.

Figurative Language and Cultural Context

The Bible often uses fire as a symbol of God's judgment and purification. For example, Malachi 3:2-3 describes God as a refiner's fire, and Hebrews 12:29 calls God "a consuming fire." These metaphors illustrate God's purifying judgment rather than literal flames of torment.

When Paul writes about "flaming fire," he uses imagery that his readers would associate with divine judgment and purification, not eternal conscious torment in the afterlife. The destruction is both final and complete, manifesting in this life and reducing the plans and ambitions of the wicked to naught.

Paul's language aligns with other biblical passages that speak of God's judgment bringing complete and irreversible destruction. For example, Sodom and Gomorrah

were destroyed by fire as a judgment from God (Genesis 19:24-25). Jude 1:7 refers to this event as *"punishment of eternal fire,"* but Sodom and Gomorrah are not still burning today. The fire represents the complete destruction of a culture, empire, plan, or individual and the irreversible judgment they experienced.

Similarly, Paul's reference to "everlasting destruction" should be understood as a complete and final ruin of the wicked's plans and ambitions, not as an ongoing torment in fire in the afterlife. The judgment leads to a state where their actions have no lasting significance or impact.

Conclusion

In verse 4, Paul boasts *"about your perseverance and faith in all the persecutions and trials you are enduring."* Paul intended to boost the morale of the Thessalonians, often suffering from persecution, assuring them that their current trials would eventually be overcome and a promise that the persecutions would ultimately fail. Paul speaks about the temporal and irreversible consequences of rejecting God's honor and the persecution of His children. The destruction is complete and final but occurs in this life, leading to the eventual ruin of the plans and goals of those who oppose God.

Tartarus

The passage of 2 Peter 2:4-6 is ambiguous and subject to much debate, with a range of opinions and interpretations. Proponents of Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) frequently cite it as supporting evidence for the concept of hellfire. However, this interpretation has significant challenges, as the text within its context and intertextual allusions reveal a different understanding. Let's explore why Peter is not teaching about eternal torture in Hellfire.

2 Peter 2:4-6 states:

> For if God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into hell [**tartaroó**] and committed them to pits of darkness, held for judgment; and did not spare the ancient world, but protected Noah, a preacher of righteousness, with seven others, when He brought a flood upon the world of the ungodly; and if He condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to destruction by reducing them to ashes, having made them an example of what is coming for the ungodly…
>
> 2 Peter 2:4-6

Tartarus is used metaphorically to describe the gloomy, dark place where rebellious angels are held, awaiting judgment. Tartarus appears in the Septuagint translation of Job (40:20 and 41:24) and in Hellenistic Jewish literature, such as the Greek text of the ancient Book of Enoch. In Enoch, God places the archangel Uriel "*in charge of*

the world and of Tartarus" (20:2), where Tartarus is understood as the prison for 200 fallen angels.[91]

Does “Tartarus” Refer to Hellfire?

The word "Tartarus" appears only once in the New Testament, in 2 Peter 2:4, where Peter describes God’s action of casting the angels who sinned into Tartarus and delivering them in chains of darkness while they await judgment. To understand Peter’s words, it is crucial to identify the symbolism of Tartarus and the event to which Peter refers.

In Greek mythology, Tartarus is both a primordial deity and a place. As a place, it is a dungeon for the Titans, the second generation of primordial deities defeated by the Olympian gods. Some humans, like King Sisyphus and King Tantalus, were also believed to be sent to Tartarus for severe crimes.

When Peter references Tartarus, he does not endorse Greek mythology but uses familiar cultural concepts to make a point. Just as Christians today might use cultural references without endorsing their underlying ideologies, Peter uses Tartarus to illustrate the severe consequences of the angels’ rebellion without supporting the mythological details.

Peter's reference to angels bound in chains of darkness could point to two different biblical events:

1. **The Angelic Rebellion:** Some believe Peter refers to the angelic rebellion described in Isaiah 14:12-21 and Ezekiel 28:1-19.
2. **The Sons of God in Genesis 6:** Others think Peter refers to the events of Genesis 6:1-4, where the sons of God had children with the daughters of men, resulting in the Nephilim. This view is supported by 1 Peter 3:19-20 and Jude 6, which speak of spirits in prison and angels bound for their sins in Noah’s days, which Peter mentioned as well.

However, both views face a possible challenge. If all the sinful angels were bound in Tartarus, how could Jesus encounter evil spirits during His ministry, and how could Satan still be active (1 Peter 5:8)? Unless, of course, the imagery in 2 Peter 2:4 is symbolic rather than literal.

Symbolic Chains of Darkness

If the imagery in 2 Peter 2:4 is symbolic, it may refer to the fear and anticipation of judgment that immobilizes the rebellious angels. Wisdom of Solomon 17:17 describes the ninth plague of darkness in Egypt as a "chain of darkness," which is symbolic rather than literal.

Peter's description of angels bound in chains of darkness suggests they are constrained by the knowledge of impending judgment rather than physical chains. This symbolic interpretation aligns with the biblical theme of God's judgment bringing chaos and disorder back into submission.

Even if one insists on a literal interpretation, it is crucial to note that Peter's description does not include humans being sent to Tartarus. Scripture does not teach that humans will suffer in Tartarus. Therefore, Tartarus cannot be equated with the concept of hellfire as a place of eternal torment for humans.

Conclusion

2 Peter 2:4-6 does not teach about hellfire or eternal conscious torment. The dark abyss symbolizes chaos and disorder, not a place of eternal suffering. Tartarus, whether understood literally or symbolically, refers to the judgment of rebellious angels, not humans. Therefore, the notion that 2 Peter 2:4-6 supports the concept of hellfire is unfounded.

By examining the context, intertextual allusions, and symbolic language, it becomes clear that Peter is emphasizing the severe consequences of rebellion against God, not describing a place of eternal torment. This understanding aligns with the broader biblical narrative of God's judgment and the ultimate restoration of order in His creation.

Jude

The Epistle of Jude, which was written to warn of the destructive concourses of false doctrines, is often cited by the Augustinian-Calvinist Eternal Conscious Torment proponents as supporting the concept of hellfire. For instance, in John MacArthur's commentary on Jude verse 23, he claims the fire is *"the fire of hell."*[92]

However, a closer examination of the text, context, and the use of figurative language reveals that Jude is not teaching about endless torture in hellfire but rather warning against the immediate and destructive consequences of following false teachers. Let's explore this in detail.

> Now I want to remind you, though you know everything once and for all, that the Lord, after saving a people out of the land of Egypt, subsequently destroyed those who did not believe. And angels who did not keep their own domain but abandoned their proper dwelling place, these He has kept in eternal restraints under darkness for the judgment of the great day, just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them, since they in the same way as these angels indulged in sexual perversion and went after strange flesh, are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire...
>
> ...And have mercy on some, who are doubting; save others, snatching them out of the fire; and on some have mercy with fear, hating even the garment polluted by the flesh.
>
> Jude 1:5-7, 22-23

Jude 1:7 - Eternal Fire and Sodom and Gomorrah

Jude 1:7 states, *"Sodom and Gomorrah…are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire."* Are Sodom and Gomorrah still burning today? No. How, then, can Jude say they underwent a punishment of eternal fire? Because it's figurative language.

In this context, "eternal fire" represents the complete and irreversible destruction that befell these cities. It does not imply that the physical fire is still burning. As we previously covered, the term "eternal" here is used to describe the totality and finality of the judgment. The **consequences** of the destruction were permanent, but the fire itself was not.

Interestingly, in Matthew's gospel, Jesus uses the same Greek words translated as "eternal fire" (Matthew 18:8). Jesus says, *"And if your hand or your foot causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. It is better for you to enter life crippled or lame than with two hands or two feet to be thrown into the eternal fire."* Most would agree that Jesus was speaking figuratively when He talked about cutting off a hand or foot. Therefore, it only makes sense that Jesus also spoke figuratively about "eternal fire" in the same way Jude did.

The broader biblical context supports this figurative interpretation. As we previously covered, the Bible often uses fire as a symbol of God's judgment and purification, not necessarily as a literal description of eternal torment. For instance, Malachi 3:2-3 describes God as a refiner's fire, purifying the Levites. Similarly, Hebrews 12:29 calls God "a consuming fire," which speaks to His purifying and judging nature, not to literal flames.

Strange Flesh

Sodom and Gomorrah are often associated with homosexuality. However, "Strange Flesh" refers to the desire for human flesh by angels, as depicted in the story of Sodom, signifying a forbidden yearning between an angel and a human rather than sexual acts between humans. Hermeneutically, 'strange flesh' is never linked to

homosexuality in Scripture. The term 'strange' is incompatible with homosexuality, which occurs within the same gender, race, and species and is not 'foreign.' The primary sin of Sodom and Gomorrah was not idolatry or homosexuality, as these were common in many cities. Instead, it was the intent to interact with visiting angels. In Genesis 6, angels sought human flesh; in Sodom, humans sought the 'strange' flesh of angels. This is why Sodom is associated with angels in the New Testament and why it was punished so severely. This distinction is crucial for the context of the angel's "eternal restraints," preventing them from once again interacting with humans.

Jude speaks of angels in the context of false teachers to illustrate the severity of rebellion against God. Just as the rebellious angels were judged and punished, false teachers will also face judgment for leading others astray. The connection underscores the consequences of abandoning God's truth.

Jude's references to fire and eternal fire are metaphorical, highlighting the destructive consequences of false teachings and immoral behavior. These passages warn of immediate, permanent, earthly destruction rather than eternal torture. The figurative use of language is consistent with the broader biblical context, emphasizing God's judgment and purification rather than eternal torment. Therefore, Jude does not teach about hellfire but about the serious, immediate consequences of straying from the truth.

Jude 1:23 - Snatching from the Fire

With that context in mind, in Jude 1:23, we read, *"Save others by snatching them out of the fire."* If this were speaking of an individual's salvation from hellfire, then it would place the responsibility on people, not God, to save from hellfire, which contradicts the central message of the Bible about salvation being solely a work of God.

Here, *"saving"* means rescuing people from the destructive consequences of following false teachers (Jude 1:4, 11). The phrase *"snatching them out of the fire"* is metaphorical, suggesting the act of rescuing individuals from a dangerous or perilous situation—namely, the **false doctrines** that threaten their faith and spiritual well-being. This metaphor indicates that the people being "saved" are in a hazardous state that could lead to severe negative consequences in their earthly lives. They are not

being saved from an afterlife situation but from an immediate effect on their lives—false teachings that will devastate their lives. In a way, this also represents the purpose of the book.

For example, consider a loved one being misled by harmful teachings and consequently joining a cult that could ruin their life. You can rescue that friend from the grips of the cult, much like pulling someone out of a fire.

A modern example of this could be the prosperity gospel, where individuals lose their life savings to charlatans promising financial blessings in exchange for donations. This "fire" is not about eternal damnation but false teachings' immediate, destructive impact.

The Book of Life

Revelation is a book steeped in symbolism and metaphor, written in the apocalyptic genre. It features descriptions of beasts, dragons, flying horses, and other imagery that first-century readers would not have interpreted literally. The apocalyptic genre is characterized by vivid imagery and symbolic language meant to convey deeper spiritual truths rather than literal descriptions.

Revelation 3:5: Being Blotted Out of the Book of Life

> He who overcomes shall be clothed in white garments, and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life; but I will confess his name before My Father and before His angels.
>
> Revelation 3:5

This verse has caused much anxiety among Christians, as it appears to imply that Jesus might blot out names already written in the Book of Life, suggesting a loss of eternal life and torture in hellfire. This statement is made to the church in Sardis, indicating that those who overcome will be clothed in white garments, and their names will not be blotted out of the Book of Life.

What is the Book of Life?

In the Hebrew Scriptures, the "Book of the Living" lists those presently alive on the earth, whether righteous or wicked (Exod. 32:32-33; Deut. 29:20; Ps. 69:28; Isa. 4:3).

The Book of Life/Living is mentioned in the Bible in three ways:

1. **The Book of the Living:** Psalm 69:28.
2. **The Book of Life:** Philippians 4:3; Revelation 3:5; 20:12, 15.
3. **The Lamb's Book of Life:** Revelation 13:8; 21:27.

Whether discussing the Book of Life or the Lamb's Book of Life, the fundamental point remains that those whose names are written in these books are alive. Different interpretations exist about whether these are two separate books or one single book with varying functions. One interpretation suggests the Book of Life lists everyone who is alive, while the Lamb's Book of Life lists those who will receive great honor. Another interpretation is that there is only one Book of Life.

In John's time, many towns, including Sardis, had citizenship rosters listing the names of their citizens. When a person died, their name was removed from the roster. Additionally, if a person committed severe crimes and brought great shame upon the town, they might also be removed from the roster.

A critical point is that Scripture does teach about names being blotted out of the Book of Life, but this does not refer to losing eternal life. To be an overcomer, one must faithfully love, serve, and honor Jesus throughout their life. The promise to never remove an overcomer's name from the Book of Life symbolizes a tribute of great honor and respect. It indicates that those who faithfully serve Him will receive special recognition. However, this does not mean that those who fail to overcome will be tortured in hellfire or lose their eternal life. Likewise, Sardis boasted of her trade in woolen goods and dyed fabrics. In ancient times, *"white garments"* connoted honor, festivity, and victory. White robes (or garments) symbolize respect, honor, and tribute.

Litotes in Revelation 3:5

Since Jesus taught that eternal life can never be lost (John 3:15-18; 4:10-14; 5:24;

6:35-40; 10:28-29; 11:25-26; et al.), it is best to understand the words, *"and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life"* (3:5), as a figure of speech called a litotes. Litotes is an understatement in which a positive affirmation is expressed by negating the opposite. For example, saying, "I will not stop loving my wife as long as she makes me ice cream," does not mean I will stop loving her if she does not make ice cream. It emphasizes my love for her, with the ice cream being an added delight.

Similarly, when Jesus says He will not blot out the names of those who overcome from the Book of Life, He uses an image the recipients are already familiar with to emphasize the special honor and blessings for those who remain faithful. This does not imply that those who fail to overcome will be tortured in fire forever.

The Lake of Fire, Sulfur and Smoke

Very little in the book of Revelation could be interpreted literally. While it is crucial to read and study the book thoroughly, appreciating its language, imagery, and themes, it is equally important to recognize the book's genre and that almost every element in Revelation is steeped in references to Hebrew Scriptures, first-century culture, and Roman politics. For instance, Revelation tells of a massive red dragon with seven heads, a beast rising from the sea, having ten horns and seven heads, locusts with human faces, four colorful flying horses, and two witnesses with fire coming out of their mouths burning up their enemies. Interpreting these images literally may result in bizarre conclusions. Similarly, we ought to view depictions such as a lake of fire and sulfur not necessarily as tangible or actual locations but the way the original recipients understood them—as metaphors.

Lake of Fire = The Dead Sea

During the First-Temple period, what we now know as 'the Dead Sea' or 'the Sea of Salt' was sometimes called the Lake of Fire,[93] or the Fiery Lake.[94] This historical context is vital for understanding the symbolic meanings behind Revelation's "lake of fire and sulfur" imagery.

For thousands of years, up to the first century, the Dead Sea was known for its regular eruptions that discharged tar, pitch, bitumen, asphaltites, smoke, sulfur, and

flames. Consequently, the Greeks named it "Lake Asphaltites" due to these fiery, asphalt-spewing occurrences. [95]

Philo said that the valley of the Dead Sea was filled with fires, which were very difficult to extinguish, and that many of these fires had been smoking and burning for a very long time. [96]

The first-century geographer Strabo named the valley *"a land of fires"* because there were frequent boiling outbursts of fire in the region, and the entire area smelled of sulfur and brimstone. [97]

It is common to witness individuals from all over the world, afflicted with various skin conditions, flocking to the Dead Sea, the lowest point on Earth's surface. They are attracted by its waters, rich in minerals such as sulfur and renowned for their healing and purifying qualities. Submerging in the Dead Sea's waters may feel like dipping in fire, as it can often be intensely painful, especially if the water enters your eyes or if you have a skin condition or even a tiny cut. However, it also has remarkable healing properties that are worth the pain. [98]

In Judaism, the lake was traditionally viewed as a place where sinful objects could be cast away. According to the Talmud, *"Any vessels that had on them the image of the sun, or of the moon, or of a dragon, 'let them cast them into the salt sea.'"* [99] Similar to Christianity, Judaism associates baptism in the Mikvah (pool of water) with the purification from sin. It is believed that a Jew *"...immerse in the Mikvah...[it] helps him to do Teshuva and purify himself from his sins."* [100]

In Jewish thought, water is often associated with purification. The ritual bath of Mikvah is a prime example of how immersion in water symbolizes spiritual cleansing in Judaism. Connecting the dots, we can argue that since the Dead Sea is a pool of salty water, it can serve as a metaphor for purification by painful baptism, where sin and impurity are left behind in the symbolic "dead" waters.

Revelation 20:10

> The Devil who deceived them was thrown into the lake of fire and sulfur, where the beast and the false prophet are also. They will be tormented day and night forever and ever.

Revelation 20:10

Some Bible translations depict the Lake of Fire as the most terrifying place imaginable—a realm of eternal torture in fire.

No one in ancient Israel would have imagined a lake like Lake Michigan, which is about 22,400 sq mi in size. Rather, the largest lake in Israel is called, quite amusingly, the Sea of Galilee, which is about 64 sq mi. Therefore, the Lake of Fire should not be understood as an enormous lava lake encompassing billions of individuals in it. If anything, it's more likely the Apostle John refers not to a lake at all but a small pool of molten metal akin to a crucible.

The Greek term "*limné*," translated as "lake," can refer to a pond of any size, suggesting a small pool of molten metal akin to what one would find in a refiner's crucible rather than an expansive lake of lava.

Undoubtedly, for a Jew, the mention of fire and sulfur evokes the biblical imagery of Sodom and Gomorrah: *"Then the Lord rained on Sodom and Gomorrah* ***sulfur*** *and* ***fire*** *from the Lord out of heaven."* (Genesis 19:24). However, consider the future hope presented in Ezekiel in light of the events of Genesis 19:

> When I bring back their captives, the captives of Sodom and her daughters, and the captives of Samaria and her daughters, then I will also bring back the captives of your captivity among them.
>
> Ezekiel 16:53-55

Evidently, Ezekiel perceived the final outcomes of God's judgment on Sodom in a very positive light.

In ancient times, fire and sulfur symbolized the gold refining process, essentially a crucible of molten gold with sulfur added to remove impurities. Sulfur, or brimstone, has been used in metal refining since ancient times.[101] One significant use of sulfur in ancient metal refining involved its ability to convert unwanted metals into sulfides. These sulfides would then react and smoke, allowing the purer metals, such as gold, to settle at the bottom of the crucible. This method was effective in removing impurities from the metal, enhancing its purity and value.[102]

This fact is also evident in biblical texts such as Revelation 3:18, where Christ advises, *"I counsel you to buy from me gold refined by fire,"* using the imagery of gold refined in fire while admonishing the church in Laodicea.

In modern times, sulfur's role in industrial processes remains vital. For instance, sulfur is a key component in the production of sulfuric acid, which is crucial for numerous industrial applications, including fertilizer production, petroleum refining, and chemical manufacturing. The United States Mint and other modern facilities continue to utilize sulfur in these processes to ensure the purity of metals used in coin production and other applications. Sulfer also has other uses, including medical treatment for certain skin diseases (a popular method for treating infections up until the 1940s), insecticides and fungicides, glass production, and other kinds of refinements.[103]

In ancient perceptions, fire and sulfur, though painful, were considered positive and beneficial elements, rather than the Middle Ages' view of them as symbols of sadistic punishment and eternal tomentous abuse.

The word "torment" in scriptures is translated from the Greek *basanizó*, which originally referred to a touchstone—a black, silicon-based stone used to test the purity of precious metals. Thus, the term should be understood not as torture but as a (perhaps very unpleasant) process of testing purity and refinement.

Further, the Greek words translated as *"forever and ever"* are sometimes also translated—and perhaps better rendered as—*"in the ages of ages,"* indicating a future period of time, not the modern philosophical concept of "eternity," one which is absent from the Bible, as we previously established.

Revelation 14:10-11

Revelation 14:10-11 reads:

> They, too, will drink the wine of God's fury, which has been poured full strength into the cup of his wrath. They will be tormented with burning sulfur in the presence of the holy angels and of the Lamb.

> And the smoke of their torment will rise for ever and ever. There will be no rest day or night for those who worship the beast and its image, or for anyone who receives the mark of its name.
>
> Revelation 14:10-11

Revelation 14:10 notes that the torment received by certain people occurs *"in the presence of the holy angels and in the presence of the Lamb"* (Jesus). This raises an intriguing question: Does the presence of Jesus and the angels, possibly symbolic of the church's spirits as suggested in Revelation 1:20, mean that the tormented are only suffering when in their presence? It seems unlikely that heavenly entertainment would include sadistically witnessing the suffering and burning of others, as this contradicts the idea of restful peace described in Revelation 14:13.

Instead, it seems that John is indicating that the torment experienced by these individuals is linked to their allegiance to the beast and its image. The presence of Jesus and his righteous assembly becomes a source of agony for them because it confronts their actions and beliefs. This idea is supported by Revelation 11:10, where the preaching and mere presence of the two witnesses tormented those opposed to their message. The torment, then, appears to be metaphorical—an internal conflict and spiritual anguish experienced by those confronted with the righteousness and truth of Jesus.

Then, the description of smoke rising forever and ever is a vivid metaphor emphasizing the finality and completeness of God's judgment. A smoked sacrifice means that the sacrificed animal will not stand up and run again.

Revelation serves as a warning against idolatry and rebellion and stresses God's justice but does not necessarily imply unending suffering in the afterlife. The focus is on the lasting consequences of rejecting God's ways rather than perpetual afterlife torment.

Revelation 20:14

> Then Death and Hades were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death.
>
> Revelation 20:14

If the Lake of Fire were a place of eternal torment, it would be illogical and nonsensical to cast abstract concepts (Death and Hades) into it. The fact that intangible, abstract concepts or powers such as Death and Hadēs are cast into the Lake of Fire strongly indicates that the Lake of Fire itself is also an intangible, abstract concept. Metaphorically, the Lake of Fire—or God's purifying judgment—overcomes even death and the Grave. In other words, death and Hades are destroyed—there is no more death. This more closely aligns with the notion of a benevolent God.

The second death signifies the ultimate defeat of death itself, aligning with 1 Corinthians 15:26, where death is described as the last enemy to be destroyed. The term "second death" indicates the finality of this destruction. The context suggests a symbolic representation of the complete eradication of death rather than a cosmic ongoing process of abuse and torture.

The casting of Death and Hades into the lake of fire symbolizes the end of their power and influence. It represents the culmination of God's redemptive plan, where death is swallowed up in victory (1 Corinthians 15:54). The second death is not about eternal suffering but about the ultimate triumph of the God of Life (Genesis 2:7, Job 33:4, Acts 17:25, John 1:3-4, Psalm 36:9) and the eradication-through-transformation of everything that opposes Him. The *second death* is where death dies.

Yes, God is the God of Justice and the Lord of Hosts (1 Samuel 1:3), but He is also rich in mercy (Ephesians 2:4) and Mighty to Save (Zephaniah 3:17). Human kings and generals kill and destroy, but the God of Israel also restores and resurrects. Death is not the end. Death, too, will be cast into the purifying Lake of Fire and Sulfur.

Revelation 21:8

> But as for the cowardly, the faithless, the detestable, as for murderers, the sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars, their portion will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulfur, which is the second death.

Revelation 21:8 again mentions the lake that burns with fire and sulfur, calling it the second death. Death represents finality, marking the end or conclusion rather than an unending ordeal. The inclusion of fire and sulfur reinforces the idea of purification. The list of sins mentioned (cowardice, faithlessness, etc.) are behaviors that lead to destruction and chaos in life. This is not to suggest that cowards will be tortured forever. The second death symbolizes the final eradication of these destructive behaviors through purification. The focus is on the ultimate defeat of sin, not eternal torment. The use of "death" emphasizes the end or termination of these negative influences, aligning with the broader biblical narrative of renewal and restoration. The use of "death" (end, concluded, ceased) rather than perpetual suffering indicates an end to the destructive influence of these behaviors. Remember the promise from just four verses earlier:

> He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away.
>
> Revelation 21:4

The only way to completely eliminate mourning and crying is either to erase and flash everyone's memories (Men in Black) so they don't remember their loved ones or to reconcile everything and everyone, which is only something truly omnipotent (all-powerful) and omnibenevolent (all-loving) God can accomplish. Therefore, the second death is portrayed as a necessary step in the divine process of eradicating

evil and purifying creation. The lake of fire serves as a divine crucible, purging sin and restoring holiness. This interpretation aligns with the biblical theme of God's judgment being restorative rather than merely punitive.

Satan, Saved?!

Deciding the fate of Satan is definitely not in my pay grade. However, many theologians and Church Fathers' views on Satan's salvation present a fascinating and controversial aspect of early Church theology. For example, Gregory of Nyssa, a saint in Eastern Orthodoxy, Catholicism, Oriental Orthodoxy, Anglicanism, and Lutheranism, is noted for his belief in all-inclusive salvation, a doctrine known as *apokatastasis* (literally translates to "restoration" or "reconstitution," implying a return to an original or proper condition). This concept suggests that all of creation, including Satan, will ultimately be restored and reconciled to the almighty God.

Gregory of Nyssa argued that since God is the ultimate source of all good and is infinitely loving and just, the ultimate purpose of God's punishments must be corrective rather than purely punitive. He believed that the process of purification would eventually lead to the repentance and redemption of all beings, including the Devil. This perspective stems from his understanding of divine justice and love, which he saw as incompatible with the idea of endless, purposeless torture.

This view was rooted in Gregory's interpretation of scripture and his reflections on the nature of God and evil. He saw the fire of divine judgment not as a literal fire of eternal torment but as a purifying fire meant to cleanse and transform. Therefore, even Satan, the embodiment of evil, would not be exempt from this ultimate purification and restoration.

There's much to debate and scrutinize. You might reject the idea that Satan can be redeemed, or perhaps you question his very existence. You might contest the idea that hell is essential for purification or dispute Gregory's interpretation of the Ransom Theory of Atonement, which influenced Christianity for a millennium. Yet, Gregory's theories stem from a fundamental belief about God: that He is not only just but also loving, kind, good, forgiving, compassionate, and gracious—even to sinners (Matthew 5:45).

Gregory argued that God created humanity not out of necessity but from a place of overflowing love, and His motives for wanting to restore His creation are similarly driven.

Embracing the concept of all-inclusive reconciliation held by some of the Church Fathers is challenging, and to be honest, from an emotional standpoint, as a Jewish individual reflecting on the atrocities committed by individuals like Hitler against our people, it's not easy for me to comprehend this concept. Yet, I recognize God is much more gracious and loving than I will ever be! Therefore, reflecting on Gregory's perspectives can be valuable and much better reflects God's character than the concept of eternal torment in Hellfire, which seems at odds with the notion of a loving, kind, benevolent, forgiving, compassionate, and gracious God.

Conclusion

The original audience would have most likely understood fire, sulfur, brimstone, smoke, and imagery of torment (testing of metals) as metaphors for purification, corrective judgment, and eradicating evil, not eternal conscious torment in Hellfire. Additionally, the cultural context of the early Christians, who were familiar with Jewish apocalyptic literature, would have led them to interpret these symbols in line with themes of divine justice, discipline, restoration, and renewal.

In summary, the lake of fire and sulfur appears to indicate a metaphorical refiner's crucible with sulfur, tested for purity. The process is one of refinement, not eternal torment. It embodies divine judgment, potentially letting wrongdoers feel the pain they inflicted while ultimately being saved—even if *"as one escaping through the flames"*—reflecting the principle that mercy prevails over judgment: *"Where sin increased, grace increased all the more"* (Romans 5:20).

The Augustinian Fallacy

Much of the confusion surrounding the mistranslation and misunderstanding of *olam* and *aion* as "endless" or "everlasting" time can be traced to the influence of Augustine of Hippo (354–430). Under the sway of Neoplatonic philosophy,[104] Augustine reasoned that because God is infinite and timeless, all divine actions—including punishment—must also be infinite, timeless, and without end.

That philosophical move did not arise from the Hebrew Scriptures or the Jewish worldview of Jesus and the apostles. It was a metaphysical assumption imported into the text, one that collapsed the biblical idea of age into the Greek concept of timeless eternity—and in doing so, permanently reshaped Western theology's understanding of judgment.

Neoplatonism

Neoplatonism is a philosophical and mystical development of Plato's thought that arose in the 3rd century CE, primarily through the work of Plotinus. It teaches that the human soul can ascend back to divine unity through contemplation and purification.[105] Unlike Plato's conversational style, Neoplatonism systematized his ideas into a structured metaphysical hierarchy, merging Greek philosophy with spiritual thought.

Augustine encountered Plotinus' ideas through Latin translations of Plotinus' works. Modern scholarship emphasizes how deeply Augustine was shaped by Plotinus' Neoplatonism. For example, the Brill monograph describes Plotinus as Augustine's *"most important non-biblical source."*[106]

Thus, it is widely agreed that Neoplatonism profoundly shaped early Western Christian theology through the work of Augustine of Hippo.[107]

Augustine of Hippo

Here is something most Christians are never told: Augustine of Hippo, the single most influential theologian in Western Christianity, was one of the few major Church Fathers who was functionally illiterate in both Hebrew and Greek. He relied almost entirely on Latin translations—translations that often flattened Hebrew imagery and altered Greek nuance. As a result, key metaphors, idioms, and cultural assumptions that would have been obvious to Jews of the biblical world were lost to him.

Having spent most of his life in North Africa—primarily in what is now Algeria and Tunisia—Augustine was largely unfamiliar with the Jewish worldview, its symbols, metaphors, and modes of thought that shaped both the Hebrew Scriptures and the teaching of Jesus and the New Testament. Yet his interpretations, filtered through Latin language and Neoplatonic philosophy, would go on to define Western theology for centuries.

This is not a small detail. Imagine a scholar in Ecuador reading a Spanish translation of Sophocles' Antigone and then building an entire philosophical system on misunderstood metaphors and mistranslated words. Now imagine that these misinterpretations become, a thousand years later, the doctrinal foundation for major branches of a world religion.

That is precisely what happened with Augustine. His interpretation of "hell" as eternal conscious torment—a concept foreign to Second Temple Judaism and the earliest Christian schools of theology—shaped the early Catholic understanding of hell. Centuries later (16th century), ECT was picked up by two towering Reformers: John Calvin and Martin Luther. Catholics themselves, they continued to embrace most of Augustine's theological beliefs—even after the Reformation—without returning to the Jewish worldview, likely because they were both highly anti-Semitic as well.[108] (You're invited to learn more about the deep antisemitism of both Calvin and especially Luther in my book, ***"Why Don't Jews Believe in Jesus."***)

The New World of Protestant Puritanism

Crossing into the New World, the American Puritan preacher Jonathan Edwards (18th century) intensified this inherited framework to its darkest extreme, giving America its most terrifying sermon: *Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God.* In it, God becomes a cosmic executioner, forever dangling humanity over blazing flames—a sickening image shaped far more by Augustine's mistranslations than by the Hebrew Scriptures or the teachings of Jesus.

Based both on linguistic misunderstandings and theological fallacies (largely caused by Neoplatonism), Augustine concluded that hell—understood by him as a very literal, fiery place—was "eternal" in the strictest sense: without end, without mercy, and without corrective purpose beyond retribution. In his view, punishment wasn't meant to purify or restore, but simply to punish again and again. Forever. This marked a major departure from the more Jewish understanding of divine justice, grace, and the purpose of hell, which saw correction and restoration as integral to judgment.

Augustine's view of hellfire as eternal conscious torment has haunted Western theology—namely Catholic and Protestant traditions—ever since.

However, Augustine's argument commits several errors in reasoning known as "logical fallacies." [109]

Augustine's Logical Fallacies

Put more precisely, Augustine of Hippo's argument rests on two fundamental logical errors.

First, **the fallacy of equivocation**: he collapses God's infinite nature into the finite reality of creation, treating human sin and historical judgment as though they must share the same ontological properties as God Himself.

Second, **the fallacy of false analogy**: he assumes that because God's love—as a divine attribute—is infinite, His punishments—as divine actions—must also be infinite in the same way. But attributes and actions are not identical, and Scripture never treats them as such.

Even in Augustine's own time, this interpretation was far from universally accepted. The Eastern and Oriental Orthodox traditions preserved a far more nuanced vision of time, judgment, and divine mercy—one that resisted collapsing biblical language into abstract metaphysics. That distinction remains alive to this day. One well-known Orthodox theologian puts it this way:

> Hell appears in the shadow of the cross as what has always already been conquered, as what Easter leaves in ruins, to which we may flee from the transfiguring light of God if we so wish, but where we can never finally come to rest—for, being only a shadow, it provides nothing to cling to (as Gregory of Nyssa so acutely observes). Hell exists, so long as it exists, only as the last terrible residue of a fallen creation's enmity to God, the lingering effects of a condition of slavery that God has conquered universally in Christ and will ultimately conquer individually in every soul. This age has passed away already, however long it lingers on in its own aftermath, and thus in the Age to come, and beyond all ages, all shall come home to the Kingdom prepared for them from before the foundation of the world.[110]
>
> (David Bentley Hart)

What Augustine Got Wrong About God's Nature

Augustine is regarded as a saint in some traditions, but even saints often get things wrong. In his case, it was his understanding—or misunderstanding—of God's nature.

Before God created time and space, there was no time at all. God's life, therefore, is not *quantitative* but *qualitative*. He does not exist for an infinite number of days along some endless timeline, because time itself did not exist prior to creation.

God cannot die not because He has accumulated unlimited time, but because He is immortal by nature—unaffected by sin or death, perfect, self-sufficient, and unchanging in who He is. His immortality flows from His very being, not from the length of His existence.

Likewise, in the resurrection, we will receive a new body that is immortal and life that is imperishable. We will no longer be vulnerable to sickness, aging, or death. We will become like God in the sense that nothing can destroy us:

> *When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable... then the saying that is written will come true: "Death has been swallowed up in victory."*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:54)

Eternal life, then, is not about living endless days. That is only a byproduct—a side effect. In its truest sense, eternal life is about sharing in a kind of life like God's own: a life that is untouchable by death, incorruptible by sin, and ultimately indestructible.

Conclusion: Think Like a Hebrew, Not a Greek

In conclusion, Augustine's Neoplatonically shaped interpretation of *olam* and *aion* introduced a rigid, endless view of divine punishment into Western Christianity that departed sharply from the restorative justice envisioned in Jewish thought and preserved in some Eastern/Orthodox traditions. By equating God's infinite nature with infinite retribution, Augustine committed logical and linguistic errors that gave rise to the Western doctrine of eternal conscious torment. Yet the biblical and Jewish tradition reminds us that eternity is not about endless duration but about the quality of incorruptible life in God—a life that conquers death, restores creation, and embodies the victory of resurrection rather than the permanence of punishment.

To understand *eternal life* is to stop thinking like a Greek philosopher or a modern engineer and start thinking more like a Hebrew prophet and a Jewish rabbi. The

Bible's vision of life is not primarily concerned with endless time but with blessedness, wholeness, closeness to God, and victory over death—**immortality**.

For us now—His disciples—eternal life is knowing God. It is living abundantly now (and forever) because nothing—not even death—can separate us from His love.

This is eternal life: life that reflects God's glory, shares His joy, and dwells in His presence with an immortal body.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of God's Character

If an alien spent five minutes on social media today, he wouldn't be surprised to discover that there are roughly 49,000 Christian groups and sects worldwide, since they rarely agree on much—especially on doctrines of salvation. But if one's afterlife fate hinges on solving a theological puzzle that Christians themselves can hardly agree on, then salvation begins to resemble not a gift of grace but a cruel game of cosmic Russian roulette.

Such a vision portrays God not as a loving Father, but as the architect of something disturbingly close to an abusive experiment.

I will now present three theological arguments against the doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Divine Guardianship

God is our guardian because He created us, knows us, and sustains our every breath. We are under His responsibility. Like a faithful shepherd, He watches over what is His own—not from obligation, but from love. We are not self-made or forgotten; we are held, protected, and guided by the One who gave us life.

Christians often use the analogy of God as a loving father. But let's put this to the test.

A good parent teaches, nurtures, and corrects their child. Even if a child rebels, a loving parent does not abuse them by burning them in the fire or casting them into a torture chamber to suffer forever. If God is truly a better father than any human (Matthew 7:11), why would He operate by standards we would find abusive in any human relationship?

If we, as imperfect human beings, would never burn our own children alive for disobedience (unless we are psychopaths), how can we believe that a God of infinite love and mercy would commit something infinitely worse?

Even earthly parents know that when children misbehave, correction should be temporary and purposeful—aimed at growth. But punishment designed only to inflict endless suffering? That is not justice. That is cruelty. If hell truly meant infinite torment with no chance of healing or change, then it would serve no purpose except to gratify divine sadism. Yet Scripture teaches that God's justice is restorative, not vengeful; His love corrects, heals, forgives enemies, and seeks reconciliation. Unending torture accomplishes none of this.

This is the great divide between religion's gospel of fear and the true Gospel of a God who is, in every way, mighty to save. If the primary purpose of human life is simply to avoid eternal conscious torment, then something is profoundly wrong with how we have imagined both God and ourselves. Life becomes a fearful escape room contest, not a meaningful journey; faith becomes anxiety, not transformation.

For what kind of loving God would torment most of humanity forever with no redemptive goal? Why would the One who commands us to forgive without limit (Matthew 5:44; Luke 17:4) refuse to forgive His own offspring and image? And how could infinite punishment be fair for finite beings—fragile minds shaped by trauma, culture, fear, misinformation, and distortion?

If God is a loving Father, then His justice must look like love. And if He created us with limited understanding, why assume that once we stand before Him—seeing clearly for the first time—we would not see, understand, repent, and turn to Him freely?

A theology built on fear collapses under its own contradictions. A theology built on love, restoration, and the character of Christ is the only one that makes sense of Scripture—and the human heart.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Redemptive Grace

We love to sing songs about the sweetness of God's amazing grace, but do we truly understand what grace means?

Human revenge is driven by emotion, which is why many find a dark comfort—and even a perverse satisfaction—in the idea of a monstrous god who tortures their enemies forever. The doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment doesn't reflect divine grace—it mirrors human vindictiveness. It satisfies something dark in us: the desire not just for justice, but for payback. For some, hell becomes a way of saying, "They may have hurt me here on earth, but one day, my God will make them suffer far worse—forever!"

But that's not grace. Punishing the wicked doesn't bring back the innocent whose lives were lost. No matter how severe the consequences, they cannot restore what the wrongdoers have taken away. How would torturing a million Germans bring my lost Jewish family members back to me? Only the true Gospel offers genuine hope—not endless retribution, but the restoration of all things—I will get to see them again!

Eternal Conscious Torment provides a sense of emotional satisfaction rooted in a revenge fantasy disguised with religious rhetoric. It allows people to hold onto bitterness while feeling righteous about it. Instead of confronting the hard work of forgiveness, healing, and grace, Eternal Conscious Torment gives them a theology that says infinite punishment is justice for those who've hurt them.

But this is not the heart of God revealed in Jesus. It is the projection of our pain onto the divine, creating a god in our own broken image.

No amount of revenge will ever bring back a lost loved one. The eternal torment of others cannot undo *your* grief or heal *your* broken heart. If you've lost someone, no amount of revenge can heal your heart. Only Christ offers something truly redemptive: resurrection of those you've lost! He will raise everyone to life again. Every tear will be wiped away. No more death. No more trauma. No pain will last forever.

The deepest wounds of history will not be ignored—they will be healed and made new. (Revelation 21:5). That's God's grace to us.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Corrective Justice

A loving punishment meant to guide and correct, aiming not to break but to heal and restore.

God's discipline is not born out of rage, but out of love—a refining fire. True punishment is not about infinite vengeance, but about correction, healing, and restoration. Like a good Father, God disciplines His children not to break them, but to bring them back—whole, humble, and transformed.

However, Eternal Conscious Torment serves no redemptive purpose. It doesn't teach, restore, reconcile, or bring justice. It doesn't educate or discipline. It is cruelty for cruelty's sake. The hellfire doctrine reduces the Augustinian-Calvinistic god to a sadistic psychopath who delights in the meaningless suffering of others—a doctrine that numbs many Christians' sense of empathy.

Consider this: most of humanity is shaped from birth by cultural indoctrination. People often sin out of fear, weakness, ignorance, trauma, survival, mental illness, or flawed perceptions. It is their *sin* that needs to be eliminated—not them!

A true Christian heart should ache at the thought of God eternally tormenting most of humanity. Yet many in the West passionately defend this grotesque doctrine with a distorted, Romanized view of justice. Test your own heart: If you find yourself clinging to the idea that unending suffering is somehow "righteous," then your understanding of God's justice is severely warped.

In the Hebrew Scriptures,[111] fire is often used to describe God's justice—not as a tool of sadism, but as a force of refinement and purification. Fire refines gold, burns away impurities, and prepares something to be made new. In this context, divine fire isn't about perpetual abuse—it's about healing what's broken, cleansing what's defiled, and restoring what's been lost:

> *I will put them into the fire; I will refine them like silver and test them like gold. They will call on my name, and I will answer them; I will say, "They are my people," and they will say, "The LORD is our God."*
>
> (Zechariah 13:9)

Infinite punishment for finite sins is neither just nor merciful. A crime committed in a human lifespan cannot deserve infinite, unending torture—that is not justice; it is sadism. The Augustinian-Calvinist hellfire overrides not only redemptive justice but also grace and mercy entirely—for they mean the offering of redemption, restoration, and forgiveness to the *undeserving*.

On the other hand, a *temporary* judgment serves a purpose. And if that purpose is not sadistic but loving—then by simple logic it must be *restorative*. Any punishment that comes to an end implies that something has been accomplished: purification, repentance, healing, or transformation. Therefore, even those who undergo judgment will ultimately be restored, because a finite correction can only make sense if it leads to a greater good. That's true, restorative justice.

This is not sentimentality—it's biblical logic grounded in the nature of God:

> *His anger lasts only a moment, but His favor lasts a lifetime.*
>
> (Psalm 30:5)

> *For no one is cast off by the Lord forever. Though he brings grief, he will show compassion, so great is his unfailing love.*
>
> (Lamentations 3:31-32)

The doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment has nothing to do with God's justice. God's discipline is not unending, and His justice is always intertwined with His love. If hell has an end, its purpose is not to indulge a psychopath's sadistic desire for revenge, but to bring about redemptive justice. Torturing someone forever—

even when disguised in religious language and framed as "doctrine"—doesn't make anything right; it's simply the product of a sadist's imagination.

Gladly, some ancient theologians, like St. Isaac the Syrian, grasped this truth: *"Those who are tormented in hell are tormented by the invasion of love... It is absurd to assume that the sinners in hell are deprived of God's love."*[112]

Early Church Fathers of the first and second centuries—among them the theologian, St. Clement of Alexandria—held that because the image of God is present in every human being, all people will ultimately be restored to God. This restoration, however, was not imagined as cheap or automatic; it involved a purifying process by which sin is stripped away from what God created good.

This hopeful view of universal restoration prevailed throughout the first three centuries, lasting until the time of Augustine. The belief was that God's redemptive work in Christ would ultimately heal, restore, and reconcile all people, bringing the entire creation back into harmony with God like it was before the fall.

To deny such a hope would imply that God condemns His own image—that He consigns to endless ruin what bears His likeness. In other words, it would mean God condemns, forever, something of Himself that He placed within every person.

Conclusion

In the end, the question is not how far God is willing to punish, but how far His love is willing to go. The God revealed in Jesus does not save by fear, nor rule by terror, but heals by truth, patience, and mercy that refuses to let go. Hope is not naïve—it is faithful to the character of God. And if love is stronger than death, wiser than wrath, and more enduring than sin, then the story of humanity does not end in despair, but in restoration, light, and a grace vast enough to bring every lost thing home.

Why "Free Will" Can't Justify Eternal Conscious Torment

For centuries, the Augustinian-Calvinist interpretation of hell, known as Eternal Conscious Torment, has been defended on the grounds of free will. The popular argument goes something like this: "God doesn't send people to hell; they choose it by rejecting Him."

But is this really a choice? Or is it actually the worst form of coercion?

If free will is exercised under the threat of unending torment, then it is not free at all. A choice made under existential fear is a forced choice, no different from someone pressing a gun to your head and ordering you to your knees—or an abuser telling their captive, "If you don't love me, I'll burn you—but it's your choice."

Is God Like a Father Warning His Child of the Danger on the Highway?

I have heard others object, saying we're like toddlers playing on a busy highway, and our Father warns us not to run into traffic because we'll get hit. According to this scenario, God warns us, but leaves the decision to us—free will.

But let's press into that fable a little further: What kind of parent lets toddlers play next to a highway in the first place? Any decent, loving parent would build a fence, lock the doors, hold their child's hand, or remove the danger entirely—not step back, warn them once, and then say, "If you get hit, that's on you!"

If God is truly loving and all-powerful, then placing "spiritually helpless children" near a deadly, infinite consequence—and then holding them responsible for not avoiding it—isn't justice. It's negligence at best, cruelty at worst.

Millions die without ever reading the Bible, understanding the Gospel, or even hearing the name Jesus in any meaningful way. Are they still toddlers playing on highways? And if so, who put them there?

What loving parent would throw their child into a fire pit or torture them endlessly for failing a theology test? If you, as an imperfect human, wouldn't even consider doing such a thing—how much more can you trust that your perfect, loving Father would never do it either.

The False Choice: Love or Infinite Suffering

Imagine a person being forced to sign a contract with a knife to their throat. Can we honestly say they made a "free" choice? No, they made a choice to avoid suffering. Love has nothing to do with it. That's exactly what hellfire theology does—it places a gun to the soul and calls it "free will."

If rejecting God means unending torment, then there is no real alternative—only forced submission. It makes no actual sense to say that God lets people destroy themselves out of respect for their free will. If God truly loves us, He wouldn't just watch us destroy ourselves forever in the name of "free will." Just like a good parent wouldn't let their hurting child walk into fire without stopping her, real love doesn't abandon—it rescues.

Love me, or else...

Or worse, imagine a parent saying to their child, "Love me, or I'll make sure you fall into a pit of fire where you will scream in agony forever." Would we call that parent loving? Would we say the child has genuine free will? Of course not. Because love, by definition, must be freely and unconditionally given—not extorted through terror!

Yet, fundamentalist theology tells us that God, the supposed source of perfect love, presents humanity with the very same ultimatum: "Worship me, or I'll burn you forever!" The mere fact that rejecting God comes with an infinite penalty makes the choice fundamentally illegitimate.

No religious faith that relies on fear of unending punishment can be called just or loving. A choice made under the threat of permanent suffering is not a choice—it's coercion.

Even in the Torah, Punishment Was Never Without End

Even in the Old Testament's "legalistic" Law, the harshest punishment prescribed for severe sins was the death penalty—not perpetual torture. Those who committed grievous crimes were executed, but their punishment was not torturous, nor did it extend beyond this life. It was only a "game over" in this world, not an everlasting torment in the next.

If torment were truly just, wouldn't God have established it in the Torah? Instead, we find a legal system that is remarkably restrained—one that rarely carried out executions at all and insisted on proportional, limited punishments shaped by mercy and restraint. Justice in the Torah is measured, bounded, and humane. Even when execution was prescribed, it was to be swift, not prolonged torment like that practiced by pagan nations. And nowhere in the Law of Moses is there any threat of endless suffering in the afterlife.

Moreover, history shows us that many individuals who committed grievous sins deserving of death—like Moses (who murdered an Egyptian), King David (who arranged a murder), and Paul the Apostle (who persecuted Christians)—all found redemption and are now seen as saints in heaven. And if God's justice graciously allowed for redemption even after severe sins, why would He suddenly become more punitive and unforgiving in the afterlife?

Human free will—our stupidity and stubbornness—is not an excuse to condemn us to eternal torment, but rather a reason to transform us.

Fear-Based Love Is Not Love At All

The Bible repeatedly tells us that *"perfect love casts out fear"* (1 John 4:18). Yet, eternal conscious torment depends and thrives on fear. The entire premise of hellfire theology is rooted in existential terror, not love.

What kind of love demands threats of perpetual torture? If God truly desires a loving relationship with us, why would He construct a system where fear is the primary motivator? An affection given under the threat of hellfire is not love at all—it's survival at best.

Free will without true alternatives is meaningless.

How Free Is Our Mind, Anyway?

For God's judgment to be completely just, our minds would have to be totally and genuinely free—unbiased, unclouded, unaffected by anything or anyone. But that is impossible for us. We are shaped by every experience, every influence, every wound, every fear, every voice that has ever spoken into our lives—even demonic ones. Human beings cannot achieve perfect objectivity or perfect clarity. Only God can.

We live in an era where ideas are traded like currency—endless controversial paragraphs scrolling through social media feeds and podcasts. Culture encourages us to "think out loud," to share reactions freely and boldly, to broadcast interpretations and flood the world with personal and collective opinions. Yet how many of these thoughts and feelings truly belong to us? Psychologist Jordan Peterson often cites psychiatrist Carl Jung's observation: "People don't have ideas—ideas have people." According to Peterson, 95% of what we think and say doesn't originate from our true selves. Most of what runs through our minds comes from thought and emotional patterns implanted from the outside. It's the voice of the world—not our own. When we think, feel, or say "we," it's often someone else's voice speaking through us:

> Most of what you think and most of what you say are the opinions of other people. There are things you've read and things people have told you. That's a benefit in some ways because you get all those thoughts that other people have spent a long time formulating, but it's a disadvantage in that it's not exactly you.[113]
>
> (Jordan Peterson)

If human judgment is this fragile—shaped by wounds we didn't choose, fears we never asked for, malevolent spiritual forces we cannot control, cultures we didn't design, ideas that often "have us" more than we have them—then for God to punish anyone with infinite torment would be monstrously unjust. How could a perfectly good God condemn people forever for a will—thoughts and choices—that was never fully their own? For reactions formed by trauma? For beliefs shaped by upbringing,

genetics, personality, pressures, or the thousand invisible influences that make us who we are? If our minds are not free in the fullest sense, then no verdict of infinite punishment could ever be fair. Everlasting hellfire would require perfect clarity, perfect freedom, perfect objectivity—and we do not possess these. Only God does.

Therefore, if God is truly just, He cannot hold finite, conditioned creatures eternally accountable for decisions made with limited knowledge, limited understanding, limited freedom, and limited agency. The logic is inescapable: a God of perfect justice could not—would not—burn confused, wounded, influence-shaped humans forever.

Eternal Conscious Torment Diminishes the Gospel

If God is truly love, if He is truly merciful and full of grace, then His actions should reflect a love greater than human love—not less.

A truly loving God would:

- Offer endless opportunities for reconciliation (Matthew 18:21–22), even in the age-to-come.
- Bring healing, not inflict endless pain (Luke 5:31–32).
- Aim at the restoration of people and the world—not their destruction (2 Corinthians 5:18-19).
- Desire genuine love, not forced compliance (Romans 8:38–39).
- Never create a religious system based on terror, coercion, and perpetual suffering (Lamentations 3:31-32).

> Love is not something you can force. It must be freely given.[114]
>
> C. S. Lewis

Telling someone they will burn in hell unless they believe X is the very definition of coercion—and coercion stands in direct opposition to love, because love cannot be forced. For that reason, any "gospel" that adds a term or condition to God's forgiveness is not the gospel at all. Anything that sounds like, *"God has forgiven you in Christ, **but only if**..."* or *"You are forgiven **if**..."* is a lie.

The gospel is this: through Christ, God has "taken away the sin of the world" (John 1:29). No ifs. No buts. Just a period.

> *He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.*
>
> (1 John 2:2)

> *God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation: that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting people's sins against them. And he has committed to us the message of reconciliation.*
>
> (2 Corinthians 5:18-19)

Conclusion

If Christianity is to reflect the God of love, then it must abandon the abusive framework of the Augustinian-Calvinist hellfire and embrace the true God of Israel as portrayed by Jesus's transformative power of grace.

God will force no one into submission. He is both wise enough and loving enough that, ultimately, every person will come to that conclusion freely. Right now, we see only a tiny percentage of the full picture. But when the whole truth is finally revealed, no knee will remain unbowed.

Jesus will ultimately gather every soul—no matter how far we've veered off course, no matter how often we've tumbled into ravines of stubbornness, fear, or pain. No matter how prodigal we have become. Through Christ, God will find us, bandage our

wounds, and guide us back onto the path, even if it means walking with us through seasons of deep regret, "gnashing of teeth," and long, dark nights of resistance. Some will fight against the rescue, clinging to their bitterness or confusion. But in the end, no heart will withstand the warmth and relentless virtue of perfect love forever.

When all the illusions melt away, once every trauma is healed, every soul will awaken to the breathtaking summit of truth: Jesus Christ is the unwavering love of God reaching out to find us. No fall is ever too deep. No detour is ever beyond His reach. In the end, and only God knows how, all will find themselves—sometimes battered, always beloved—safely gathered into His embrace.

If your theology portrays God as less loving or caring than the parent you aspire to be, it's time to rethink that theology.

He Truly Sees Us—Understanding Is Love

My Jewish mother refuses to accept Jesus—not out of rebellion or hardness of heart, but because the "Jesus" presented to her family was clothed in antisemitism and hatred. To her, to her parents, and to her relatives, this so-called Messiah was inseparable from those who claimed His name while persecuting Jews: crusaders, inquisitors, pogroms, blood libels, and ultimately the Nazis.

Before moving to Israel, she grew up in Eastern Europe and endured intense antisemitism from the surrounding Christians, who made sure she knew she was being mocked and bullied solely because she was Jewish.

And if that wasn't enough, when she later met Messianic believers in Israel, they told her that the same god in whose name her family had been persecuted—the one she was supposed to trust—was now also cruelly burning them in hellfire, just like Hitler did to them, only this time for good.

Does God Ignore Christian Antisemitism?

When public figures like Candace Owens spread antisemitism day after day—doing so beneath a visible cross and while calling herself Christian—what do you think Jewish people conclude about Christians? About Christ Himself? The message they receive is not love, mercy, or truth, but hostility baptized in religious symbols. And once again, the name of Jesus is dragged through the mud by those who claim to speak for Him.

And now ask yourself—is God really so narrow-minded, so limited in His understanding, empathy, and love, that He would refuse to welcome Jews like my mother into His kingdom simply because the only Jesus they ever met was a distorted, hateful counterfeit?

What kind of justice is that, and what sort of ruthless judge do we imagine Him to be? Where are the mercy, the understanding, and the grace that evangelists so often emphasize? Are they merely concepts in theory or just words in worship songs?

The notion that a God of infinite wisdom, justice, love, power, and understanding would fail to save most of humanity—and instead condemn creatures of such limited rationality and overwhelming emotion to eternal conscious torment—is not just troubling; it is incoherent. To suggest that God would allow people to damn themselves because of misunderstanding, delusion, trauma, pain, fear, or anger—conditions bound up with the very way they were created—portrays Him as distant, indifferent, and blind to the human condition.

Such a god does not truly see us. He does not understand us. And he bears little resemblance to the God revealed in Jesus.

Does God Ignore Christian Bigotry and Sectarianism?

What the Jewish people experienced isn't an isolated case.

The leadership of the British Empire was almost exclusively Christian, and behind the scenes, Christianity played a significant role in shaping the empire and its vision. India was under British occupation for nearly two centuries—and while I don't believe colonial rule is in itself evil, the British Empire was often oppressive, violent, and merciless in its treatment of native populations.

Now ask yourself: what impression has that left in the minds of the one billion Hindus for the past 80 years about what Christianity stands for? When the "Christian nation" ruled with injustice, how would the average Indian raised in Hinduism come to view the Christian God? Likely not as a God of mercy, compassion, and love. Would they then want to follow a Western religion? I very much doubt it.

Now imagine a 15-year-old Hindu girl in the 1800s who dies "without Christ," having never truly encountered Jesus apart from a distorted version associated with the oppression she and her family endured.

Would a just and loving God disregard her entire life's context and cast such a soul into eternal conscious torment simply for not believing correctly?

If so, then God is not a righteous judge—because a good Judge always seeks understanding and considers context. He weighs motive, background, trauma, and exposure. He understands how culture shapes belief, how history distorts truth, and how human hearts are formed.

To ignore all that would be to render judgment without mercy, justice without wisdom—something no good judge ever does.

And God is not just a good judge—He is the perfect and most merciful judge:

> *Therefore the Lord waits to be gracious to you; therefore he will rise up to show mercy to you. For the Lord is a God of justice; blessed are all those who wait for him.*
>
> (Isaiah 30:18)

Who Are They Truly Rejecting?

We are all shaped by extremely limited knowledge, flawed understanding, emotional wounds, cultural conditioning, religious distortion, and environmental influence. A child born in North Korea or a teen raised in a spiritually abusive Christian household aren't necessarily rejecting God—they're rejecting what they've been told He is. They may be rejecting a god of terror, control, tribalism, hypocrisy, or injustice. But the true and living God—the Father revealed in Jesus—is often hidden from them. So, is it really rejection if they've never truly encountered Him, understood Him, grasped His message, or known Him? Remember, the very reason Jesus asked the Father to forgive His enemies was because *"they know not what they do"* (Luke 23:34).

Human consciousness is limited, conditioned, shaped, and often distorted—and it's in that very gap where the grace of God is needed and where it appears, not to condemn, but to forgive.

We are all still in the fog, still sorting through shadows, lies, traumas, and half-truths. Many Christians project a smug sense of certainty, as if they alone—unlike the other 48,999 views—have finally "figured it all out." But once pressed, even the most respected theologians, priests, rabbis, and mystics have admitted to me in countless theological discussions that their understanding is incomplete on so many topics.

Even the apostle Paul—who experienced visions and revelations—said, *"Now we see through a glass, dimly… now I know in part"* (1 Corinthians 13:12). If that was true for Paul, how much more so for the rest of us?

And if salvation is to come to the knowledge of Him, then that knowledge—by Paul's own admission—is still partial, indirect, and incomplete: seen "through a glass," and only "dimly." Thus, it could be argued that rejection based on a partial or distorted understanding isn't rebellion—it's confusion. And God understands it.

I believe this logic applies both to those who pervert His name and image and those who "willfully" reject Him.

I also think that's why Scripture prophesies that *"every knee will bow… every tongue will confess"* (Philippians 2:10–11). Not because they are forced to, but because when they finally understand, when the veil is lifted and the truth of God's goodness is fully revealed, awe and surrender will be the only natural response. Every knee will bow.

When the blinders are gone, when the distortions are burned away by perfect love, then—and only then—will the human soul truly choose. And when it sees God for who He truly is, it will not walk away.

This is why all rejection of God must be temporary. This is why Hell—however one defines it—must also be temporary. Because the rejection is not of God Himself, but of a false image—a distortion. God's plan is not to punish the confused, the brainwashed by the devil, the indoctrinated by sin, but to enlighten them. And once they are enlightened—truly, fully, gloriously—they will fall to their knees, not in shame or fear, but in praise.

Every knee will bow when every mind truly understands.

God Understands Evil—and the Way It Shapes Us

No child is born a hater; no baby longs to murder. It is only through trauma and indoctrination in hatred that innocent hearts are twisted into instruments of violence.

Boy Named Ahmed—An Illustration

From the moment Ahmed was born, his world was filled with the passionate voices of the muezzins echoing from loudspeakers. Before he could walk the streets of Gaza, his ears had already absorbed words heavy with meaning: Shahid, Jihad, evil Zionists, martyrdom, and being told Allah is the God of revenge.

At three years old, Ahmed was already chanting hateful phrases he didn't understand but was praised for saying. His uncle placed a toy gun in his hand and told him he was Allah's lion against the Jews. "Allah will reward you. One day, you will bring honor to your family," he said.

His picture books weren't like those of Western children. They were filled with tales of young boys who died fighting the so-called "enemy"—Jews portrayed not as individuals, but as one cursed people, dehumanized and imagined with horns. In one story, a Jewish man betrayed the Prophet and was justly punished. In another, a teenager's soul was lifted to paradise because he threw a stone at a Jew and was killed. Ahmed learned that paradise was closest to the brave, and bravery meant resistance, and resistance meant bloodshed.

At five, Ahmed sat cross-legged in the mosque, where the imam taught that to fight the Jews was not only political—it was divine will. The Quran was quoted to him in fragments, always ending in certainty: "You, little one, are chosen by Allah to resist. To fight is to believe."

By age seven, Ahmed was playing "ambush" with his cousins in alleyways, pretending to sneak up on Jews made of cardboard. He practiced knife grips, praised by his older brother, who had photos of armed martyrs on his bedroom wall. At family dinners, the name of a man who had blown himself up at a Jerusalem bakery was mentioned with pride. "He is in paradise," his aunt said, "and now his whole family is honored."

Ahmed didn't learn Hebrew. He didn't meet Jewish children. He didn't hear stories about peace or shared pain. He only knew what he had been indoctrinated with: fear, resistance, and the promise that Allah's favor would rest on him if he fought unto death.

By thirteen, driven by sexual desire and swayed by warped beliefs, he was led to believe he'd be rewarded with 72 virgins if he died committing violence against Jews and Christians.

By fifteen, Ahmed was ready. He no longer smiled when he played. His play had become preparation. When a recruiter from a militant group noticed him at the mosque, he praised his knowledge, his devotion, and his seriousness. "You are pure," the man said. "The world haven't corrupted you. You are now ready. You will make Allah proud!" Ahmed believed him.

The boy who once held a toy gun now held a real one. He no longer saw the world in shades—only in black and white. Us and them. Allah and the cursed Jews. He was told that if he died fighting, he would awaken immediately after in the gardens of paradise, with angels and virgin girls attending to him, and countless heavenly rewards awaiting.

He didn't know the faces of the people he was taught to hate. He never met them. He only knew the story he had been told, over and over again, in the name of Allah. He didn't know better.

This story might sound like fiction to a Western "enlightened" ear, but it's an everyday reality in parts of the Middle East and Africa, where groups such as Hamas, Hezbollah, ISIS, Boko Haram, and Islamic Jihad have often used brainwashed children

as soldiers. Child soldiering is evil at its worst—these kids were never truly given a chance, certainly not like a "pastor's kid" born into a Christian family in Texas.

We Don't Realize What We Don't Know

By definition, the human mind is incapable of grasping all truth, because we are not all-knowing. From birth, we are slowly formed—often unconsciously—by inherited narratives. We do choose freely, but our freedom is never absolute; it is always heavily conditioned.

And this is where I believe God's understanding and mercy come into play. I'm not suggesting young terrorists are in for a garden of roses, but God is not binary. Divine justice isn't a simple equation of bliss versus torment.

Being refined and purified by fire is hardly what one would picture a pleasant experience, but losing reward or facing consequences for wrongdoing doesn't have to mean endless torment in hellfire, as some Christian (and Islamic) traditions claim. Besides, if all will ultimately be resorted, then even the most tragic and violent deaths are not the final word. Every person—whether lost traumatically or naturally—will be resurrected and restored again. In that light, even the worst death becomes a temporary condition, not an everlasting one.

If God's grace isn't bigger than our own, then it's not really divine grace at all.

We Wrestle Not Against Flesh and Blood

There is a dimension of evil that is often ignored—one reflected in struggles like Ahmed's—which I believe God understands far more deeply than we do and fully takes into account. It is not only culture that shapes human beings; spiritual forces are at work as well. And humans, fragile and impressionable as we are, are profoundly susceptible to the influence and damage of these dark powers.

The biblical assertion that *"we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against*

spiritual wickedness in high places" (Ephesians 6:12) highlights that the true nature of our struggles is spiritual rather than human. In this view, dark spiritual forces lurk behind every terrorist and murderer, pulling their strings like marionettes—whether figuratively or perhaps even literally (demonic possession).

These dark spiritual forces influence everything—from global systems down to individual lives. And make no mistake: Satan targets the Church as well. He attacks its beliefs, its doctrines, its Bible translations, its commentaries, and its teachings. How else can we explain the sheer number of conflicting theologies within Christianity, some of which are so distorted and grotesquely unlike the character of God that they could only arise from spiritual deception rather than divine truth?

All of creation is engaged in a spiritual battle and influenced by powerful spiritual forces. Most human beings are not even aware that they are caught up in a cosmic spiritual struggle. But since our struggle is spiritual in essence and universal in scope, then the solution—the salvation and redemption of humanity—must be universal as well. The universality of the conflict demands a universality of redemption, revealing a God whose saving grace is as far-reaching as the battle itself, and not confined by the limits of human awareness, wisdom, or understanding.

And if the primary conflict truly lies between spiritual forces far more powerful than we are, then human beings are not inherently evil, but image-bearers under assault—wounded and influenced by evil. In that case, God's task is not to eliminate sinners, but to eradicate sin itself. The victory over these powers must therefore resemble healing a disease—not killing the patient, but destroying the infection.

If Christ truly accomplished that—atoning for the world so that, in the end, all are saved—then what we see is a complete and unambiguous victory over the powers of evil, leaving them with nothing. It proclaims that God's power and love are so vast that they ultimately redeem not merely a few, but all of creation from the grip of these spiritual adversaries, not leaving even a single one behind.

Conclusion

God's desire that *"all people be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth"* (1 Timothy 2:4) becomes a reflection of His omnipotent capability to defeat the true

enemies—sin and evil—not the individuals influenced by them.

Just as evil and death do not discriminate in their reach, neither does God's salvation. His redemptive love encompasses *all*, ensuring that every soul is eventually restored. This reflects the character of a God who does not abandon His creation to ruin, but rescues it fully—revealing both His supreme authority and power, and His limitless mercy.

When we finally see the story as God sees it—when we understand that evil is deeper than individuals and salvation wider than our categories—we discover that God's answer to darkness is not abandonment or torment, but redemption. His justice does not end in exclusion, but in healing; not in destruction, but in restoration. Sin and evil are confronted, judged, and undone, yet the image-bearer is never discarded. This is the triumph of the gospel: not that a few escape while the rest are lost, but that light overcomes darkness, truth dispels deception, and love outlasts every distortion. A world apart from God fractures and decays, but in Christ, what was lost is being found, what was broken is being restored, and what was condemned is being redeemed. The world is not being thrown away—it is being saved!

Love, Fear, and the Conditional "If" - Why the Gospel Cannot Be Rooted in Terror

In religious discussions, few words carry as much weight as *"if."* At the center of much Christian theology stand conditional statements: "If you do or believe X, then Y will happen." Depending on how that *if* is understood, it can either open the door to a living, transformative relationship with God—or warp faith into a system of anxiety, insecurity, and fear.

The meaning of that "if" depends entirely on the framework through which we read it. And here, two very different theological paradigms emerge:

1. Existential Condition (Fear-Based Theology):

"If you don't intellectually believe the right doctrine or behave a certain way, you'll suffer eternal conscious torment in hell."

This view dominates much of Western theology. It places salvation on a razor's edge, dependent on intellectual or moral precision. In other words, this "if" is a fear-driven faith.

I'm very familiar with the verses that speak about "fear of God" (e.g., Proverbs 9:10; 19:23; Matthew 10:28; 2 Corinthians 7:1). However, the commonly translated biblical term "fear," particularly the Hebrew *yir* and the Greek *phobos*, does not equate to the modern English understanding of terror or fright, but instead primarily signifies awe, reverence, and profound respect toward God. Distinct Hebrew words exist for the feeling of terror or dread, such as *pachad* and *eimah*.

2. Relational/Consequential Condition (Love-Based Theology):

If my son misbehaved and refused to repent, I might deny him ice cream—a temporary consequence that affects our relationship. But I would never even consider taking his life simply because he refused to repent. In other words, the *"if"* shapes the quality of relationship and the consequences within it—not the child's existence or ultimate destiny.

This understanding—deeply rooted in Jewish thought—views God not as a tyrant seeking perpetual punishment, but as a loving Father who disciplines yet never abandons. This is the consistent pattern of God's relationship with Israel throughout the Hebrew Scriptures.

Even at Israel's lowest moments—idolatry, rebellion, exile—God's promise remained unwavering:

> *I will not reject them or abhor them so as to destroy them utterly and break my covenant with them; for I am the Lord their God.*
>
> (Leviticus 26:44–45)

> *This is what the Lord says, he who appoints the sun to shine by day, who decrees the moon and stars to shine by night, who stirs up the sea so that its waves roar—the Lord Almighty is his name: "Only if these decrees vanish from my sight," declares the Lord, "will Israel ever cease being a nation before me."*
>
> (Jeremiah 31:35–36)

If this is God's love toward a rebellious, "stiff-necked" (Exodus 32:9; Deuteronomy 9:6, 13) and chronically unfaithful (Jeremiah 3:20; 32:33) people, does it not apply to us as well?

These verses echo a central biblical truth: God corrects, but He does not cast off forever. His judgments are restorative, not annihilating. He doesn't engage in cancel culture because His steadfast love remains constant, even when His people fall short.

The God who refused to forsake Israel in her rebellion will not forsake us either. His love for His creation endures even when ours does not, and His faithfulness remains even when ours falters.

The gospel is not a fragile contract that collapses at the first sign of human weakness. It is a relationship—covenantal, parental, rooted in fidelity rather than fear. God disciplines to heal, not to destroy; to guide, not to damn.

As I was writing these very lines, I received a short email, and due to its ironic timing, I decided to take it as a "divine sign" and include it in the book:

> Hi. Do you have a link or a book that talks about headcovering? I come from a Mennonite community, and goodness, they go so far that, if I don't have a headband, I'll be lost forever. That 1 Corinthians 11,13, 15 is a straight command from God.
> Thank you for all your work and Shalom.

You see, if our motivation comes from fear instead of love, insecurity and anxiety will slowly creep into our souls, because we can never truly be certain that God won't punish us forever for not believing the right thing or behaving the right way.

When "If" Becomes a Threat Instead of an Invitation

If unending torture is held out as a conditional threat—based on performance or possessing the "right" faith—then the gospel is reduced to a transaction. Fear becomes the engine. Obedience is no longer born of love, but of terror. "I'll believe—just promise You won't torture me forever."

Unless one is Hannibal Lecter or the bogeyman, by any honest standard of logic, that is not love. It is coercion.

This is why the apostle John wrote:

> *There is no fear in love. But perfect love casts out fear, because fear has to do with punishment.*
>
> (1 John 4:18)

A relationship with God built on fear cannot be intimate. You cannot draw near to someone you're afraid might destroy you for one reason or another. The soul becomes obsessed with getting the formula right—never resting, never sure, never free.

In fact, research shows that Scrupulosity and OCD are disproportionately high among fundamentalist Christians. A 2019 study, for example, found that the severity of OCD symptoms linked to scrupulosity differed between religious groups, with conservative Catholics and Protestants reporting the highest levels.[115]

If you're part of this group, please let me encourage you: No matter how far you fall, you cannot outpace the love of God. No matter how badly you stumble, you can never outdo God in love or forgiveness. You will never be better at sinning than He is at redeeming.

If God is truly infinite and never changes, so are His mercy and grace everlasting. Thus, by definition, our capacity to sin can never exceed His power to redeem. To believe otherwise is to imagine that human failure can outmatch divine compassion. But that would make our sin stronger than God's grace—an impossibility. No matter the depth of your stumbling, His forgiveness will always reach deeper still.

The "if" of Divine Love

A faith rooted in love looks very different from one rooted in fear. Love leads to intimacy, joy, and a life of gratitude. Fear leads to anxiety, legalism, and performance-driven spirituality. When we fear God's rejection, we become actors on a stage, hoping our performance will earn divine applause. But when we trust God's acceptance, we become children in the arms of a Father—free to grow, learn, stumble, and rise again.

God's "if" isn't about whether you'll be endlessly forgiven or endlessly tormented—but about the consequences and rewards that flow from how you live this life.

Scripture is full of consequences—not eternal condemnation, but consequences nonetheless. Paul says:

> *Each one's work will become manifest... and the fire will test what sort of work each one has done.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 3:13)

> *We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ... to receive what is due for what he has done in the body.*
>
> (2 Corinthians 5:10)

In this light, the "if" is no longer existential—it mainly shapes the status and rewards in the age to come. The judgment is not about sadistic wrath or punishment for its own sake, but refinement and purification. Just as a loving parent might discipline a child without ever withdrawing love or identity, so too God punishes for the sake of correction.

The outcome? Not annihilation. Not everlasting hellfire. But loss—or gain—of reward, honor, and role in God's coming Kingdom. Just like a good parent disciplines but never disowns, God corrects without rejecting (Hebrews 12:6).

This distinction is crucial. If the "if" relates to our identity, inclusion, or immortality itself, then we live in constant dread. But if it relates to our calling, responsibility, and future reward, then it becomes a path to growth.

That's the Gospel. Not "God threatened us into heaven," but "God loved us into transformation."

God still disciplines. There are still stakes. But God's corrections are born of love, not hate. Like a physician cutting out disease—not to punish, but to heal. Like a fire that refines gold—not to destroy, but to purify.

Reclaiming the "If" as a Blessing

When we see the "if" in the right light, it turns into a medal, a trophy, a bokeh, a promise—not an existential threat. It calls us not to fear never-ending damnation, but to live with purpose. To win heavenly rewards. To reflect God. To steward our gifts. To store up treasures in heaven. To become Christlike. Every act of love, every sacrifice, every act of mercy—none of it is forgotten.

In this light, the "if" becomes a potential blessing, not a burden and threat. It challenges us, but never threatens what Christ did for us. It corrects us, but never condemns us. It sharpens our purpose without undermining our identity.

Any discipline that proceeds from a loving source must serve a loving purpose. By simple logic, that purpose can only be restorative. God's judgment, then, is not vindictive fury but the fierce fire of His love—burning away what destroys, cleansing what corrupts, purging what enslaves.

Judgement that comes to an end implies that something has been achieved: purification, transformation, repentance. And if repentance is reached, then restoration necessarily follows.

Conclusion

Let us, then, walk not in existential fear, but in awe of the grace that welcomes us. Let us believe not for the sake of escaping, but to reflect the One who saves us in every way. For perfect love drives out fear—and draws us deeper into the joy of the Father's heart.

Let us reject the existential dread masquerading as theology, and embrace the love that drives out fear. Let us obey not because we are terrified, but because we are loved. Let us remember: We are not being threatened into faith. We are being invited into glory.

The retributive vision of eternal conscious torment portrays God as fragile, wounded, capricious, and vindictive—seeking to pacify Himself through the suffering of others. It imagines an offended ruler who lashes out, rather than a healer who restores. But if God truly is love, then His response must be compassion: to heal, not to harm; to restore, not to destroy. Eternal conscious torment is irreconcilable with a God who is love—good, perfect, self-sufficient, and complete in Himself.

God Is Not a Nazi

I'm often amazed at how some Christians use Hitler as the ultimate example of evil—and rightly so, given that he burned countless people alive—yet simultaneously attribute to God the very same actions and character they condemn in Hitler:

> If only born-again Christians go to heaven, then the piles of suitcases and bags of human hair displayed at the Holocaust Museum represent thousands upon thousands of men, women, and children suffering eternal agony at the hands of an angry God. [116]
>
> (Rachel Held Evans)

The logic used to defend eternal conscious torment for someone like Hitler does not stop with him. It inevitably extends to the six million Jewish men, women, and children he murdered—most of whom were not believers in Jesus—and condemns them to the very same fate. Under this framework, victims and perpetrators alike, the murdered and the Nazi murderers, end up suffering identical punishment: endless torment.

That conclusion alone exposes the moral bankruptcy of the system

Think about how absurd this is: under the ECT view, some of the kindest people who ever lived would endure endless torment just like the most monstrous figures in history. And that, we are told, is God's justice?

Preaching God's Name in Vain

> Someone has said that no theology is worth believing that cannot be preached standing in front of the gates of Auschwitz. I, for one, could not stand at those gates and preach a version of God's sovereignty that makes the extermination of six million Jews, including many children, a part of the will and plan of God such that God foreordained and rendered it certain.[117]
>
> (Roger Olson, PhD)

If a "gospel" becomes morally grotesque and collapses into incoherence in the face of atrocities like the Holocaust, then it is not the *"good news of great joy for all people"* (Luke 2:10). It is a theological system in desperate need of reexamination.

A true gospel—if it is truly good—must be able to speak meaningfully into humanity's darkest hours, offering a hope deeper than despair and a compassion strong enough to touch the wounds of history. If our theology becomes useless, or even cruel, when placed beside the worst horrors humanity has endured, then perhaps the problem is not with God—but with the way we have come to understand Him.

Hitler's Final Moments

It's one thing for people to have never heard of Jesus or to have only encountered a distorted image of Him, but what about those who are truly evil? What name comes to mind when you think of someone you could never imagine in heaven? For me, growing up as a descendant of Holocaust survivors, that name was Hitler—the monstrous German dictator responsible for millions of deaths, including members of my own Jewish family. Adolf Hitler, who ended his life by gunshot on April 30, 1945,

in his Führerbunker in Berlin, embodied for many the very definition of irredeemable evil.

But there's an overlooked part of Hitler's story that turns our assumptions on their head.

During Hitler's meteoric rise to power, a German theologian named Dietrich Bonhoeffer became one of his fiercest critics—eventually participating in a plot to overthrow the Nazi regime. For this, Bonhoeffer was arrested, imprisoned, and finally executed in April 1945, just days before Germany's defeat. His letters and papers from prison, published posthumously, remain one of the most profound testimonies to Christian conviction under tyranny.

According to a report online, a letter was found hidden deep within the ruins of Hitler's bunker. This letter, allegedly written shortly before his suicide, revealed something shocking: Hitler had been haunted by Bonhoeffer's teachings in the final months of the war. The words he had once dismissed as weakness now gnawed at him. His letter records overwhelming remorse for his crimes, particularly against the Jewish people. It describes a desperate cry for God's mercy—a confession, a plea.

The Soviet propaganda machine, it is said, suppressed the letter. Allowing Hitler even the possibility of redemption would have undermined the black-and-white narrative. Hitler, in their view, could only be seen as monstrous and damned—not complex, not broken, not redeemable.

And yet, this possibility forces us to ask a deeper question:

What if he did repent? What if, in the last moments of his life, Adolf Hitler sincerely sought forgiveness from Christ?

Many Christians—especially within "born again" and Calvinist traditions—see no serious theological problem with granting salvation to someone evil—even Hitler—provided he repented moments before death, much like the thief crucified beside Jesus. In this framework, a sincere last-second prayer or "inviting Jesus into one's heart" is enough to secure salvation, regardless of a lifetime of atrocities.

The irony is chilling. Under this logic, the six million Jews Hitler murdered would suffer eternal conscious torment, while Hitler himself would walk free.

Think about that for a moment.

According to this belief, the murderer is embraced while the murdered are forever tortured.

The abuser finds peace while those he abused find everlasting agony.

The "born again" oppressor is granted heaven, while his victims suffer permanent torment in hellfire.

But strangely, these same Christians erupt into spiritual outrage at even the possibility that repentance could be accepted and salvation granted if it occurred five seconds *after* death—when a soul finally sees undiluted reality face-to-face. In that case, they declare, it is "too late"—grace is cut off, God becomes a cosmic executioner, and the door to heaven is slammed forever.

How strange—how different the outcome, all because of ten seconds. Had Hitler whispered a prayer for mercy five seconds before death, many would eagerly welcome him into heaven. But had that same repentance occurred five seconds after his final breath—after facing pure truth—most would declare it impossible. As if the ticking of a clock, not the sincerity of the heart, determines the fate of an eternal soul. How fragile, how arbitrary, Western theology can be.

If this strikes you as not just logically contradictory but also morally disturbing, you're definitely not alone.

The theology that flows from Augustine and Calvin, with its binary afterlife of instant heaven or endless hell, demands such contradictions. It forces you to celebrate Hitler's "salvation" (if he repented) while condemning Anne Frank to endless burning—because inherited belief systems, not moral sanity, is running the show.

And yet, Scripture reveals a better, more coherent story—a story of justice that restores, not simply punishes; of mercy that outlasts death; of love that never fails (1 Corinthians 13:8).

The tale of Hitler's letter circulates on the internet, yet it has never been definitively verified. In any case, whether this letter is real or not is ultimately beside the point. The story is a thought exercise—an exploration of how deeply the Gospel challenges our assumptions about justice, mercy, and human worth.

"Where Sin Increased, Grace Increased All the More" (Romans 5:20)

Salvation is not an on–off switch. It is not a mechanical transaction triggered by the correct words spoken at the last second of life. And though it is not easy for me to say

this as a Jew, I believe God's mercy and compassion are far greater than my own. His love extends even to my greatest enemies.

I would rather see Hitler—and any other deeply wicked person—come to the knowledge of the truth, repent, bow the knee, and confess Jesus Christ as Lord, than be tortured forever for no redemptive purpose. Endless torment accomplishes nothing. Repentance does.

Yes, even a soul as dark and twisted as Hitler's could, through a hell-like process of judgment and purification, truly repent and ultimately be restored. That does not minimize evil; it declares the final victory of God over it.

But not cheaply. Not instantly. And certainly not without facing the full weight and horror of what he did. Restoration is never about sweeping evil under the rug. It's about confronting it, being broken by it, and allowing grace—slow, costly, searing grace—to heal what seems beyond repair.

People like Hitler would first have to face hell—the full, unfiltered reality of the harm and suffering they inflicted on others. What that hell looks like, I do not pretend to know. But I imagine it as an encounter with truth so unbearable it can no longer be evaded: seeing their deeds as they truly were, feeling them not abstractly but inwardly, bearing their weight in the depths of the soul until denial collapses and repentance becomes unavoidable.

Such repentance would not erase what was done. It would transform the one who did it. They would not emerge honored or exalted. If anything, they would be "least in the kingdom." Their honor would be stripped away, their rewards forfeited, their former power undone—exchanged for humility, service, and a long apprenticeship in love.

But restoration does not mean denial. Restoration means healing after justice has been satisfied—not human revenge, but God's perfect justice that disciplines to restore, not destroy.

In the end, if Hitler is in heaven, it will not be because his crimes were forgotten. Yesterday was Israel's Holocaust Remembrance Day, and like every year, a nationwide loud siren screamed for two minutes while everyone stood still. We still remember. We still grieve. But no amount of vengeance can bring back our loved ones. And it's okay, because I know they, too, will see God, will meet Jesus, and will come to accept Him. If they too are to be saved, then all the harm done to them by evil Hitlers was only temporary.

In the end, if Hitler is in heaven, it will be because God's mercy is wider than we dared imagine—and because God's justice is not a mirror of human wrathful vengeance, but a fire that purifies even the worst among us. A fire that burns away the impure and forges what's left into precious gold.

If that scandalizes you, remember: It is not Hitler who defines the limits of God's grace. It is Jesus—the One who said, *"Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do."* (Luke 23:34)

And if He could pray that prayer for the very men nailing Him to the cross, then maybe the scandal of grace is exactly what we need to be confronted with—and transformed by.

Then What's the Point in Evangelizing?

An objection frequently raised is, "If everyone will eventually be redeemed, then why evangelize?"

During an Iranian missile attack in Israel in June 2025, the siren blared and chaos broke out. Everyone rushed for cover, and those on the street dashed into the nearest bomb shelter across from us, desperate to be safe. In the middle of it all, one family grew visibly upset, insisting that only residents from nearby buildings should be let in. They demanded the doors be locked to keep “outsiders” away.

Later, I sat with one of them, who was still visibly upset that "strangers" had sought safety in “their” shelter. I told him I understood the practical limits—sometimes a shelter can be overcrowded and unsafe for all. But in this case, there was still enough space. I sensed this was not a practical concern, but something deeper—an emotional wall. So I asked him, “Don’t you care about these people? What if you closed the door, and they died from the missile strike—how would you feel?” He answered, almost numbly, “I don’t feel anything anymore.” I gently pressed, “Why? Did something happen to you in the past?” His eyes instantly filled with tears as he confessed, “I did something terrible when I was young and stupid. Since then, I don’t care because I don’t feel anything anymore.”

Now, to those who ask why the gospel should be preached at all if every knee will eventually bow: does the gospel still matter to someone like him? Can the Good News reach a person who feels shattered—hollow, numb, almost dead inside? Can hearing that he is *already* forgiven in Christ (no *ifs*) begin to heal a wounded soul? Can the gospel breathe life into a heart that feels like a corpse—or is all it offers merely a ticket to heaven after death?

And what about the Jewish mothers whose children were kidnapped by Hamas on October 7, 2023, and murdered in Gaza? Or the Palestinian mothers who lost their babies? Can the gospel—the announcement that death will not have the final word, that all will be raised and live again—restore even a measure of hope to their broken hearts? Does the promise of reunion, of seeing their loved ones again, matter? Does it heal? Does it sustain?

When the Very Question Exposes the Misunderstanding

Is God really so narrow and selective that the gospel applies only to a small, enlightened few, as many believe? Or is the good news actually *good news for all,* especially for the grieving, the traumatized, the lost, the searching, and the broken?

But honestly, the very fact that we find ourselves wrestling with this objection reveals just how far the Western gospel has drifted from its original message in the first century. The questions we ask today expose a disconnect between the life-giving, *present-tense* gospel proclaimed by Jesus and His apostles, and the reduced version many have inherited—a somewhat gnostic gospel preoccupied with the afterlife, rather than transformation here and now.

The point of sharing the gospel is not to "save" people from falling into a fire pit in the afterlife. The gospel is meant to rescue people from the hell they're living in right now. It's about offering genuine hope to the hurting and direction to the lost. It's about awakening compassion where numbness has taken over, bringing new life where the soul has gone cold. The gospel isn't just a promise for the future—it's an invitation to be made whole now, to breathe again, to live as we were created to live.

That's why we share it—even if God's mercy will reach everyone in the end: Because people need to be saved from the hell they already live in, today.

So why should you evangelize?

You evangelize because you want people to truly live and live abundantly.

You evangelize because healed hearts heal others.

You evangelize because forgiven people forgive.

You evangelize because the Prince of Peace has come into the world—and through Him peace can be made even with enemies.

You evangelize because to know Jesus is to overflow with the life He gives—a life that cannot help but spill outward.

You evangelize because you love, and love cannot sit still.

Evangelism is not recruitment into a cosmic survival bunker. It's an invitation into the healing flood of God's restoration.

We evangelize because we have tasted something beautiful—and beauty demands to be shared.

We evangelize because we have seen the face of love—and love demands to be reflected.

We evangelize because the Kingdom of God is not just something we wait for—it is something we build, one act of kindness, one word of truth, one spark of mercy at a time.

Evangelizing for a Better Society

The beauty of the gospel is that it was never meant to stop at the level of private belief or individual spirituality. From the beginning, its horizon has been public, communal, and even cosmic. Jesus spoke of a kingdom—not merely a personal rescue plan—and Acts tells us that this message was meant to spread outward, reshaping lives, communities, and nations (e.g., Matthew 28:19–20, Mark 16:15, Acts 1:8). Wherever the gospel has taken root in its fullness, it has carried with it a vision of human dignity, moral responsibility, justice tempered by mercy, and the worth of every person made in the image of God.

Now consider the world beyond the West. Have you ever been to Syria, Afghanistan, North Korea, Sudan, Iran, Gaza, or Yemen? These are places scarred by tyranny, endless cycles of violence, suppression of conscience, and the crushing of the weak. This is not a matter of cultural superiority, but of moral contrast. Societies shaped by Judeo-Christian values—however imperfectly—have tended to cultivate ideas that many now take for granted: the sanctity of human life, limits on state power, care for

the poor, the dignity of women and children, and the idea that rulers themselves are accountable to a higher moral law.

The gospel challenges injustice not only in hearts but in systems. It confronts cruelty, tribalism, and oppression wherever they appear. It insists that power exists to serve, not to dominate; that truth matters; that love of neighbor is not optional; and that the strong are responsible for the weak. These ideas did not arise naturally in human history—they were seeded, slowly and often painfully, by a worldview rooted in the Hebrew Scriptures and embodied in the life of Jesus.

To say that the gospel is only about personal salvation is to shrink it far below its biblical scope. It is not merely about where an individual goes after death; it is about what happens to the world while we are alive. It is a message meant to humanize societies, restrain evil, inspire compassion, and cultivate justice. When received rightly, it does not erase cultures, but heals them—calling every nation to become more humane, more just, and more aligned with the goodness for which humanity was created.

The gospel, at its best, is not an escape from the world. It is God's invitation to remake it.

But Wouldn't People "Backslide" Without the Threat of Endless Hellfire?

Discipline, loss of rewards, and correction are still unpleasant, even if the punishment is only temporary. But the idea that Christians would "backslide" into terrible behavior without the looming threat of burning forever not only paints a grim picture of God but is also both logically and morally flawed.

Some would argue that preaching hellfire is necessary to demonstrate God's justice. But in the apostolic era, God's justice was demonstrated in Christ's victory over sin, death, and evil—not in the perpetual torment and suffering of souls. God's justice was about setting things right, healing creation, and *"reconciling the world to Himself"* (2 Corinthians 5:19).

If the only thing preventing someone from committing evil is the fear of eternal conscious torment, then we're not talking about righteousness—we're talking about

restraint. That's not transformation; it's just wickedness kept on a leash. Is that what Christianity is all about?

The God of the Hebrew Scriptures doesn't manipulate with terror—He draws with *chesed* (lovingkindness). Grounding morality in existential fear undermines the very heart of the Gospel. The teachings and life of Jesus embody this: not a religion of fear, but a way of life rooted in mercy, truth, justice, and love.

True faith is not driven by fear but by love, compassion, and a desire to do what is right. A relationship with God grounded in terror does not foster trust, growth, or genuine devotion. Fear may produce temporary compliance, but it cannot produce love—and love is exactly what God asks of us: *"Love the Lord your God… and love your neighbor as yourself"* (Deuteronomy 6:5; Leviticus 19:18; see also Matthew 22:37–39).

Religion Motivated by Fear vs. Faith Inspired by Love

Take my Jewish friends—religious and secular alike—as an example. Many follow a strong moral and Jewish ethical code, often making sacrifices for complete strangers, giving generously, and working toward justice and peace—all without believing in the doctrine of eternal torment in hellfire. Their lives show that living morally doesn't depend on the fear of eternal conscious torment.

If your beliefs require the threat of unending punishment to guide your morals, then it is not love that drives your behavior—it is fear. Again, you are simply a malevolent Christian on a leash.

True faith isn't about avoiding punishment. It's about becoming more like the One who forgives, heals, restores, and loves—even to the end.

As we saw at the beginning of the book, the apostles never evangelized with threats of flames. They preached Jesus—His resurrection, His fulfillment of prophecy, His invitation to repent from idols and receive forgiveness and blessings, and His promise of great rewards and honor in God's restored world for those who are faithful.

Conclusion

Evangelism, then, is not about scaring people into heaven. It is about proclaiming the goodness of God, the beauty of Christ, the power of His resurrection, and the hope of transformation. It is about inviting all people to step into the abundant life God offers here and now—and in the world to come. It's about proclaiming life over death, healing over brokenness, light over darkness. It's about inviting people to live the life they were created for—now and forever.

Hellfire was never the driving force of Apostolic evangelism. Life was. And it still should be today.

A Word on NDEs (Near-Death Experiences)

Healthy theology cannot be built on private visions. It must be grounded in the text—its language, its context, and its coherent witness. My conclusions do not arise from what someone claims to have seen in a vision, during a coma, or after a near-death episode, but from what the biblical authors actually wrote and meant within their Jewish worldview.

The foundation of doctrine is not personal experience. It is Scripture.

The Problem with NDE as Authority

Near-death experiences (NDEs) are often presented as compelling evidence for what awaits us beyond death. But there is a serious problem: they contradict one another.

Some describe a realm where all people appear healed, joyful, and at peace. Others recount scenes of terror, darkness, and torment. They cannot all be correct. When "experiences and "visions" compete with one another, they cancel each other out. They cannot function as final authority.

Scripture, however, does not contradict itself in this way. When Scripture speaks, it stands.

What Science Actually Suggests

Research indicates that in the moments before, during, and immediately after clinical death, the brain undergoes a massive surge of neurotransmitters—dopamine, serotonin, and norepinephrine among them. This chemical cascade, often part of a terminal spike in brain activity, is believed to contribute to intense experiences: feelings of peace, dread, heightened awareness, or vivid imagery.[118, 119]

Researchers also note that the brain may remain active for at least thirty seconds after the cardiovascular system has ceased functioning. In such a state, it is not unreasonable to assume that pre-existing beliefs about the afterlife shape the structure of the experience itself.

In other words, if someone already expects light and angels, or flames and judgment, the mind under extreme neurological stress may supply imagery consistent with those expectations.

This does not mean people are lying. It means human consciousness is complex, especially at the edge of death. But it does mean such experiences are subjective and cannot serve as doctrinal authority.

Experience Is Not Revelation

As a theologian and Bible scholar, I am not interpreting dreams, visions, or subjective encounters. I am interpreting Scripture.

The Bible—not NDEs, not testimonies, not emotional stories—is the standard. Experiences may be meaningful to individuals, but they are not the measuring rod of truth.

Whenever someone shares a vivid dream or vision of the afterlife, I am reminded of Jeremiah's warning:

> "Do not listen to what the prophets are prophesying to you; they fill you with false hopes. They speak visions from their own minds, not from the mouth of the Lord…. I have heard what the prophets say who prophesy lies in my name. They say, 'I had a dream! I had a dream!' How long will this continue in the hearts of these lying prophets, who prophesy the delusions of their own minds?"

So, bottom line, when it comes to doctrine, I believe it's best to stick with Scripture rather than personal experience, including NDEs.

Conclusion

If you aim to educate and warn your child about the dangers of hard drugs, it's logical to do so well in advance rather than during or after they've started using. Similarly, if the concept of Hellfire is as crucial as believed—impacting everyone's eternity—one would expect it to be clearly and prominently communicated from the earliest stages of the biblical text.

However, when we examine the progression of how Hellfire is discussed in biblical texts, there's a notable absence in the places where it might be most expected. This absence raises questions about the clarity and priority given to the concept in the scriptures.

Initially, God warns Adam and Eve only of mortality—no mention of eternal torture of some kind, just a life of toil followed by death. Then, throughout the entire Torah, there is not a single warning of eternal Hellfire.

Concurrently, surrounding pagan cultures have rich mythologies featuring fiery underworlds for the wicked, yet these ideas are not reflected in early Jewish theology or anywhere in the Old Testament.

Life's Purpose Isn't Escapism

The idea sounds audacious, even scandalous. It feels almost unthinkable to imagine offering forgiveness to the very hands that mocked, spat in the face, hammered nails into the flesh, and ultimately crucified Christ.

But what seems offensive and unthinkable to us was not unthinkable to Jesus.

From the cross itself—while still bleeding, still suffocating, still surrounded by hatred—He pleaded:

"Father, forgive them!" (Luke 23:34)

Some might say there's no forgiveness for those who turn away from Christ. But if Christ could ask the Father to forgive those who committed the very act of killing Him, then surely His love atones for every human heart, no matter how resistant or broken.

God's love is not small.

It is not finite or bound by time.

It is not limited by resistance or human rebellion.

His love is boundless, relentless, and eternal—because He is.

The Gospel was never meant to terrify people into belief.

It was never designed to be a cosmic threat hanging over humanity's head.

The Gospel is a proclamation of forgiveness and an invitation—into love, into healing, into transformation, into truth, into life.

It is the announcement that God's goodness is stronger than our darkest failures, that His mercy outlasts our stubbornness, and that His desire and ability to save are far greater than our ability to resist Him.

Hell's "Fire" Meant for Refinement, Cleansing, and Purification

Perhaps the true purpose of what we call "hell"—metaphorically speaking—is, as several early Church Fathers taught, to encounter God's purifying fire: a refining and healing process rather than mere retribution. Figures such as Origen of Alexandria, Gregory of Nyssa, Clement of Alexandria, and later Isaac of Nineveh (the Syrian) spoke of divine judgment not as endless revenge, but as corrective, medicinal, and ultimately restorative—fire that burns away corruption so that what God created good may finally be made whole.

I don't claim to know exactly what that will look like, but I can imagine it might involve feeling, in full awareness, the sorrow and pain we've caused others in our

lifetime. Not as vengeance—but as transformation. Until we fully understand and accept the truth of our wrongs and willingly repent. This process, I believe, is what leads to the day when every knee will bow and every tongue will swear allegiance.

> *God disciplines us for our good, that we may share in His holiness. No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace for those who have been trained by it.*
>
> (Hebrews 12:10–11)

The teachings of the Lord are given so that we might repent now—freely, joyfully, and with open hearts—rather than learning the hard way through painful consequences. Repentance offered today is a gift; delaying it may only mean unnecessary suffering on the path to the same eventual restoration.

Repentance is not merely spoken words or crying eyes—it's a realignment of our will, our values, and our moral behavior with the heart and character of God.

Think of it like this: a loving parent warns their child about the consequences of reckless choices. The wise child listens—and is spared the pain that follows rebellion. But sometimes, despite all the warnings, the child chooses their own path. When the consequences arrive—like a visit from the authorities or imprisonment—they become the teacher. Suffering opens the door to understanding. And from there, repentance flows.

Christ invites us to skip the needless pain. To follow Him *now*. To embrace His wisdom and walk the path of repentance—not as punishment, but as the way to true freedom, healing, and joy.

A Different Gospel?

If today's gospel focuses on escaping endless hellfire torment instead of the early message from the first two centuries about stepping into the life, light, and love of

God through Christ, it raises the question: Who altered the biblical message, and for what reason?

The answer is straightforward: if Satan used Scripture in an attempt to tempt and deceive Jesus—if he dared to twist the Bible against Christ Himself—then we can be certain he employs the very same tactic to mislead the Church.

It only makes sense that one of the most effective ways for Satan to distort the gospel is by using the Bible itself. He convinces well-meaning Christians they are being "biblical"—when in reality, they are cherry-picking verses out of context to support their own agendas and theological biases.

And tragically, this kind of selective misuse of Scripture leads people to believe they are preaching the gospel, when in fact, they are driving others away from it.

If this is true—and given how Satan operates, it likely is—then some of the people most in need of salvation are already inside the church.

They need salvation from a distorted image of God—a frightening, wrathful, and condemning figure created by well-meaning Christians who truly believe they are honoring the Bible. They need saving from anxiety and depression, and a path into life.

Sometimes, the greatest deception isn't outside the church. It's inside—dressed in religious language, backed by isolated verses, and preached with the best of intentions, but far from the heart of Christ.

A Final Word

I wish to leave you with an action point. We must not remain passive and let the gospel be diminished to merely decoding the right theoretical formula to escape a sadistic, neverending torment in a cosmic inferno. Churches arguing the Gospel is all about escaping a realm of eternal cruel, sadistic, torturous punishment shift focus away from the original message of the Gospel, which we ought to uphold. The message of Christ was about embracing God's love, mercy, and grace and paying them forward.

Rather than getting bogged down in theological debates over the afterlife, we should focus on embodying and radiating God's love in a world riddled with brokenness and despair. God's love is not a formula for escaping torture; it's a call to action, inviting us to participate in healing and restoration. The Gospel, at its core, is about transformation—of hearts, lives, and communities—through the love and grace of God, as revealed in our Messiah Yeshua (Hebrew for Jesus, which also means "salvation").

I have a small favor to ask before you close this book (or turn off your e-reader). I've dedicated significant time and effort to creating this book, and I anticipate that some fervent Calvinists may intentionally give my book a low rating (as they sadly do with the complete work, often without even bothering to read the book...). Therefore, if you have found enjoyment and education in the book, please consider expressing your appreciation by sparing a few seconds to rate it on Amazon or Goodreads. If you also have two minutes to spare, leaving a short review would also mean the world to

me as an author! I make it a point to read every review. If you want to go the extra mile and help, then feel free to post about the book on social media or even get a copy or two for friends! Also, please remember to consider the complete book.

Lastly, I invite you to check out my other books.

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4. The complete book provides numerous examples directly from renowned Calvinists.
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